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Harmanpreet, Deepti set up India's big win

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18 held, ₹100 cr. traced in Northeast drug raids

- Central agencies, police target 'narco-hawala' network across region, the Home Ministry says
- Drive results in the freezing of 1,424 accounts, recovery of 500 detonators, cash, and assets
- Money generated flows back to Mizoram border for settlement with Myanmar suppliers, says ED

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In a major crackdown on drug trafficking, enforcement agencies have conducted simultaneous raids at 38 locations across Assam, Mizoram, and Manipur, leading to the arrest of 18 accused persons and the detection of ₹100 crore in "hawala" transactions in connection with an international "narco-hawala" racket.

Congratulating the anti-narcotics team comprising Central agencies and police forces of the three States, Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday said the Narendra Modi government had dealt another "lethal blow" to drugs with "Operation Trident".

"Our agencies launched a barrage of simultaneous crackdowns across 38 locations in Assam, Mizoram, and Manipur on October 23, smashing an international narco-cartel," Mr. Shah said in a post on X.

The operation led by the Narcotics Control Bureau in coordination with the State police and Directorate of Enforcement resulted in the freezing of 1,424 bank accounts, the attachment of assets estimated at ₹17.82 crore, the seizure of 500 detonators, and ₹12 lakh in cash, and the arrest of 18 people, a release by the Union Home Ministry said on Sunday.

The coordinated operation after days of collating confidential intelligence comprehensively covered major urban centres and sensitive border corridors such as Aizawl, Champhai, and Zokhawthar in Mizoram, Churachandpur in Manipur, and the transit corridor in the Cachar region of Assam, the Ministry said.

"The network trafficked narcotics across the borders of India, Myanmar, and Bangladesh through the Death Triangle Corridor. The offensive attests to India's Himalayan resolve to realise the mission of eradicating every drug network by December 31, 2029. India will hammer until the last nail is driven into the coffin of drug cartels," Mr. Shah said.

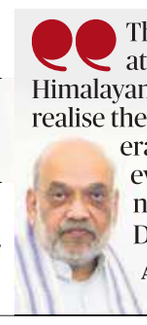
The multi-State operation was the result of sustained intelligence-based investigations conducted by the NCB and other agencies into the cases which uncovered a major international smuggling syndicate led by Myanmar-based kingpin Thangsintuang, alias Chintuang, alias Tluanga, the Home Ministry said. The alleged kingpin, who was arrested from Delhi in May, operated cross-border smuggling of methamphetamine and heroin into India and Bangladesh through the Myanmar-Mizoram-Manipur-Assam-Tripura corridor.

Drug control

Central agencies carried out searches over alleged trafficking of drugs from Myanmar and 'hawala' settlements of proceeds

- Local carriers were hired by Myanmar-based organisers to move consignments
- Payments routed through 'hawala' accounts receiving drug proceeds from across the Northeast
- Bank accounts in Champhai, Aizawl, and Lawngtlai of Mizoram received drug money and settled with suppliers in Myanmar, says the ED

> The offensive attests to India's Himalayan resolve to realise the mission of eradicating every drug network by Dec. 31, 2029
>
> **AMIT SHAH**
> Union Home Minister



Coordinated searches

In a separate press release, the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) said coordinated searches were carried out under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002, in connection with three cases alleging trafficking of heroin, brown sugar, and methamphetamine tablets from Myanmar, and "hawala" settlements of drug proceeds.

The ED's investigation has revealed that the same set of bank accounts in Champhai, Aizawl and Lawngtlai received drug money generated in Manipur, Mizoram, Assam, and Tripura, and settled it with suppliers in Myanmar.

Six arrested on money-laundering charges have been identified Kashyap G. Thakkar, Thangkhuala, T. Chatuan Vanlalgakha, Zenngaihniang, Nengzatuan Valte, and H. Gouzalal.

"Heroin and methamphetamine tablets entering Mizoram and Manipur are consumed locally and moved onward through Assam to the rest of India and Bangladesh, and the drug money generated across this chain flows back to the border towns of Mizoram for settlement with Myanmar-based suppliers. The trafficking corridor works as a two-way street through the Champhai-Zokhawthar sector of Mizoram," the ED said, explaining the *modus operandi*.

In one direction, precursor and cutting chemicals move from India to Myanmar, from where heroin, brown sugar, and meth tablets produced there are carried across the Tiau river at Zokhawthar, opposite Khawmawi, and kept at Champhai before being transported via the Champhai-Aizawl road and NH06A to Aizawl, Vairengte, and the Assam and Tripura borders.

The Myanmar-based organisers hired local carriers and moved consignments concealed in soap cases, taxis, motorcycles, and escorted truck convoys. Payments were routed through the same Champhai "hawala" accounts receiving drug proceeds from across Northeast India. Drugs are sold for cash across Manipur, Assam, Tripura, and other parts of India, with the proceeds routed to suppliers in Myanmar through "hawala" channels.

In Manipur's Churachandpur, syndicate operatives collected cash for handlers, who channelled the funds into the banking system through mini-ATM/customer service point counters.

INSIDE



Dismantling RSS ideology key to peace: Kharge

PATNA
Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Sunday attacked the BJP and the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), saying the country would not have lasting peace until the ideology of the RSS was dismantled. Unity could never be achieved as long as such an ideology existed in the country, he said. » PAGE 5

CMRL case: HC is to hear Pinarayi's plea on FIR today

KOCHI
A politically significant legal battle will unfold before a Division Bench of the Kerala High Court on Monday, when former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and others challenge a Single Judge's order directing the registration of a first information report (FIR) against them in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case. » PAGE 3

Ashoke Sen wins the Oskar Klein Medal for physics

CHENNAI
Theoretical physicist Ashoke Sen has been awarded the 2026 Oskar Klein Medal, becoming the first Indian laureate to receive the honour, awarded by Stockholm University and the Nobel Committee for Physics of the Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences. The Medal recognises significant contributions to theoretical physics. » PAGE 6

Ukrainians used Starlink to guide drones: Musk

KYIV
SpaceX's Elon Musk accused Ukraine on Saturday of violating Starlink's terms of service by using it for "drone strikes to kill people", after tension between Washington and Kyiv over disruptions to the network. An Ukrainian official said long-standing restrictions on the civilian system made such offensive use impossible. » PAGE 14

India slams Pak, says military is the 'actual ruler'

UNITED NATIONS
India strongly hit out at Pakistan's attempts at the United Nations to paint a "propagandist" picture of New Delhi, saying Islamabad can "dare not" override instructions from the country's real rulers, the Pakistani military. It took an indirect dig at Islamabad over 2024 general elections marred by allegations of rigging. » PAGE 4

Skilled display



An Indian Air Force team performs aerial manoeuvres during the 'Wings over Ganges' air show in Varanasi on Sunday. AFP [REPORT: PAGE 4]

Houthis target Riyadh, say Saudis struck Yemen infra

Agence France-Presse
RIYADH

The Houthi militia in Yemen on Sunday launched strikes across southern Saudi Arabia even as the Iran-backed group said the kingdom struck Yemen dozens of times over 24 hours. It targeted Riyadh's airport hours after its partial reopening, as well as an airbase and naval base. "The Yemeni armed forces conducted three military operations with dozens of ballistic missiles," Houthi military spokesperson Yahya Saree said on X.

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 14



Congress leaders Alka Lamba and Saptagiri Ulaka addressing the media in New Delhi on Sunday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Govt. failed to contain violence in Manipur, CM must quit: Cong.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Alleging failure to contain renewed violence in Manipur, the Congress on Sunday demanded the resignation of Chief Minister Y. Khemchand Singh, dissolution of the State Assembly, and fresh elections, alongside an intervention by the Union government to end the violence and initiate an inclusive peace process.

No armed group or individual attacking civilians should enjoy "political protection or immunity", the party said. Congress leaders cited recent incidents of violence, including the killing of three Meitei civilians on October 19 and clashes in Kamjong district in which Kuki and Naga civilians were killed.

Addressing a press conference, party MP and Manipur in-charge Saptagiri Ulaka called for time-bound investigations and prosecution in cases of killings, firing, arson, and destruction of civilian property in the State.

The police, Mr. Ulaka alleged, used a heavy hand to suppress the protest by using tear gas shells and lathi charge against the people.

Mahila Congress president Alka Lamba, who visited Manipur earlier this month, said women affected by the conflict continued to face hardship. "The BJP government in Manipur has completely failed to stop the violence there," she said.

Sophisticated weapons

Mr. Ulaka, the Congress in-charge of Manipur, alleged that armed groups possessed more sophisticated weapons than security forces. He said around 300 people had been killed since May 2023, while nearly 60,000 were displaced, with about 24,000 yet to return home.

The Congress leaders called for immediate protection of civilians in vulnerable areas, strict enforcement of the suspension-of-operations ground rules, restoration of free movement across the State, and a credible roadmap for rehabilitation and the return of displaced persons.

The ethnic conflict between the Meitei and Kuki communities that began in May 2023 has claimed more than 300 lives and displaced thousands. In recent months, clashes involving Kuki and Naga groups have also been reported.

Andhra Pradesh, Odisha on alert as deep depression develops over Bay of Bengal

The Hindu Bureau
BHUBANESWAR/VIJAYAWADA

The weather system over Bay of Bengal which is expected to make landfall as a 'very severe cyclonic storm' on October 28 intensified into a deep depression on Sunday, the India Meteorological Department said.

Andhra Pradesh, where the storm is likely to make landfall, deployed several battalions of disaster management teams on Sunday and announced evacuation of people in the likely impact zones.

According to a bulletin issued by the IMD on Sunday evening, "The depression over eastcentral and adjoining Southeast Bay of Bengal moved southwestwards with speed of 5 kmph during past six hours, [and] intensified into a deep depression. It lay centered in the Bay, about 420 km north-northwest of Sri Vijaya Puram in the Andaman Islands, and 870 km east-southeast of Vishakhapatnam.



Fishing boats lie on the beach in Visakhapatnam on Sunday in view of the forecast. V RAJU

The system is likely to move nearly southwestwards, and intensify further into a cyclonic storm over eastcentral and the adjoining southeast Bay of Bengal by early morning on Monday (October 26). Then it is very likely to move west-northwestwards over the eastcentral and adjoining westcentral Bay of Bengal and intensify into a severe cyclonic storm over the westcentral Bay of Bengal on Tuesday morning (October 27), the bulletin said.

The severe cyclonic storm is then likely to move northwestwards, intensify further into a very severe cyclonic storm and reach the westcentral Bay of Bengal near the Andhra Pradesh coast on Wednesday morning (October 28), and cross the Andhra Pradesh and Yanam coasts between Bapatla and Visakhapatnam.

Response teams on alert

Andhra Pradesh State Disaster Management Authority managing director Prakhar Jain told *The Hindu* that the State has deployed 12 battalions of the State Disaster Response Force and seven battalions of the National Disaster Response Force. The State has also requisitioned three more NDRF battalions.

The Odisha government instructed eight Ministers, including two Deputy Chief Ministers, to station themselves in eight districts to supervise disaster management measures.

Officials filed 1/3rd of Form 7s in Karnataka

Rishita Khanna
Pon Vasanth B.A.
BENGALURU/CHENNAI

Over one-third of roughly 1.82 lakh Form 7s filed to delete voter names from the draft rolls during SIR of electoral rolls in Karnataka were filed in the names of officials, with none stating why they sought the deletions.

Officials *The Hindu* spoke to said that the forms were auto-generated by the software for those marked as 'ineligible' from among those who were sent notices for 'logical discrepancies' or for being 'unmapped' with the electoral rolls from 2002.

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 5

INBRIEF



Haryana guest teachers stage march seeking regularisation

Thousands of guest teachers from across Haryana on Sunday took out a rally in Kurukshetra and marched towards Chandigarh demanding their regularisation in accordance with court rulings. The protesters will submit a memorandum to the Haryana Governor seeking implementation of the State government's three-year regularisation policy. The march, organised by the Haryana Guest Teachers' Joint Front, comes amid a protest outside the Mini Secretariat in Kurukshetra that has been going on since June 23.

FIR sought after voter ID cards found on banks of Narmada

A total of 343 voter ID cards were found abandoned on the banks of the Narmada river in Mandleshwar town of Madhya Pradesh's Khargone district on Sunday, following which the Opposition Congress demanded the filing of an FIR and an impartial probe. Preliminary information suggests that the cards belong to the Rau Assembly constituency in neighbouring Indore district. Residents found the cards during a cleanliness drive along the riverbank and informed the administration. A video showing the recovered cards went viral on social media. PTI

Anti-drug activist murder: protests break out across Punjab against AAP govt.

Agitators burn brooms, effigies in Mansa, Hoshiarpur and several other districts on Joint Action Committee's call seeking justice for Jhota; govt. 'failed' to rein in drug traffickers, allege protesters

Press Trust of India
MANSA/HOSHIARPUR

Members of various farmer organisations and political parties held protests across several districts in Punjab on Sunday, demanding justice for slain anti-drug activist Parvinder Singh Jhota. The protests were held on a call given by the Joint Action Committee, which is leading the agitation over the murder of Jhota.

Protesters burnt brooms and effigies of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government in several districts, including Mansa and Hoshiarpur. In Mansa, Jhota's father Bhim Singh burnt a broom, the election symbol of AAP.

At Tanda, the protesters were led by Lok Inqlab Manch patron Hardeep Singh Khudda. Kisan Mazdoor Sangharsh Committee (Piddi group) president Paramjit Singh Bhulla was among those present.



The agitation is spearheaded by the Joint Action Committee that comprises various organisations and social activists. FILE PHOTO

Mr. Bhulla alleged that the AAP government, which had come to power promising to curb drug abuse, "failed" to rein in drug traffickers while those raising their voices against drugs were facing violence. He alleged that political leaders were exploiting the drug issue for electoral gains instead of addressing the problem. He urged people not to allow any political party to use Jhota's death for electoral purposes.

Meanwhile, Congress workers led by former Zila Parishad member Sumit Dadwal gathered at Adda Harse Mansar in the Mukerian area of Hoshiarpur and burnt brooms to register their protest. Senior Congress leader and former Health Minister Balbir Singh Sidhu led a candlelight march from Gurdwara Amb Sahib to Mohali's Phase 7 to honour Jhota and others who have fought against the drug menace in Punjab. State Congress president Pargat Singh and former Faridkot MLA Kuldeep Singh Kiki Dhillon also participated in the protest. Members of Akali Dal Waris Punjab De also held protests over the Jhota's murder at several places in the state.

On October 13, Jhota, known for raising his voice against the alleged illegal sale of addictive substances at chemist shops, was shot dead inside a medical store in a busy marketplace in Mansa. Ashwani Kumar, the store owner who allegedly opened fire at Jhota after the activist questioned him over the sale of drugs to an elderly man, has ben arrested.

The killing triggered a political slugfest in Punjab, where the Assembly election is due early next year.

Family's demands

The family of Jhota has refused to allow a post-mortem and cremation until their all demands are met, including the resignations of CM Bhagwant Mann and DGP Gaurav Yadav.

Uttarakhand govt. lifts freeze on hiring ahead of 2027 poll

Press Trust of India
DEHRADUN

Drive announced to fill vacant teaching and non-teaching posts in aided non-government secondary schools

In the run-up to the 2027 Asembly election, the Uttarakhand government has announced that a recruitment drive will be launched to fill vacant teaching and non-teaching posts in aided non-government secondary schools.

A statement issued by the BJP government in the State on Sunday stated that the long-standing freeze on recruitment has been lifted keeping in mind the interests of students. "In the election year, and with interests of students in mind, the State government has lifted the long-standing freeze on the recruitment process," it read.

School management committees will now be able to fill vacancies in respective schools based on student enrolment. School Education Minister Dhan Singh Rawat said the government was committed to strengthening the State's education system and ensuring the availability of required staff in schools.

"While some school management committees have been approaching the High Court regarding the recruitment of teachers and staff, other schools, lacking such resources, have been struggling to function with a minimal number of teachers. In light of this, a decision has been made to facilitate the appointment of regular teachers and staff across all such schools," he said.

Mr. Rawat added that recruitment would be undertaken only against sanctioned vacant posts that had been formally revived or restored by the competent authority to prevent administrative hurdles in the future. He said teacher recruitment would be based on student enrolment and schools' actual requirements to ensure adequate staff and improve the quality of education.

He also directed officials to ensure recruitment in aided schools is transparent, fair and lawful.

Ghulam Nabi Azad, BJP hit out at Farooq over remarks on Pakistan

The Hindu Bureau
SRINAGAR

Democratic Progressive Azad Party (DPAP) president Ghulam Nabi Azad and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday criticised the remarks by National Conference (NC) president Farooq Abdullah, who allegedly referred to "Pakistan and its saviour role in Kashmir".

Terming Mr. Abdullah's remarks as "seditious and anti-national", BJP spokesperson Altaf Thakur demanded that the authorities "examine it and take appropriate legal action".



Farooq Abdullah

"It was deeply unfortunate that a senior political leader was questioning India's intentions towards the people of J&K while projecting Pakistan as a force working in their interest. Mr. Abdullah should be booked for making such remarks. A leader who has taken an oath under the Constitution cannot be allowed to question the country's intentions towards its own people while giving political legitimacy to Pakistan's narrative," Mr. Thakur said.

"Since 1947, successive Central governments have contributed to J&K's development, irrespective of political affiliations. I am shocked by Farooq Abdullah *saheb*'s statement," Mr. Azad said.

Former Army captain held in Tamil Nadu over intelligence leak

The Hindu Bureau
VELLORE

A 52-year-old retired Army captain has been arrested by the Kaniyambadi police in Vellore on charges of sharing sensitive information on security forces with an unidentified woman, suspected to be a Pakistani intelligence operative.

The police identified the arrested person as Babu of Keelavalam village on the outskirts of Vellore. An initial inquiry revealed that, based on inputs from Central agencies, the Kaniyambadi police searched the suspect's house.

The police said Babu had served in the artillery wing of the Army for 28 years before retiring in 2022. Thereafter, he settled in the village with his family. Investigations by Central agencies found that a Pakistani agent got in touch with Babu a year ago. They chatted on social media platforms, and Babu gave sensitive information to him.

Naseeruddin Shah wants to weaken democracy, says BJP amid SRFTI row

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

A war of words has erupted after veteran actor Naseeruddin Shah attacked the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) as he backed students of the Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute (SRFTI) staging an indefinite sit-in over violent incidents on the campus.

Mr. Shah alleged that the BJP was taking "revenge" on anyone not subscribing to its beliefs and policies. The BJP leadership in West Bengal questioned the motives of the actor and said he "wanted to weaken democracy in the country".



Naseeruddin Shah

BJP Rajya Sabha member Rahul Sinha called for a full investigation into the veteran actor's criticism of the party over the ongoing agitation at the SRFTI, alleging his remarks could be linked to an international conspiracy.

Power cut alleged

On Sunday, a section of SRFTI students claimed power supply to the only classroom they had been accessing for Internet connectivity and workstation facilities was cut off, accusing the administration of intensifying measures to pressure them into calling off their agitation.

SPOTLIGHT

Maid to order

Quick-help apps ensure that house help is just a few screen taps away. This is beginning to upset the ecosystem of support among domestic workers and long-term relationships built with employers

Suchitra Karthikeyan

It is 8.30 a.m. Office-goers bustle outside Chembur's Sandu garden in Mumbai, while teens laze on swings and slides, doomscrolling through their phones. Elder citizens and middle-aged men practise yoga or jog around the garden's tracks as the city awakens to a new day.

Priti Saputre, 40, looks alert, wearing a black shirt with the name of a quick-service app printed on the back, as she waits for any notification on her phone to get to work as a domestic worker. With six bookings a day, each up to 2 hours, Saputre endures 12-hour work days. She is paid every 15 days.

"I have been working for a year and a half for them and earn about ₹25,000 per month if I get all five stars. If I get four stars, the pay is halved. Only two cancellations are allowed every 15 days," says Saputre. Every cancellation by her also withholds ₹1,000 from her pay, she says.

Since 2025, applications like Snabbit and Pronto have entered the domestic work market, and existing players like Urban Company expanded their services to include house-help on demand under InstaHelp. These applications allow customers to book a domestic worker (almost exclusively women) for an hour or more to do most of the household work: dusting, cleaning, mopping, washing utensils, cutting vegetables, and more. The rates start as low as ₹99 an hour and come with bulk welcome offers such as ₹49 for three bookings to attract more customers.

Rating-based pay

"We don't have any weekly offs and lunch time is decided by our supervisor. This varies usually as per the bookings," says Shaheen, a 32-year-old woman working for a quick-service company.

She says that the star-rating works both ways. "We can rate a customer as bad, and that person will not be listed for me again. But if someone else has reported a particular customer as bad, they may appear on my list as a potential customer". Sick days too result in docking in pay.

From 7 a.m. to 7.30 p.m., both women work in and around Chembur, resting in between at Sandu Garden in Mumbai.

"Initially, women working with these app-based companies were reluctant to talk to us," says Deepak Paradkar, the Maharashtra co-ordinator for Aajeevika Bureau. The non-profit organisation works with workers in the unorganised sector for their rights, pay, and social security.

"However, in the past year, many changes have been introduced which have made more women approach us. Initially, the app-based work was paying more. As more women join, the clauses for docking pay have increased. In one case, a worker had her salary halved due to new clauses like late login, insufficient hours, and lower star-rating," says Paradkar.



Domestic workers, representatives of trade unions, and activists attending a seminar on issues faced by app-based workers conducted by the Aajeevika Bureau in Mumbai. AAJEEVIKA BUREAU

Customer is king

The ultimate gainer is the customer. Younger people who have recently relocated to newer localities prefer booking domestic workers as per their need.

Anshika, a 32-year-old bank employee residing in Chembur uses an app-based service, as she is assured of help when she needs it. "At ₹99/hour, the app is more reliable than a bai (domestic worker), as there is no scope of her skipping work. I can also add the same worker as a favourite if I am pleased with her work, so that I can repeat her in the next booking," she says. The app allows customers to book workers between 6 a.m. and 6 p.m. "Both me and the worker can rate each other. While she will be able to see my rating of her work, I cannot see hers," says Anshika.

Paradkar says the problem with the rating system is that when a worker complains about a customer, no real action is taken against the customer.

Paradkar says people try to squeeze in unreasonable amounts of work into a time slot. "If someone is booked for an hour and they complete the assigned tasks before time, then additional tasks are added by the customer, for the same pay. Workers have complained that if they refuse to do additional tasks, their ratings drop, resulting in docking of pay or fewer jobs," he explains.

Familiarity, flexibility

Not all domestic workers want to be on these apps. Manisha Chaudhary (42), prefers to do full-time housework. Working in four houses in a locality around Chembur's Diamond Garden in Mumbai, and two independent bungalows nearby, she says her work and timings are flexible.

"I have seen these (app-based) workers sit around Diamond garden waiting for bookings. They are not allowed to go home till their shift ends at 7.30 even if they have no jobs. I work from 7.45 in the morning to 6 in the evening, and am free to go if I finish my jobs earlier," says Chaudhary.

Her view is shared by other workers in the locality. Madhuri (45) too enjoys the flexibility in work timings. "Mornings are hectic at home. There is a water cut and my child goes to school in the morning, so I cannot come to work before noon. I work from noon to 8:30 in the evening in the same locality and one adjoining bungalow," says Madhuri.

However, she says that she is overworked by some customers and has had fights with some over pay. "The pay is less than those apps, but full-time work is less taxing and travel time is saved. I can also ask my employers for my salary early, in case of emergencies," says Madhuri.

Paradkar says the apps have changed the nature of domestic worker relationships. "Women in traditional housework know each other and build a community. Apps have killed this as workers are sent to different locations, giving no opportunity for bonding," he says.

No safety net

Safety is a big concern for women working via these apps. Apart from reporting problematic customers, Snabbit and Urban Company have an SOS button which the worker can press, alerting her supervisor, positioned nearby.

Paradkar says there have been instances when the door was locked with a complex locking system once the worker entered a customer's home. One worker alleged that a customer asked her to watch movies with him, while one worker alleged that a customer had hinted at sex, he says. All of the cases were reported to Aajeevika Bureau, which has sought the government's intervention.

Both Snabbit and Urban Company did not respond to *The Hindu*'s questions on pay and safety of the workers, and app processes.

Domestic-work app-based workers are not currently eligible for social security under any Maharashtra government scheme, says Paradkar. "These women are not workers but 'partners' as per these apps which puts them under the 'self-employed' category," he explains.

"When we tried to register these women on Maharashtra's domestic worker portal, a signature from the employer is required, which is the customer in this case. Most of them refuse to sign as these workers do temporary jobs at their houses," Paradkar says.

He adds that the apps are not ready to take responsibility as an 'employer', making it impossible to register these women for social security benefits offered by the State.

Parliament passed the Social Security Code, 2020, which provides the unorganised workforce, including platform and gig workers with social benefits.

"Currently, we are under the process of getting them e-Shram cards so that they may get some benefits in the future," says Paradkar. The e-Shram card registers workers in the national database of unorganised workers and can facilitate access to eligible social-security schemes.

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Forensic team collect evidence from the car involved in the fatal accident on Sunday. THULASI KAKKAT

Man killed as luxury car 'driven by minor' hits scooter in Kochi

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

A 55-year-old man was killed after a luxury car, allegedly driven by a 17-year-old boy, rammed the scooter he was riding in the early hours of Sunday in Kochi, Keralam.

The deceased has been identified as Jayabalakrishnan of Chittur, Cheranalloor. The accident comes days after three youth were killed after an allegedly speeding luxury car driven by a 19-year-old youth rammed the two-wheeler they were riding near Nedumbassery.

The police on Sunday recorded the arrest of the minor driver, reportedly the son of a judicial officer. The boy was released on bail from the police station later in the day under Section 8 of the Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015, according to the police. The accident occurred around 2.20 a.m. near a car showroom at Maraparambu on Container Road in Cheranalloor. The Cheranalloor Circle Inspector told media the boy was not under the influence of alcohol as per preliminary medical examination.

The Cheranalloor police have registered a case against the driver on charges of rash driving and rash or negligent act that does not amount to culpable homicide under Sections 281 and 106(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

The body of the victim was shifted to the Ernakulam Government Medical College Hospital. Mr. Jayabalakrishnan is survived by his wife Manju and three children, including two Plus Two students.

Strict action sought

Ernakulam MLA T.J. Vinod, meanwhile, requested Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala to examine if the police's act of granting station bail to the minor accused was legally correct. He said the responsibility of the car owner who permitted the minor to drive the vehicle should also come under the purview of the investigation.

Get ready to oust TVK-led govt.: Stalin to DMK workers

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK president M.K. Stalin on Sunday urged his party workers to get ready to oust the TVK-led government under Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay.

Speaking at a wedding in Chennai, he said that when the DMK-led alliance won in the 2021 Assembly election and he took charge as the Chief Minister, he had told reporters that his government would deliver good governance that even those who had not voted for the alliance would regret not having done so. However, today, those who had voted for the TVK were regretting their decision. "Under this government, newspapers carry reports every day of the rising prices of essential commodities, administrative failures, sexual offences, murders, and robberies. On the one side, there are power cuts, while on the other, there are reports, appearing for the past five or six days, about the abduction of children," he said.

Mr. Stalin said the government had formed a special force called the Singappen Special Force. "Now, a situation has arisen in which another force has to be formed to protect the Singappen Special Force," he said.

"I had said this government would last only six months. Now, the situation has reached a point where this government would not even last six months," Mr. Stalin added.

Arlekar's recommendation on KPSC chief sparks row

Former Keralam Governor sent communication to President seeking removal of Baiju over alleged irregularities; CPI(M) asks Chief Minister to clarify stand; Ministers in UDF govt. divided over move

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

In an unprecedented move, former Keralam Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar has reportedly recommended to the President the removal of Kerala Public Service Commission (PSC) Chairperson M.R. Baiju over alleged irregularities in the running of the recruitment body.

The recommendation came out in the public domain hardly a few days after Mr. Arlekar left the State and has been succeeded by Om Prakash Mathur as the Governor. He is learnt to have sent the communication to President Droupadi Murmu a week before he was relieved of his duties.



Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar

A Crime Branch investigation into the alleged irregularities in the PSC examination for certain posts in the State Planning Board is currently progressing.

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) State secretariat, which called the Governor's move unconstitutional, has demanded that the Chief Minister clarify his stand on the Governor's recommendation to the President to dissolve the PSC.

"Has the government asked the Governor to dissolve the PSC at this stage when no allegation can be proven or presented in court? It is no secret that the Sangh Parivar is targeting the PSC, after the universities in the State," said the CPI(M) in a statement.

Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan said the recommendation to remove the Chairperson and dissolve the commission was unlawful, a violation of constitutional provisions, and gross abuse of power.

He said the move raised concerns about the use of Lok Bhavans for the BJP's political agenda. The Congress-led UDF government should clarify its stand and oppose attempts to undermine institutional autonomy, he said.

While a majority of the UDF Ministers, who spoke on Sunday, supported the Governor's move, Revenue Minister A.P. Anil Kumar called it a constitutional impropriety to hastily recommend the action without the government's knowledge when an investigation was under way.

Travel ban for five suspects in Veeramani POCSO case

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Police have issued a Look Out Circular (LOC) against five suspects in the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) cases against Gem Granites owner R. Veeramani, restraining them from leaving India.

The police said investigators believe the suspects were in possession or had knowledge of certain documents or information in the cases booked against Veeramani and his associates.

"We have issued an LOC against five persons to prevent them from escaping to a foreign country. Going by the investigation so far, these persons are suspected to be involved in the cases against Veeramani," a police officer said.

LOCs are issued to stop any individual wanted by the police or investigating agency from leaving or entering the country through designated land, air, and sea ports. The Bureau of Immigration will enforce the LOC, preventing such individuals from leaving or entering the country.

Archana Veeramani, daughter of Veeramani, who was hospitalised due to an ailment, was allowed to go home. She was detained at the Chennai International Airport by the Special Investigation Team (SIT) constituted to probe the cases against Veeramani, when she was about to leave the country on Friday.

CM warns of action against private companies sidelining Kannadigas

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Sunday warned the government would take appropriate action against private companies found deliberately sidelining Kannadigas in employment.

The government would not allow the rights, dignity and opportunities of Kannadigas to be disregarded, he said.

"It is disheartening to hear complaints that Kannadigas are facing injustice in employment opportunities in Bengaluru's Information Technology companies. The government has taken seriously the issue of native Kannada speakers being sidelined," Mr. Shivakumar said on social media platform X.

Online complaints

His remarks followed a series of complaints on social media alleging that Kannadigas were being denied employment opportunities. Recently, a woman claimed online that candidates who mentioned Kannada in their resumes were being rejected by Bengaluru-based companies.

She also alleged that few Kannadigas were being hired and that those selected were offered lower salaries.

She sought the Chief Minister's intervention.

"In Karnataka, Kannadiga is sovereign. The government will not allow the rights, dignity and opportunities of Kannadigas to be disregarded for any reason. The world sees Bengaluru as India's technology capital, and we take immense pride in the talent, skills, and capabilities of our Kannadigas," Mr. Shivakumar said.

"If it is found that any private institution is deliberately sidelining Kannadigas, the government will take appropriate action," the Chief Minister warned, adding.

The government remained committed to addressing concerns affecting Kannadigas, he added.

HC to hear Pinarayi's plea against CMRL case FIR today

K.S. Sudhi
KOCHI

A politically significant legal battle will unfold before a Division Bench of the Kerala High Court on Monday, when former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and others challenge a Single Judge's order directing the registration of a first information report (FIR) against them in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case.

It was on a petition from lawyer K.M. Shajahan, who approached the court against the State's decision to go for a preliminary inquiry rather than register an FIR, that the Single Judge issued the order.

Mr. Vijayan and others had last week secured a favourable order from the Supreme Court against an order of the Division Bench, which refused them leave to challenge the Single Judge's order.

The Single Judge, while ordering the FIR, had also quashed the decision of the State to constitute a SIT to probe the details revealed in a letter from the ED regarding the alleged corruption by Mr. Vijayan.

On its part, the ED booked cases against Mr. Vijayan's daughter T. Veena and son-in-law P.A. Mohamed Riyas for money laundering and hawala transactions based on the FIR, which was registered based on its letter to the State Police Chief.

The apex court had also stayed the probe for 10 days. The Supreme Court had held that Section 175 (4) of the BNSS ensured that the participation of a public servant who was made a potential accused was mandatory before registering an FIR.

Drought conditions may affect food production: Karnataka Deputy CM

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister and Revenue Minister G. Parameshwara on Sunday said that the prevailing drought conditions owing to the deficient southwest monsoon, which ended last month, had led to a loss of 80% of crops in certain regions of the State. He warned that this situation could affect food production.

"Currently, the State has an adequate stock of food grains. However, if food grain production declines in the coming days, suitable actions will have to be taken after discussing the consequences. The MPs from Karnataka should forget their party affiliations and help in mitigating the drought situation," he said.



Rough patch: Most of the sown crops wilted in areas affected by drought due to prolonged dry spells in Karnataka. S.K. DINESH

Release of funds

Urging the Finance Department not to delay the release of the compensation amount, he said orders have been issued with respect to the compensation, and farmers would receive the compensation once the funds are released.

He also said that the idea of taking an all-party delegation to Delhi to seek drought relief has not been dropped. "We have sought time from the Centre. However, they are yet to give us time," Mr. Parameshwara added.

The Deputy Chief Minister asserted that the State government had fulfilled its responsibilities and that the Union government must also discharge its obligations. "If the Centre and the State continue trading allegations, it is the farmers who will ultimately suffer," he said.

Total crop losses have been estimated to be around ₹62,000 crore due to the impact of the drought. While sowing during the kharif season was affected by the drought, most of the sown crops wilted in the drought-affected areas due to prolonged dry spells.

Shivakumar behind ₹600-cr. deal to politically 'finish off' our family: Kumaraswamy

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Union Minister for Heavy Industries and Steel and Janata Dal (Secular) leader H.D. Kumaraswamy on Sunday alleged that Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar had struck a ₹600-crore deal to politically "finish off" the family of former Prime Minister H.D. Deve Gowda, Mr. Kumaraswamy's father.

"There is no doubt that the Chief Minister is the one who has spoken about finishing off a family – which is Mr. Deve Gowda's family," he told pressperson here. "There are many conspiracies that have been plotted against our family, and this [₹600 crore deal] is one among them," Mr. Kumaraswamy said.



H.D. Kumaraswamy

Probe into 'sting' video

"That is why I had sought a detailed investigation [into the episode of the 'sting' video]. If I ask the government to arrest the kingpin of sting operations, it allows him to take anticipatory bail," the Union Minister said.

"The government is targeting persons who are unconnected with the case. When I point out the suspicious death of Vikas, who worked for the person involved in the sting operation, the Home Minister seeks evidence," he added.

The JD(S) leader also alleged that Home Minister Priyank Kharge was sheltering those accused of indulging in the alleged 'sting operation'.

Revanth to meet Fadnavis for talks on Tummidihatti Barrage

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy has stepped up efforts to revive the long-pending Tummidihatti Barrage across the Pranahita river at Tummidihatti on the Telangana-Maharashtra border, with the State government delegation set to hold crucial talks with Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis in Mumbai on Monday to secure consent for raising its proposed height from 148 metres to 150-152 metres Full Reservoir Level (FRL).

The Telangana delegation, led by the Chief Minister, would comprise Minister for Irrigation and Civil Supplies N. Uttam Kumar Reddy and senior officials. The Maharashtra Chief Minister would be assisted by Minister for Water Resources Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil and senior officials.



The proposed site for barrage.

In 2016, an agreement was reached between the governments, with K. Chandrashekhar Rao and Devendra Fadnavis at the helm of affairs, and the height agreed for the barrage was 148 metres. In the same meeting, the Medigadda Barrage was agreed to at 100 metres FRL. The project subsequently lost priority as the BRS government concentrated on the Kaleshwaram project.

Now, the Congress government is planning to revive the Pranahitha-Chevella project by taking up a barrage at Tummidihatti with 152 metres FRL, as originally planned in 2007, to take water by gravity and a small lift to Yellampally project. Telangana is arguing that only 2,300 acres of land would face submergence with the barrage at 152 metres FRL and less than 1,000 acres with 150 metres FRL. The State is prepared to consider 150 metres if that helps secure Maharashtra's approval.

TDP in a pickle after spokesman fires shots into air during clash in Nandalur

A.D. Rangarajan
TIRUPATI/KADAPA

Shots allegedly fired into the air by a Telugu Desam Party (TDP) leader during a clash in the nomination phase for the ZPTC (Zilla Parishad) and MPTC (Mandal Parishad) elections in Nandalur mandal of Kadapa district in Andhra Pradesh on Thursday have left the TDP in a piquant situation and the ruling NDA embarrassed.

TDP spokesperson Koduru Balasubramanyam, a Tirupati-based medical professional, reportedly fired several rounds in the air when members of his group clashed with a rival gang led by Yeddula Sagar during the nomination phase on Thursday.



Cameo gear: Koduru Balasubramanyam (centre, in white) holds the pistol during the clash at Nandalur. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Police rushed to the spot and brought the situation under control. They seized the weapon and arrested eight persons involved in the melee. Mr. Balasubramanyam was admitted to a hospital, citing a rib fracture.

Though licensed weapons have to be deposited with the police when the Model Code of Conduct comes into effect, the TDP leader has apparently kept the department guessing by carrying it to a troublesome spot.

Licensed, not recorded

Since Mr. Balasubramanyam had not informed the Tirupati Collectorate about his weapon, the district police were understandably clueless about it, and as a result, reportedly did not demand its surrender.

After the incident, the Kadapa police were at a loss as to how to deal with a weapon that, although licensed, had not been mentioned in the official records. "The weapon meant for use in self-defence was apparently used without any provocation. We will write to the appropriate authority to seek cancellation of the license," Superintendent of Police (Kadapa) Nachiket Vishwanath Shelke told *The Hindu*.

Meanwhile, the TDP, which has been claiming an incident-free nomination phase, is on the defensive because the incident involves its own official spokesperson.

India slams Pak. at UN, says military is country's 'real ruler'

Press Trust of India
UNITED NATIONS

Indian diplomat accuses Pakistan of attempting to paint a propagandist picture of the former

India strongly hit back at Pakistan's attempts at the United Nations to paint a "propagandist" picture of New Delhi, saying Islamabad's "Form 47 government" can "dare not" override instructions from the country's real rulers, the Pakistani military.

Form 47 is an official election document in Pakistan that records the provisional, consolidated results of voting in a constituency. Pakistan's February 2024 general elections were marred by allegations of rigging and irregularities, with critics using the term "Form 47" to question the official results.

During an interactive dialogue with the Special Rapporteur on Minority Issues at the UN General Assembly's Third Committee on Saturday, First Secretary at the Permanent Mission of India to the UN, Raghoo Puri, accused Pakistan of attempting to "paint a propagandist picture" of India. Islamabad's actions, he said, are aimed at diverting attention from its own domestic challenges, including economic distress, lawlessness and human rights violations.

"But of course, the interest of the Fauj, the Pakistani army, who are the real rulers of the country, is supreme, and we fully understand the predicament of the Pakistani representative," he said.

Shrinking minorities

Questioning Islamabad's record on protecting minority rights even as it sought to criticise India, Mr. Puri underlined that it is well-documented that Pakistan's minorities have shrunk dramatically since its independence.

"We do understand, unfortunately, that the Form 47 government dare not override instructions from the Pakistani military," he said, adding that the interests of the armed forces, which he described as the country's "real rulers", took precedence.

Cybersecurity emerging as a critical concern: PM

A country can be weakened by attacks on its economy, says Modi after opening RBI's data centre and Cybersecurity Training Institute in Bhubaneswar; he slams Cong. for crippling banking system

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday emphasised the need to safeguard financial institutions against cybercriminals and cyberterrorists, warning that the changing nature of warfare had made cybersecurity an increasingly critical concern.

Mr. Modi was inaugurating the Reserve Bank of India's new data centre and Cybersecurity Training Institute in Bhubaneswar. "We all know that wars today are not fought with weapons alone. A country can also be weakened by attacks on its economy. As India grows stronger economically, protecting our banking system from cybercriminals and cyberterrorists becomes equally essential," the Prime Minister said.

"The nature of cyberthreats is changing. We cannot confront these emerging challenges with outdated systems, old training methods and obsolete tools. We need modern infrastructure as well as a skilled workforce," he said, adding that this was where the Cybersecurity Training Institute assumed great importance.


Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurates the RBI's ₹169-crore data centre and Cybersecurity Training Institute in Bhubaneswar. PTI

Dig at Congress

Taking a dig at previous Congress governments at the Centre, Mr. Modi said banks had been out of the reach of ordinary citizens for decades while select groups had been benefiting from banking systems due to their proximity to power.

"Banks were nationalised in the 1960s and 1970s in the name of helping the poor. Yet, until 2014, more than half the country's population remained outside the banking ecosystem. Banking products and services, including loans, were a distant dream even for many middle-class families. Poor people, small farmers, landless women and girls could not even imagine accessing them," Mr. Modi said.

"In New Delhi, thousands of crores of rupees in bank loans were extended over telephone to a select group of people close to certain Congress leaders and those who had access to them. Poor and middle-class families needed a guarantor even to open a bank account. But under the Congress's 'phone banking system', thousands of crores of rupees were readily available to the rich at any time," he said. "The banking system was brought to the brink of collapse."

"Over the past several years, the systems we have built and the new ecosystem developed under Digital India have taken banking services to every citizen across the country," he said.

Odisha's growth

He also lauded Odisha's economic growth. "The eastern Indian State has transitioned from a mineral-based economy to a micro-chip manufacturing hub," the Prime Minister said.

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman also spoke on the occasion.

'Hindutva reading of Indian history is single and fixed'

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI


Romila Thapar

Historian Romila Thapar on Sunday said that colonial historians fundamentally shaped the way Indian history came to be understood, reducing complex social and political processes to simplified religious narratives that continue to influence historical interpretations today, and in propagating the Hindutva reading of Indian history. Ms. Thapar was delivering the Second Sitaram Yechury Memorial Lecture on the theme "Historiography and Early Indian History".

Tracing the origins of many prevailing ideas about Indian history, the 96-year-old said that colonial scholars viewed India through the framework of "oriental despotism", portraying Asian societies as static and unchanging and governed by despotic rulers. She argued that the tendency to read Indian history primarily through a religious lens was inherited from colonial scholarship.

"Those writing the history of the colony were writing their own invention," she said, pointing to British historian James Mill. Ms. Thapar criticised Mill's periodisation of Indian history into the Hindu, Muslim, and British periods, arguing that such categorisations imposed simplistic divisions on a far more complex experience.

The Hindutva reading of Indian history is "single and fixed", she said, which did not take into account the multiplicity within Hinduism itself.

"In this interpretation, the purpose of history is not to explain what happened in the past, but instead to construct statements of contemporary political views. These statements deny the centrality of secularism and democracy as the essential component of the new nation."

PM Modi watches as fighter jets roar across Varanasi skies at IAF air show

Press Trust of India
VARANASI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday attended the Indian Air Force's (IAF) air show, "Wings over Ganges", at Namo Ghat in Varanasi, where IAF teams performed aerial manoeuvres over the river Ganga.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Uttar Pradesh Governor Anandiben Patel and Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath accompanied Mr. Modi on the final day of the three-day event, organised to commemorate the 94th anniversary of the IAF.

Wearing a white Air Force cap and dark sunglasses, Mr. Modi watched as fighter jets roared across the skies above the city. The air show lasted for over an hour.


Special event: People at the Indian Air Force's air show 'Wings over Ganges' in Varanasi on Sunday. ANI

According to IAF officials, the show featured displays by fighter aircraft, including the *Sukhoi-30 MKI*, indigenous *Tejas* and *LCH Prachand*, as well as helicopters.

Officials said the highlight of the show was the "Kashi formation", in which three Kiran aircraft flew in a V formation, creating a spectacle in the colours of the Tricolour. The display drew loud cheers from the crowd. During the "Omkar formation", Mi-17 helicopters flew carrying the national flag.

Aerial stunts

Fighter aircraft, including the Rafale, Sukhoi, Mirage 2000, Tejas, MiG-29 and Jaguar, along with transport aircraft and helicopters, showcased the IAF's operational capabilities, officials said. The Surya Kiran aerobatic team showcased precision flying and coordinated manoeuvres, while the Sarang helicopter display team performed aerial stunts.

Mr. Modi's presence drew large crowds along the route from the Police Lines to Namo Ghat. BJP workers and residents greeted him with rose petals, traditional musical performances and cultural programmes at designated points along the route.

Divakar Singh, who attended the event, said it was a matter of pride for Varanasi. "It is a memorable experience to watch the Indian Air Force's show at Namo Ghat in the presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The spirituality of Kashi, combined with the might of fighter aircraft in the sky, fills us with pride," he said.

Jamia student protest intensifies amid restrictions, heavy police deployment

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

A day after attempts were made to forcibly remove protesting students at Jamia Millia Islamia University, students gathered around the campus and tried to enter by climbing the gates on Sunday. Classes were suspended, water facilities on the campus were cut off and no entry or exit was allowed, but students still gathered in large numbers and staged the protest amid heavy police deployment.

On Saturday, security personnel, teaching and non-teaching staff had attempted to remove the students protesting since October 11 for restoration of their students union.

The tent where students protested was removed from the lawn inside Gate no. 7, campus electricity and water facilities were suspended, and gates and libraries closed.



Students were informally being told to vacate the hostel on account of online classes and upcoming festivals. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

It was also announced that all classes will be conducted in online mode until further notice.

Following this, students had gathered in large numbers and stayed through the night, singing songs, raising slogans and demanding the restoration of the Jamia Millia Islamia Students' Union (JMISU).

Similar scenes were observed on Sunday as well, though Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) and Delhi Police personnel guarding the entry gates were seen dispersing the students who were trying to enter the campus.

"Dialogue has been happening since day one. On Saturday, the entire Jamia went to meet the students, but they did not want to end their protest," an official said.

Campus trespass FIR

A first information report (FIR) has been registered on the charges of trespassing, defacement of property and confinement, against political leaders and students following a complaint sent by Jamia administration, the police officials said.

"The complaint contains names of MPs, leaders, students and ex-students who were trying to trespass on campus property. The FIR has been registered under the charges of criminal trespassing, wrongful confinement and voluntarily causing hurt under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS)," Utkarsha, Additional Deputy Commissioner of Police (South East), said.

Padma Shri awardee Chef Damu passes away at 72 in Chennai

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI


K. Damodaran

Chef K. Damodaran popularly called 'Chef Damu', whose simple yet delicious recipes enlivened thousands of kitchens, passed away in Chennai on Sunday after a brief illness.

He was 72 and is survived by wife Usha and daughter Akshaya, a doctor, working in London. According to family sources, his last rites would be held at 3 p.m. on Monday.

Born in September 1954 in West Mambalam to Kothandaraman who worked at the Secretariat and Kothainayaki, a homemaker, he was interested in cooking from a very young age and wanted to take up catering as a career.

He was the first Indian chef to receive a doctorate in hotel management and catering technology.

In December 2010, he entered the Guinness Book of World Records for the Longest Cooking Marathon – Individual, after he set the record by cooking 617 dishes (190 kg of food) in 24 hours, 30 minutes, and 12 seconds.

Chef Venkatesh Bhat, said Chef Damu, the first from the community of chefs to be awarded a Padma Shri (in 2025) in Tamil Nadu, was an inspiration for many youth to enter the hospitality industry and consider catering as a career.

In a post on X, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay condoled Chef Damu's death.

RAF units rushed to Arunachal Pradesh

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Centre has dispatched two Rapid Action Force (RAF) companies of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) to Arunachal Pradesh following violence in Pasighat during protests against the proposed 11,200-MW Siang Upper Multipurpose Project, officials said on Sunday.

The Ministry of Home Affairs had said on Saturday that the RAF companies comprising about 250 personnel will be airlifted from Navi Mumbai on board an Indian Air Force transport aircraft. The units will reach Pasighat and get deployed by Sunday, the officials said.

A statement from the Chief Minister's Office said a 12-hour bandh in Siang, Upper Siang and East Siang districts remained peaceful on Friday. But violence erupted in Pasighat after the bandh ended.

Summit exploring challenges, opportunities in semiconductor industry to be held tomorrow

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

SRM Institute of Science and Technology (SRMIST), in association with *The Hindu Group*, will organise the Semiconductor Summit 2026 on Tuesday.

Industry leaders, researchers, policymakers, academics and students will participate in the summit to discuss developments in semiconductor technology and the challenges and opportunities shaping India's semiconductor ecosystem.

Chip design, advanced manufacturing, artificial intelligence (AI), defence applications, geopolitical competition, talent development and next-generation semiconductor technologies will be the focus areas at the summit.

Chief guest Kamaljeet Singh, Director-General of the Semiconductor Laboratory, Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), Government of India, will deliver the keynote address on "Overview of New Frontiers in Semiconductors".

Michael Hasper, Consul General of the Federal Republic of Germany, and C. Muthamizhchelvan, Vice-Chancellor of SRMIST, will deliver special addresses.

The objective of the Semiconductor Summit 2026 is to encourage dialogue and collaboration among academia, industry and policymakers. The summit will explore ways to bolster India's semiconductor capabilities, address emerging technological challenges and support the development of a skilled workforce for this strategically important industry.

Panel discussions

The first discussion, "The Chip War: Technology, Geopolitics and India's Challenges", will delve into how global semiconductor rivalries, U.S.-China tensions, export controls and supply-chain disruptions affect India's technological and economic strategies.



Sharat Kaul, Consultant and India Representative, International Electronics Manufacturing Initiative (iNEMI); Sandeep Garg, CEO and Board Member, Indichip Semiconductors Limited; Ravi Bhatkal, Vice-President - Strategy, MacDermid Alpha Electronics Solutions; and Yogan Senthilkumar, Chief Technology Officer, iVP Semiconductor, will speak. Aroon Deep, Principal Correspondent, *The Hindu*, will moderate the discussion.

Khyathi Atmakuru, a fourth-year B.Tech. student in Electronics Engineering (VLSI Design & Technology), and Dhruv John Sebastian, a fourth-year B.Tech. student in Electronics and Communication Engineering at SRMIST, will present their work, "Advancing Semiconductor Paradigms: Student-Driven VLSI and Semiconductor Research Initiatives".

The second panel discussion, "Chips for the Next Battlefield: Semiconductors, AI and the Future of Defence", will focus on the role of advanced chips in AI-enabled defence systems, and next-generation military technologies.

A. Sivathanu Pillai, Sir C.V. Raman Chair Professor, SRMIST; Vijay Kumar Saraswat, Scientist and former Director-General of the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO); and Deleep Nair, Professor, Department of Electrical Engineering, IIT Madras, will take part in the discussion. John Xavier, Science & Technology Editor, *The Hindu*, will moderate the session.

The third panel discussion, "Who Will Build India's Chips? Bridging the Semiconductor Talent Gap", will deliberate on the increasing demand for skilled engineers, chip designers, researchers and specialised professionals.

The fourth panel discussion, "From Design to Fab: Can India Build a Complete Semiconductor Ecosystem?", will look into India's efforts to bring in investments across semiconductor manufacturing, and outsourced semiconductor assembly and testing (OSAT).

It will also delve into the challenges in developing an integrated ecosystem spanning research and development, chip design, fabrication, and packaging.

Times Now is the telecast partner. Entry is by invitation only.

Registration link: newsth.live/SCS2026E or scan the QR.

61,000 Form 7 applications filed by poll officials in Karnataka, none cite reason

Rishita Khanna
Pon Vasanth B.A.
BENGALURU/CHENNAI

At least 61,059 Form 7 applications seeking the deletion of names from Karnataka's electoral rolls were filed by election officials themselves, with not a single application mentioning a reason for the deletion, a mandatory requirement under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) and Assistant Electoral Registration Officers (AEROs), listed as the objectors in these applications, said the system "auto-generated" the forms with their digital signatures when voters could not be reached during hearings on notices issued for no mapping or logical discrepancies, and the voters were therefore marked as "ineligible".

This meant the same election machinery was raising objections to voters' names and deciding on whether they should remain on the rolls. Under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960 an objection that is not filed in the prescribed manner, including stating the reason, is liable to be rejected.

The officials said they had been instructed to file Form 7 applications if a voter had shifted, had a duplicate entry elsewhere, was underage, had died, or was not an Indian citizen. But as the forms were auto-generated, the reason for seeking deletion was left blank. With no reason recorded, neither the voter nor anyone examining the electoral roll can establish why a particular name was marked for deletion or verify whether the removal was justified.

Moreover, these categories of voters (ASDDO or Absent, Shifted, Duplicate, Dead and Others) had already been checked during the enumeration phase of the special intensive revision (SIR), which led to more than 1.07 crore names being deleted from Karnataka's draft electoral roll. Most deletions were on the grounds of voters having permanently shifted, followed by those marked as absent.

The number of Form 7 applications filed by election officials rose sharply after the claims and objections period ended on September 23, 2026. Between August 24 and September 23, only 192 such applications were received. More than 60,800 were filed after the claims and objections period, between September 24 and October 22.

The filing continued at an exceptionally high rate even as the disposal deadline approached. On October 22, the last day for disposing of claims and objections, election officials filed 10,105 Form 7 applications. Another 10,314 were filed on the previous day, October 21. On October 17 and 19, officials filed 11,132 and 11,760 applications, respectively.

Opaque deletions

One-third of all the Form 7s generated since the beginning of Claims and Objections phase in Karnataka were filed in the name of officials, with none mentioning any reason

Total Form 7s filed since Aug 24 *(only those made available on ECI's website)*	**1,81,509**
Filed in the name of self	**1,12,514** (62%)
Filed by the officials	**61,059** (33.6%)
Filed by third parties	**7,936** (4.4%)

FIVE DISTRICTS THAT SAW HIGHEST NUMBER OF FORM 7S FILED BY OFFICIALS

B.B.M.P (South)	**10,374**
B.B.M.P (North)	**8,443**
Bangalore Urban	**8,102**
Kolar	**3,392**
Chikkaballapur	**3,330**

Already deleted

To examine the pattern, *The Hindu* obtained the EPIC numbers of several voters against whom election officials had filed Form 7 applications and cross-checked their details on the Election Commission of India (ECI) portal. In all the cases checked, the names had already been deleted from the electoral roll, including those against whom applications had been filed after September 23.

This is at odds with Rule 17 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, which states that any claim or objection not lodged within the prescribed period or in the prescribed form and manner "shall be rejected by the registration officer".

It also remains unclear whether hearing notices or orders, which are mandatory before deletion, were issued in these cases, or on what grounds the names were deleted, as the relevant details had been left blank.

In the Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike South district, where election officials filed the highest number of Form 7 applications, applications filed by officials outnumbered those filed by voters or third parties. Of the 17,491 applications in the district, 10,374 were filed by officials. In the Bommanahalli Assembly constituency alone, officials filed 4,095 of the 5,757 applications received. The pattern of EROs and AEROs filing more Form-7 applications than voters or third parties was seen in at least 26 Assembly constituencies.

Karnataka's final electoral roll is scheduled to be published on October 27. Only claims and objections received by September 23 were to be considered for the final roll. Applications filed after the deadline were to be considered only for a supplementary roll after the SIR. However, *The Hindu*'s sample checks found that the names of voters cited in applications filed even after the deadline had already been deleted from the roll.

Dismantling RSS ideology key to lasting peace, says Kharge

Congress chief terms protest against special intensive revision 'second war of Independence' and urges people of Bihar to support the nationwide movement; alleges nexus between BJP and ECI

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Sunday attacked the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), saying the country would not have lasting peace until the ideology of the RSS was dismantled.

He accused the BJP-RSS of being anti-people, adding that unity could never be achieved as long as such an ideology existed in the country.

Mr. Kharge also triggered controversy with his remark, "Modi *ka baap bhi jayega*" (even Modi's father will go)". He was speaking at an event held on the occasion of the 139th birth anniversary celebration of Bihar's first Chief Minister, Sri Krishna Singh.

He expressed disappointment over former Chief Minister Nitish Kumar joining hands with those who believe in the RSS ideology. "I am pained that socialist leaders like Nitish Kumar joined hands with the people who believe in the RSS ideology," Mr. Kharge said.

All top leaders of the Bihar Congress, including Rajya Sabha member Akhilesh Prasad Singh and Bihar Congress president Rajesh Ram, were present at the event organised at Babu Sabhagar.



Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, along with other party leaders, being felicitated during an event in Patna on Sunday. PTI

Mr. Kharge alleged a nexus between the BJP and the Election Commission of India (ECI), claiming that names were being deleted from the voters' list at the BJP's behest. He added that the Narendra Modi government was misusing Central agencies against Opposition leaders.

Attacking the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC), Mr. Kharge said, "Gyanesh Kumar is not just working to make a party win, but he has also taken up the contract of getting officials BJP ticket and making them Ministers, as revealed by a former Chief Secretary of Kerala. Modi*ji* has made a traitor the CEC; the BJP has betrayed the country."

Mr. Kharge accused the BJP of capturing governments in West Bengal, Haryana, Bihar, and Maharashtra by "stealing votes". He called the ongoing protests against the special intensive revision (SIR) a "second war of Independence" and urged the people of Bihar to support the nationwide movement.

'BJP is anti-Dalit'

The Congress president alleged that the BJP and the RSS supported untouchability and that Mr. Modi himself did not wish for any improvement in the condition of Dalits. He said that even today, the BJP and the RSS did not consider Dalits human beings.

"Eighty years after independence, untouchability still persists in the country. When I visited Haldwani, the BJP and RSS members performed a 'purification' ritual on the stage after I left. How can there be national unity if you do not even consider a large segment of the country's population as your own?" Mr. Kharge asked.

Mr. Kharge remarked that he would pray to Lord Ram to grant wisdom to those who steal offerings from the Ram Temple and to punish them – not only for stealing offerings, but also for stealing votes.

"Two Election Commissioners wrote letters on 14 separate occasions, raising objections regarding Gyanesh Kumar's intent to manipulate the voter rolls, yet their concerns went unheeded," Mr. Kharge said.

'Promises broken'

He questioned the BJP, asking what had happened to the "black money" promised to be brought back within 100 days and the pledge to double farmers' income. Mr. Kharge alleged that the Prime Minister had a habit of lying.

He said that whenever the BJP was asked about its performance, it created a ruckus by invoking Rahul Gandhi's name.

BJP to launch protest against remarks by Cong. chief

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI

The BJP on Sunday hit out at Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge for his remarks against Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

The party said it would hold nationwide protests on Monday against the "inappropriate and offensive remarks".

Criticising the "Modi *ka baap bhi jayega* (even Modi's father will go)" comment, Union Home Minister Amit Shah said Mr. Kharge had "torn apart all norms of decorum". "This is not the first time that the Congress party has used abusive language against Modi*ji* or his family," he said, accusing the party of having hurled insults at the Prime Minister's mother, and mocking his poverty by addressing him as a "*chaiwala*" in the past.

"Under Rahul Gandhi's leadership, the Congress party keeps crossing the limits of indecency every day," he said, alleging that repeated electoral defeats had bred "desperation and frustration" within the party.

"There is a certain dignity to political opposition as well, but dragging the departed family members into speeches from public platforms has now become the real 'culture' of Rahul Gandhi and the whole Opposition," BJP president Nitin Nabin said.

U.P. election officer orders recheck of forms submitted through computer operators

Mayank Kumar
Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

Amid controversy over errors found in the electoral rolls published after the special intensive revision (SIR), the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) of Uttar Pradesh on Sunday ordered reverification of all entries made by computer operators since the publication of post-SIR final electoral rolls on April 10 and directed that any future digital applications be filed only by booth-level officers (BLOs) and not by outsourced computer operators.

"Under no circumstances should the feeding of physical application forms be handled by computer assistants. It must also be ensured that all physical forms received are digitised exclusively by the BLO through the BLO App. Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) must review all pending Form 6, Form 7, and Form 8 applications on a daily basis and ensure their prompt disposal strictly as per rules. Proper custody and preservation of all physically received forms must be ensured", an official statement said.

The measures were announced at a virtual meeting, called to review preparations for special summary revision (SSR) of the electoral rolls for the Assembly constituencies on Saturday, with all Divisional Commissioners, District Election Officers (DEOs), Electoral Registration Officers (EROs), Assistant Electoral Registration Officers (AEROs), and computer assistants.



All electoral officials were strictly instructed not to share their ERONET login ID and password with anyone. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Uttar Pradesh CEO Navdeep Rinwa also directed that errors identified during the investigation of complaints received regarding the electoral rolls through various political parties and social media platforms should not be repeated.

Congress's claim

On October 21, Uttar Pradesh Congress leaders had alleged that details of 13,150 voters were changed while their EPIC and serial numbers remained the same in Pilibhit constituency. They said the changes were made between July and September after the final rolls came out on April 10. The Congress also claimed that 804 residents were removed and about 2,600 non-residents added, putting the total at 16,554 irregular entries. Reports of duplicate entries in electoral rolls have also emerged from other parts of the State.

All officials were strictly instructed not to share their ERONET login ID and password with anyone and conduct a mandatory verification for all Form 6, Form 7, and Form 8 entries fed by computer assistants from the conclusion of SIR (April 10, 2026) to date.

All officials involved were also warned of action under the Section 32 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, which pertains to the breach of official duty in connection with the preparation of electoral rolls.

'Maldives President could stir up anti-India campaign again'

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

Days after Maldives President Mohamed Muizzu visited Pakistan for a bilateral visit that yielded many agreements, the former Foreign Minister of Maldives, Abdulla Shahid, accused him of moving in an "anti-India" direction.

Mr. Shahid, who is running for the leadership of the Opposition Maldivian Democratic Party (MDP) ahead of the Presidential elections in 2028, alleged that Mr. Muizzu, who has had a cordial relationship with New Delhi for most of his tenure, would revive the "India Out" campaign of 2023.

"The President [Mr. Muizzu] is trying to make India the issue again, because for him, he hasn't been able to perform. He hasn't been able to provide any development or deliver on any of the promises, and therefore, come next election again, he will try to create some narrative on hate," Mr. Shahid, who was Foreign Minister during the tenure of the previous President Ibrahim Solih (2018-2023) and won a term as the President of the UN General Assembly with India's support in 2021, told *The Hindu* in an interview here.



Abdulla Shahid was Foreign Minister during the tenure of the previous President Ibrahim Solih. SUHASINI HAIDAR

The Maldives government spokesperson did not reply to a request for a response to Mr. Shahid's comments.

Mr. Shahid called for more transparency about the 20 MoUs signed between the Maldives and Pakistan when President Muizzu went on a three-day visit to Islamabad from October 20 to 22, the first such visit by a Maldives President since 2015. After talks between Mr. Muizzu and Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, the two sides announced agreements in a number of areas, including defence and maritime security, combating illicit trafficking and narcotics, information technology, cybersecurity and AI. They agreed to start direct flights between Male and Islamabad. In particular, Mr. Muizzu's meeting with Pakistan's Field Marshal and Army chief General Asim Munir had raised eyebrows in Delhi. Mr. Muizzu also called for the revival of SAARC, on hold since 2016 when India pulled out of the summit in Islamabad over cross-border terrorism.

"We do not want Maldives to be drawn into disputes within our neighbours," said Mr. Shahid, demanding that the Muizzu government make a statement in Parliament about the nature of the agreements signed with Pakistan. "We must aim for expanding our relationship with everyone who has goodwill to the Maldives, but it should not come at the cost of our own friends, our established relationships," he added.

When asked about Mr. Muizzu's Pakistan visit on Friday, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said that the government kept a "close watch" on such developments and would "take whatever appropriate steps may be necessary". In response to the comments on SAARC, Mr. Jaiswal said that it was "one country", indicating Pakistan, that had "stalled" the functioning of SAARC, and India was keen to strengthen regional cooperation.

'India Out' campaign

Mr. Shahid's comments to *The Hindu* indicate that ties with India may once again become an issue in the Maldivian elections. Mr. Solih lost the elections in 2023 due to the "India Out" campaign of the People's National Congress (PNC), led by Mr. Muizzu, against what he alleged was undue Indian influence in the island chain, especially accusing the Solih government of allowing India to build military bases in infrastructure projects that India had constructed.

Mr. Muizzu had also demanded that Indian Air Force personnel stationed at three locations in the Maldives, including Gan Island and Hanimadhoo Atoll, who operated aircraft that India had provided to the Maldives, be removed. While the beginning of Mr. Muizzu's tenure saw tensions with the Modi government, and he chose to travel to Turkiye, the UAE, and China before visiting India, relations improved after India agreed to withdraw military personnel and replace them with civilian personnel instead.

In June 2024, a month after the final batch of 89 Indian personnel had been withdrawn, Mr. Muizzu visited India to attend Prime Minister Narendra Modi's swearing-in ceremony, and then returned in October 2024 for a bilateral visit, when India offered the Maldives several economic support measures, including a currency swap agreement to help Maldives avoid a debt failure.

Mr. Shahid is in India to attend the Words Beyond Borders International Literature Festival and is expected to affirm a campaign more friendly to India.

JD(U) is finished, it won't win even 10 seats: Anant Singh

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

A day after being expelled from the Janata Dal (United), Mokama MLA Anant Singh on Sunday hit out at the party's leadership over the disciplinary action.

Blaming JD(U) working president Sanjay Kumar Jha for the action, Mr. Singh said that those who had taken this decision would face the consequences when the Assembly elections are held in Bihar. He asserted that the JD(U) would not even win 10 seats.

'Anti-party activities'

The JD(U) on Saturday expelled Mr. Singh and his wife Neelam Devi, who is also a former MLA, for six years for indulging in "anti-party activities". The JD (U), which is part of the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA), also urged the Bihar Assembly Speaker, Prem Kumar, to rescind Mr. Anant Singh's membership of the House with immediate effect.

"Nitish Kumar*ji* has made JD(U) and he is no longer active. So after him, I don't think anybody is there to run the party. Those who are there in party are good for nothing. When Nitish*ji* is finished, JD(U) is also finished. The party will struggle to win even 10 seats in the election," Mr. Singh told pressmen at his residence here.

Backed other candidate

In the recently concluded Bihar Legislative Council polls in eight seats, Mr. Singh campaigned widely in support of the Jan Suraaj Party's Anuj Kumar Singh, and declared that he would defeat the JD(U)'s official candidate, Neeraj Kumar, in the poll.

INBRIEF



First snowfall at Yamunotri, Kedarnath delights devotees

The season's first snowfall at the Yamunotri shrine in Uttarakhand on Sunday brought cheer to pilgrims visiting the temple, while Kedarnath also witnessed snowfall as the Char Dham Yatra entered its final phase. Vinit Posti, a specially invited member of the Kedarnath-Badrinath Temple Committee, appealed to pilgrims to carry all essential medicines and exercise caution during their journey. A surge in pilgrim arrivals during the final phase of the summer Char Dham Yatra has brought renewed activity to Yamunotri shrine, offering relief and optimism to local business owners whose livelihoods depend on the pilgrimage. PTI

392 civic officials in M.P. face action over irregularities

As many as 392 civic officials across Madhya Pradesh face government action over alleged financial irregularities, and seven have been terminated from service so far, a senior official said on Sunday. The officials facing action include 135 chief municipal officers (CMOs). Additional Chief Secretary (Housing and Urban Development) Sanjay Dubey said more than 80 government contractors have also faced action for irregularities such as supplying items at inflated rates. In the video, Mr. Dubey is heard telling municipal officials that the government was tracking their purchases to identify irregularities.

Foreign investors withdraw ₹48,056 crore from equities

Foreign investors have withdrawn ₹48,056 crore from Indian equities in October so far, amid elevated crude oil prices, escalating West Asia tensions, concerns over inflation and weak corporate earnings. However, Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) significantly moderated their selling last week and turned net buyers on two trading days, signalling some easing in selling pressure. The latest outflows follow net withdrawals of ₹35,861 crore in September. FPIs had invested ₹20,200 crore in Indian equities in July and ₹29,631 crore in August, according to data from the Central Depository Services Ltd. (CDSL). PTI

NCERT introduces 20-hour AI module for Classes 9-12

Use of AI in everyday applications, understanding how machines learn from examples, detecting deepfakes and ethical boundaries protecting personal data – Classes 9 to 12 will now study a 20-hour introductory module on computational thinking (CT) and artificial intelligence (AI) released by NCERT. The National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) has developed the activity-based module in consultation with IIT-Madras and IIT-Jodhpur. Special emphasis has been placed on the ethical and safe use of AI, including data privacy, misinformation, fairness, digital safety, and critical verification of AI-generated information. PTI

Prioritise domestic products during festive season, says PM

Modi lauds initiatives in organic farming, digital healthcare, and environmental conservation in his *Mann Ki Baat* address; he cites research at the IIT-M using the Param Shakti supercomputer

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday lauded individuals and communities for promoting organic farming, indigenous products, digital healthcare, scientific research, and environmental conservation. Their efforts were creating new opportunities and contributing to the vision of a self-reliant India, Mr. Modi said.

Ahead of the Deepavali and Chhath festivals, the Prime Minister in his *Mann Ki Baat* address urged people to prioritise domestic products under the 'Vocal for Local' campaign. He also highlighted the importance of packaging, noting that Maharashtra's 'Shabari Naturals' had received Japan's Good Design Award. A Karnataka start-up was developing packaging materials from bamboo and agricultural waste. Khadi's popularity was also growing continuously, he said.

Recalling his recent visit to Chennai, Mr. Modi highlighted the Sudha Gopalakrishnan Brain Centre at the Indian Institute of Technology-Madras, which has developed a brain imaging technology platform and will study 100 human brains. The research uses the Param Shakti supercomputer, and its data will be made available as an open source for research across fields.



> The popularity of Khadi is growing, supporting the artisans whose skills keep our traditions alive. Let's strengthen 'Vocal for Local' by choosing products made by our local artisans
>
> **NARENDRA MODI**
> Prime Minister

Young innovators

At IIT-Madras, he also met young innovators working on gold quality testing, recovery of funds lost to bank fraud, AI-based cervical cancer screening, flying electric vehicles, fast-charging batteries for drones and electric vehicles, and AI applications in defence technology.

On healthcare, about 50 crore tele-consultations had been conducted through the e-Sanjeevani scheme, which had reached remote parts of the country, he said. Nearly 1.9 lakh 'Ayushman Arogya Mandirs' were providing healthcare facilities across the country, he added.

Mr. Modi paid tribute to scientist Narinder Singh Kapany, known as the 'Father of Fibre Optics', ahead of his 100th birth anniversary on October 31. Born in Punjab's Moga district, Kapany's research on transmitting light through thin fibres helped advance modern communication networks.

Kheti Virasat Mission

The Prime Minister highlighted the efforts of the Kheti Virasat Mission in Punjab's Malwa region to promote natural cotton cultivation. Organic cotton is grown without chemicals, while naturally coloured cotton eliminates the need for additional chemicals to dye yarn and fabric. Highlighting environmental conservation, the Prime Minister referred to community efforts to revive the Heval river in Uttarakhand's Tehri Garhwal region. He also underscored the importance of organ donation, and described the decision of the family of road accident victim to donate her organs as an inspiration to society.

Mr. Modi called on people to participate in the 'Run for Unity' on October 31, marking the birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, which is observed as National Unity Day.

Referring to Maharishi Valmiki's birth anniversary on October 26, he highlighted the messages of service, compassion and social harmony in the Ramayana. He also paid tribute to Bhai Parmanand, whose 150th birth anniversary falls on November 4. The British sentenced him to transportation to the Andaman Islands, popularly known as Kala Pani, Mr. Modi said, and he later entered the field of education and also taught Bhagat Singh. Bhai Parmanand was associated with the Arya Samaj and the Hindu Mahasabha for many years, he said.

Jogen Chowdhury, eminent painter and ex-MP, passes away

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA


Jogen Chowdhury

Eminent painter and former Rajya Sabha member Jogen Chowdhury died at a private hospital in Kolkata on Sunday morning. He was 87. He was admitted to the hospital on October 16 after his health deteriorated and was put on ventilator support on Saturday.

Born in Faridpur, now in Bangladesh, on February 15, 1939, Mr. Chowdhury developed an interest in drawing at a young age. During the Partition, he moved to Kolkata with his family. He studied at the Government College of Art and Craft in Kolkata before pursuing further studies at École Nationale Supérieure des Beaux-Arts in Paris. In the early years, he worked in an expressionist style of figuration. His paintings used human forms and were often a satire on politics and society.

Mr. Chowdhury joined the faculty at Visva-Bharati University in Santiniketan in 1987 after serving as Keeper of Art at the Rashtrapati Bhavan. Over the past few years, he had been associated with the design of art installations during Durga Puja.

The Delhi Art Gallery, in a description of his work on its website, said Mr. Chowdhury interpreted the "human form through the X-ray vision of his creativity: attenuated, exaggerated, fragmented, reconfigured, and rephrased".

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari condoled the artist's death, saying his contributions had brought international acclaim to West Bengal and his passing left an irreparable void in the State's intellectual and artistic soul.

Former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee had nominated Mr. Chowdhury to the Rajya Sabha on Trinamool Congress ticket. He served in the Upper House from 2014 to 2020. In 2012, the Trinamool Congress government conferred on him the Banga Bibhushan, one of the State's highest civilian honours. Painter Samir Aich described Mr. Chowdhury as a stalwart of contemporary art who always stood by fellow artists.

Theoretical physicist Ashoke Sen wins Oskar Klein Medal

Vasudevan Mukunth

Theoretical physicist Ashoke Sen has been awarded the 2026 Oskar Klein Medal, becoming the first Indian laureate to receive the honour, awarded by Stockholm University and the Nobel Committee for Physics of the Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences.

The Medal recognises significant contributions to theoretical physics. Dr. Sen is the ICTS-Infosys Madhava Chair Professor at the International Centre for Theoretical Sciences (ICTS), Bengaluru. He also delivered the memorial lecture accompanying the Medal in Stockholm on October 22, titled "Gravity from Strings and Strings from Gravity".

In his career, Dr. Sen has focused on string theory, which is the name of an attempt by physicists to describe matter and nature's fundamental forces, including gravity, within a single framework called quantum gravity. Currently, they are split across two frameworks, quantum physics and relativity. String theory offers ways to reconcile them, but while it is mathematically a highly evolved theory, it has been unable to make predictions that can be confirmed with experiments using today's technologies.


Ashoke Sen is the first Indian to win this award. R. RAVINDRAN

In the 1980s, Dr. Sen helped establish how the equations describing hypothetical strings moving through space could relate to the equations that describe the physical fields that surround it. In the 1990s, he helped show that two apparently different ways to describe physical forces were really equivalent, an idea called S-duality.

Sen conjectures

He also proposed three related ideas, together called the Sen conjectures, in 1999 that gave physicists new ways to understand the behaviour of the strings of string theory. Dr. Sen graduated from Presidency College in Kolkata before going to IIT-Kanpur and thereon to earning his Ph.D. from Stony Brook University, New York, in 1982. After working at institutions including the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (TIFR) in Mumbai and the Harish-Chandra Research Institute (HRI) in Prayagraj, he moved to ICTS in 2021.

For his work, he has won the S.S. Bhatnagar Prize (1994), the Infosys Prize (2009), the Breakthrough Prize in Fundamental Physics (2012), and the Dirac Medal (2014).

He also received the Padma Shri in 2001 and the Padma Bhushan in 2013.

The impact of Dr. Sen's contributions has exceeded their own ambit. In one 2014 interview, U.S. theoretical physicist Edward Witten – widely considered to be the greatest living mathematical physicist – called one of Dr. Sen's papers "short but brilliant" and that it "convinced me that the duality had to be right". Dr. Witten also said Dr. Sen's findings had inspired work that paved the way for more breakthroughs in understanding how subatomic particles interact with each other.

He has also done important work on black holes. Physicists had long known that these enigmatic cosmic beasts had entropy but could not explain its origins in their physical theories. Dr. Sen developed mathematical methods to make sense of a black hole's microscopic states in a way that could account for its observable, macroscopic characteristics.

Together, many physicists agree, his contributions have considerably advanced the theories physicists use to understand quantum gravity.

The Oskar Klein Medal and the accompanying Memorial Lectures was launched in 1988 to honour the Swedish physicist Oskar Klein (1894-1977). In 1926, Klein, building on the work of German mathematician Theodor Kaluza, explored whether electromagnetism and gravity could be described in a common framework by introducing an extra dimension of space. The result, known as Kaluza-Klein theory, exerted a significant influence on later attempts by physicists – including string theory – to unify these forces.

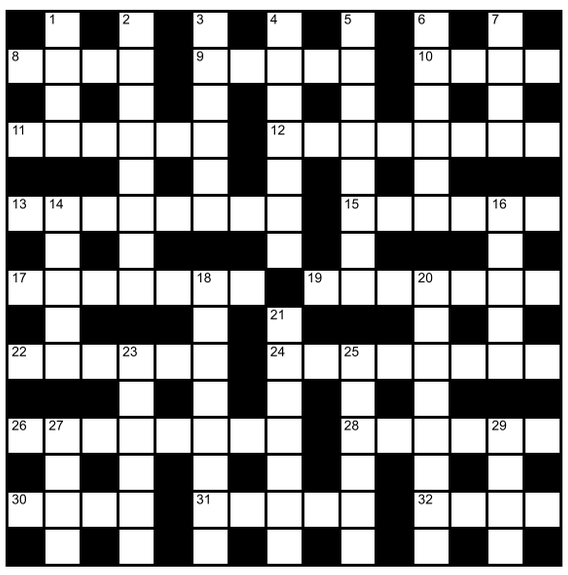
India in particular has an influential community of string theorists, especially at TIFR Mumbai, ICTS Bengaluru, HRI Prayagraj, and the Indian Institute of Science Education Research in Pune. Aside from Dr. Sen, the community's notable members include Nabamita Banerjee, Shiraz Minwalla, Sunil Mukhi, P. Ramadevi, and Spenta Wadia.

TH CROSSWORD + 14932

(set by Incognito)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

8/10 Meet, by accident, vagrant with piebald horse (4,4)
9 One shaping lawn is a relative by marriage (2-3)
10 See 8
11 Excited pooch carrying new garment (6)
12 Musical composition, that to some extent, is fake (8)
13 Mark goes around one premier tech institute and produces sword (8)
15 Come out, European, and join (6)
17 Movement from trains running on time (7)
19 Sinatra danced... He is skilled at his work... (7)
22 German father's wish (6)
24 Shake... shake own beaky facial feature (4,4)
26 Spring loaded hatch, perhaps, made from rotor pad (4,4)
28 Well known Hun expelling nob in battalion restructuring (6)
30 Honey... it's expensive! (4)
31 Girl with anchor is a spectral creature (5)
32 Robs drinking vessels (4)

Down

1 Small vehicle from Australia starts to teeter oddly (4)
2 Menaces horribly, capturing initially pacific astronauts (8)
3 Abstain from drink having iodine (3,3)
4 Erratic source around lake results in shutdown (7)
5 West, with armies, destroyed Bikini, for example (8)
6 Fruit from Chile, perhaps, with energy (6)
7 Hastening, carrying a gun (4)
14 Swear, "Dog's excited initially" (5)
16 Girl chased by running ants and other insects (5)
18 "Rock" handling equipment in bar (3,5)
20 Excitedly, I mention, "Immediately" (2,2,4)
21 Company possesses musical instrument and lightweight Indian bed (7)
23 Meaning get from another country (6)
25 Anger about one spirit (6)
27 Bird from Jaipur he aided (4)
29 Bingo's 11 pairs of supporters (4)

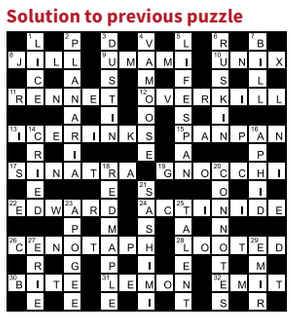
SUDOKU

5					7		9	
			6				1	7
		1				5	8	
		6		3				
	4		8		1		5	
				4		2		
	9	4				7		
1	2				5			
	6		3					1

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

No.SS7042 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

5	8	3	6	1	7	4	9	2
4	9	1	2	3	8	7	6	5
2	6	7	5	9	4	3	8	1
6	5	2	7	8	9	1	4	3
3	4	8	1	5	6	2	7	9
1	7	9	4	2	3	6	5	8
9	2	6	3	7	5	8	1	4
7	3	5	8	4	1	9	2	6
8	1	4	9	6	2	5	3	7

FAITH

Triumph of divine love

Sage Suka describes how Rukmini, the princess of Vidarbha (Kundinapura), is an incarnation of Mahalakshmi, who fell in love with Lord Krishna from her childhood purely by hearing tales of Krishna's virtues (gunas), beauty, and wisdom (noble exploits), said Tirukkudanthai Dr. Venkatesh in a discourse. Rukmini (Rukma means gold) is the daughter of King Bhishmaka, and she had five brothers. Bhishmaka approved of Krishna, but her elder brother Rukmi allied with Kamsa and Jarasandha and vehemently opposed the match. Rukmi arranged a forced marriage to his friend Shishupala, king of Cedhi kingdom and Lord Krishna's cousin. As wedding preparations began and Shishupala arrived, Rukmini realised she had no family support to stop the wedding and refused to accept anyone other than Krishna. She secretly entrusted an elderly and trustworthy person with a confidential letter, instructing him to deliver it quickly to Krishna and rescue her.

In cantos 12 and 13 of Swami Vedanta Desika's Yadavabhyudayam, the narrative of Rukmini's letter (Rukmini Patrika) and her subsequent rescue by Lord Krishna is presented through grand poetic imagery, philosophical allegories, and devotion (bhakti). In her letter, she asks why a jackal should steal a lion's prey, comparing Krishna to a lion and Shishupala to a jackal. Rukmini's letter embodies the concepts of complete surrender. Upon receiving the message, Krishna set off for Vidarbha in His chariot, arrived near the temple, killed Shishupala, defeated Rukmi, and prepared to slay him, but spared his life upon Rukmini's plea, and whisked her away to Dwaraka, where the grand wedding of Krishna and Rukmini took place.

India needs to train its clinical staff before erecting data shields

User data is routinely commoditised today, and passing a law assuming compliance and waiting for complaints or litigation will not suffice; as the DPDP Act comes into effect, the government must finance, build, and sustain an ecosystem that allows every health worker to comply and patients to be able to better access care

C. Aravinda

The recent conversation over the merchant discount rate on select UPI transactions raised the question of who pays for the digital convenience that millions of people enjoy. Hospitals may soon face a similar problem for strengthening their privacy even if no separate "privacy charge" appears on a patient's bill.

Protecting digital patient information will require secure systems, trained personnel, and continuous compliance. The Parliament enacted the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act 2023 in response to this need. The Act consists of 44 sections in nine chapters plus one Schedule. The government notified its Rules on November 13, 2025, with the Sections pertaining to provisions for consent managers set to kick in from November 13, 2026. The rest of the substantive obligations will start to apply from May 13, 2027.



The government should not expect every small hospital, diagnostic centre, and/or PHC to independently purchase the same privacy tools in order to enforce the DPDP Act. BERMIX STUDIO/UNSPLASH

Unusually difficult places

The Act is a general framework to protect digital personal data across sectors, including healthcare. In healthcare, the Act recognises that clinical consent and data consent are different. For example, persons agreeing to undergo a medical scan does not automatically mean they have agreed to every later use of the same scan, no matter how useful the hospital or doctors deem the scan data to be. While facilitating this distinction, the Act also makes room for data-processing during emergencies and specific medico-legal and public health situations.

Under the DPDP Act, the patient is the data principal (or owner) and the hospital – which usually decides why and how some information will be used – is the data fiduciary. Some external software, cloud, and/or data-processing company will serve as the data processor.

That said, hospitals are unusually difficult places in which to ensure compliance with a general data-protection law.

Unlike banks or regional transport offices, hospitals continuously create information of an intimate nature. For example, healthcare workers record a patient's clinical notes, nursing observations, diagnostics and laboratory results, ventilator readings, and prescriptions – all within hours.

At the same time, several professionals will need to access different parts of that record at different times. If access is too tightly controlled, patient care may suffer; on the other hand, unrestricted access can result in significant breaches of privacy. So the Act needs to facilitate the lawful processing of consent with reasonable security safeguards, grievance handling processes, and of course the correction or erasure of data where permissible.

Failure to take reasonable safeguards can attract a penalty of up to ₹250 crore.

Compliance costs

In the same vein, compliance requires hospital information systems with role-based access, facility to encrypt or mask data as necessary, systems to generate and preserve audit logs, backups, vendor contracts, breach response protocols, staff training, and a clearly identified person who is responsible for data governance.

Entities designated data fiduciaries must also appoint a statutory data protection officer, and smaller hospitals will need a privacy or data management lead in practice.

Further, information rarely stays within the hospital, since a cashless claim can send diagnoses and reports to an insurer or a third party administrator. Laboratories, radiology platforms, cloud vendors, and telemedicine services will create additional routes for the same record.

Even low-cost WhatsApp-based workflows that became popular because they were convenient will have to be examined for compliance and security.

Healthcare may therefore need specific DPDP provisions, either explicitly or eventually as a separate Act, to cover sector-specific uniqueness, such as small hospitals and large hospitals separately, as clinical care is more than a commercial transaction.

No uniform training

U.S. estimates show the cost of complying with the famed Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act, or HIPAA, to be around $5 per patient a year in 2008. Estimates for 2025 suggest the cost of $498 per affected record.

In a 2023 study, researchers from India and Norway estimated that adding an integrated information and communications system to an urban primary health centre (PHC) would expand the centre's annual economic budget by 17.7%. But when the researchers applied the same model across 400 PHCs, the incremental cost fell to about 6% per PHC. The reason: common development and infrastructure costs were shared.

The finding offers an important policy clue: the government should not expect every small hospital, diagnostic centre, and/or PHC to independently purchase the same privacy tools, legal templates, and so on.

That said, the harder problem is that India has legislated faster than it has trained the people who must make the law work. Medical education teaches confidentiality and ethics, but there is no uniform DPDP-oriented National Medical Commission curriculum or standard course materials that span medicine, nursing, allied health, hospital administration, and healthcare IT training. The vendor side faces the same problem: behind every software workflow is a human being who configures access, checks claims, handles support or views data. And an untrained person handling data in a hospital can pave the way for a major breach due so little as to one leaked password. So data literacy has to become a core healthcare competency.

Building an ecosystem

The National Health Accounts 2022-23 released this year estimated the out-of-pocket expenses on healthcare to be 43.4% of total health expenditure. There is a nontrivial chance that the new costs of complying with the DPDP Act will be passed on to patients as well.

Ahead of the November 13 date, the Indian government should step in by enabling a shared infrastructure through the Unified Health Interface of the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission. It could provide model consent and vendor agreements with affordable cybersecurity support, and healthcare-specific implementation standards.

User data is routinely commoditised today, and passing a law assuming compliance and waiting for complaints or litigation will not suffice. As the DPDP Act comes into effect, the government must finance, build, and sustain an ecosystem that allows every health worker to comply and patients to be able to better access care.

(Dr. C. Aravinda is an academic and public health physician. Views expressed here are personal.
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THE GIST

India's DPDP Act 2023 establishes a legal framework for protecting digital personal data, including health records; most obligations will take effect from May 13, 2027, while provisions relating to consent managers begin in November

The Act distinguishes between consent for medical treatment and consent for using personal health data; a patient's agreement to a procedure does not automatically permit all future uses of the resulting data

The law designates patients as data principals and hospitals as data fiduciaries, requiring secure processing, grievance redressal, and data correction or erasure mechanisms while ensuring healthcare delivery is not hindered by excessive access restrictions

BIG SHOT



Waves crash against a lighthouse at Newhaven Harbour during Storm Austen in Newhaven, Britain, October 23; a low-pressure front brought 179 km/hr winds and heavy rain across Europe overnight with over 3 lakh homes losing power, while airport and trains were delayed. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Molecular machines

Vasudevan Mukunth

A molecular machine is a combination of molecules that converts energy into motion, to perform specific tasks. These are sophisticated systems — and nature makes abundant use of them.

A famous example is the protein kinesin, which transports minerals inside our body's cells by moving on microscopic tracks; another example is the protein myosin, which helps muscles contract.

Scientists have also been building artificial molecular machines since the 1980s. Specifically, in 1983, the French chemist Jean-Pierre Sauvage and his team reported a way to connect two ring-shaped molecules the same way an axle connects the wheels of a car.

Eight years on, the British-American chemist Fraser Stoddart & co. built a molecular structure where a molecular ring could move along an axle. Together with the Dutch chemist Ben Feringa, who led a team that built a molecular motor that could be driven by light, Sauvage and Stoddart won the chemistry Nobel Prize in 2026 for their work.

Fun though they sound, molecular machines are also quite finicky. At the scale of a molecule, random heat constantly jostles the structures, rendering their movements unpredictable. A molecule may also rotate or change its own position without moving anything else, presenting another challenge that comes in the way of coordinating multiple molecules.

The protein kinesin (red) attaches to and moves along microtubules (blue-green). KADEN.RAWSON, MARISAASADIAN, STEVENGPARKIN (CC BY-SA)

But there have been advances apace. On October 22, for example, researchers reported in *Nature* that they had built a corkscrew-shaped molecule that, when suspended two electrodes, could cycle through a series of states when the current flowed one way and in the reverse direction when the current flowed the other way.

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New avenues

India and Poland have no conflict, but are pulled apart by other nations

Sixteen years after his visit as Poland's Prime Minister, Donald Tusk's travel to Delhi and Bengaluru last week was to signal a renewed desire to work closely with India. Mr. Tusk's visit, two months ahead of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's trip to Brussels to sign the India-European Union (EU) Free Trade Agreement, indicated one part of his agenda. Both sides agreed that it was time to develop trade, currently worth just $6 billion, to double its size by 2030. Mr. Tusk's last visit to India was in 2017, as President of the European Council for the EU-India summit, and it is fitting that his trip was just as the FTA is finalised and ratified after years of delays. Another area of increased India-Poland collaboration is in technology, AI and defence hardware, critical minerals, renewable and nuclear energy given Poland's expertise in the last few decades and India's capacity for scale. As the EU's sixth largest economy, Poland has officially crossed the $1 trillion GDP (nominal terms) milestone. Its $120-billion-dollar tech economy is also gaining global interest. A large part of Polish machinery and parts is exported to Germany, which in turn has a growing share of Indian imports, and India could consider more trilateral collaborations for manufacturing and mining technology. The two sides agreed to establish a "Defence Industry Dialogue" and explore a dialogue on counter-terrorism cooperation. Finally, the Modi-Tusk talks focused on geopolitics, particularly the ongoing war in Ukraine. The war's impact, especially on the Global South, has been a concern for India, and the Modi government's initiative to work on an agreement acceptable to Kyiv and Moscow on grain exports and seafarers' safety was discussed. The four-pronged plan, announced by External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar during his September visit to Warsaw, won Mr. Tusk's support.

At the India-Poland Business Forum in Bengaluru, Mr. Tusk, who was accompanied by a Polish business delegation, said the challenge now was in "translating" the talks and MoUs signed into actual joint ventures between businesses. Apart from the distance and geographies, there is the matter of trust, given India's defence engagement with Russia and Poland's defence ties with Pakistan. Poland is credited with training Pakistan's Air Force in its early years; a mutual defence cooperation agreement was signed in 2018. India has a unique and enduring partnership with Russia, and New Delhi is unlikely to accept Warsaw's strictures over its military engagement and exercises with Russia that caused a controversy earlier this year during the Polish Foreign Minister's visit. It is essential for Delhi and Warsaw to complete the confidentiality of classified information that is still being negotiated and draw up the parameters of future cooperation based on realities. Mr. Tusk's statement that India and Poland today have no "conflicts of interest" is a significant aspiration, for two countries that share old values, and new avenues of partnership.

Wicked surprise

Northeast monsoon is more unpredictable, and south must be wary

As India recovers from a monsoon-deficit year, there is both hope and trepidation regarding the prospects for that 'other monsoon', or the 'northeast monsoon'. While contributing only around a quarter of India's annual rainfall, it is largely focused on the south-east peninsula regions of Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, coastal Andhra Pradesh, Rayalaseema, south interior Karnataka and Keralam. The southwest monsoon, influenced by a strengthening El Niño, has already left its desiccating mark. Rainfall from June-September was 759.4 mm against 868.6 mm, a 12.6% deficit, the driest in 11 years. This has impacted *kharif* sowing and is reflected in food inflation.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has said that this year, the northeast monsoon rainfall, spanning October to December, would likely be 'normal,' meaning in line with a 50-year average and within a 12% error window. Most parts of the country, it said, are expected to receive below-normal rainfall, except some areas of northwest India and southern parts of peninsular India, where rainfall is likely to be normal to above-normal. The wide error window, however, is far less precise than its forecasts for the southwest monsoon with its margin of 5%, and can sometimes make the northeast monsoon the bearer of nasty surprises. For instance, December 1, 2015, saw the city of Chennai deluged by its heaviest rainfall in 24-hours in over a century; at least 500 lives were lost and 18 lakh people displaced in the State. That year and the present are linked by a common thread: a powerful El Niño. Associated with the heating up of the Central Pacific, the El Niño is linked to the drying up of the southwest monsoon rains but also yoked – not always – with a vigorous northeast monsoon. Other than in 2015, several El Niño years, such as 1997 and 2009, have been associated with above-normal rainfall between October and December in Tamil Nadu though El Niño years, such as 2002 and 1982, saw a poor northeast monsoon (and a predictably bad southwest monsoon). While the climate mechanisms linking a vigorous northeast monsoon and El Niño are still to be fully understood, it appears the warming patterns of the El Niño tend to deflect rain-bearing cyclonic circulations in unpredictable ways. Therefore, the Centre and the southern States ought to take enough precautions: from clearing up stormwater drains, fortifying shelters, making provisions for infrastructure damage and tightening weather warning forecasts to prepare for torrents.

Jantar Mantar to 'Dilli Chalo', protest challenges power



Zoya Hasan

Professor Emerita, Centre for Political Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University

Over the past few months, three distinct streams of dissent have emerged in India: the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)-led agitation, actions by left-wing student organisations, and campaigns spearheaded by the Congress and the INDIA bloc. Although these streams have largely evolved independently, their paths have increasingly converged around shared concerns about democracy, dissent, citizens' rights and the fairness of the political and electoral process. Their significance lies in their capacity to bring disparate grievances and constituencies together in a broader challenge to the government.

Dissent finds new voices

The first phase of the agitation unfolded at Jantar Mantar in June and July, focusing on education reform, the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) paper leaks and demands for the (then) Education Minister's resignation. The CJP played a pivotal role in galvanising public discontent, drawing large numbers of young people into the streets, where they articulated their grievances through a distinctive blend of humour, creativity and youthful energy. This indicated that dissatisfaction with the ruling establishment extended well beyond the established Opposition parties, with the political disaffection of this constituency having been seriously underestimated. The Minister's eventual resignation gave the movement fresh impetus, demonstrating that sustained public pressure could secure political concessions.

On Gandhi Jayanti, Opposition parties, student groups and civil society activists took to the streets, demanding the Chief Election Commissioner's (CEC) resignation over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. Mobile Internet services were suspended around Jantar Mantar, gates at a number of Metro stations were closed, and more than 700 protesters were detained in the vicinity by the police. The CJP's call for a protest at Jantar Mantar 2.0 on October 10 met with an even heavier crackdown. A massive deployment of police and paramilitary forces brought much of the capital to a near standstill, effectively preventing the gathering from taking place. Two days later, thousands gathered in central Delhi for the unprecedented 'Dilli Chalo' march, led by Leader of the Opposition (Lok Sabha) Rahul Gandhi, Congress and prominent INDIA bloc leaders.

The contrast was telling. While the 'Dilli Chalo' march showed the Congress's capacity to draw large crowds onto the streets, the CJP's calls brought youth discontent into sharper public focus. For Mr. Gandhi, this offered an opportunity to unite various concerns and channel them towards a more focused political agenda. The Jantar Mantar uprising created new political space outside parties. Its most significant contribution was to break the climate of fear. The mass protest demonstrated the ability of established Opposition parties, particularly the Congress, to consolidate concerns over electoral integrity, institutional accountability and the right to protest into a broader political challenge to the government. While movements can mobilise people and articulate dissent, parties provide the organisational means to sustain it and translate it into political action. Neither form of collective action is sufficient on its own. Ultimately, political change depends on parties being able to turn mass mobilisation into a sustained challenge to those in power.

Disparate protest movements are converging over shared concerns about democracy and accountability

At the heart of this public upsurge is a widening struggle over the sanctity of the vote, a cornerstone of democracy. By early September 2026, the exercise had resulted in the exclusion of 13.37 crore names from draft electoral rolls across 30 States and Union Territories – equivalent to 14.1% of the pre-SIR electorate – raising concerns about the possible disenfranchisement of eligible voters. The central question is whether the revision is transparent, verifiable and subject to adequate safeguards against arbitrary exclusion, particularly given concerns about the reliability of the procedures and centralised software used to remove names.

The protest, accompanied by a petition to the Supreme Court of India seeking an investigation, an audit of voter deletions, safeguards against arbitrary exclusion and suspension of the process, underscored the political force of a convergence between mass participation, Opposition mobilisation and legal action. The petition also put the judiciary to the test, challenging it to protect constitutional rights through judicial review rather than allow executive decisions to evade scrutiny.

The ECI's independence had already been questioned following the enactment of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, which excluded the Chief Justice of India from the panel appointing Election Commissioners (ECs) and provided immunity from civil and criminal proceedings for acts undertaken in the discharge of official duties. Reports of disagreements among the ECs over unilateral decisions taken by the CEC further fuelled questions about the ECI's functioning. These doubts intensified opposition to SIR, adding a new dimension to the challenge by linking electoral administration to democratic accountability.

The issue of electoral fairness

Thousands have taken to the streets, protesting the voter-list overhaul and raising concerns over the ECI's constitutional obligation to act impartially. Gathering momentum since early October, the protests signal a significant shift in Opposition politics. The demand for scrapping SIR and the CEC's resignation, once unthinkable, has emerged as a rallying point of protests. It has also brought the contest over electoral fairness beyond the institutional arenas of Parliament and the courts and onto the streets. When eligible citizens are excluded from voter rolls without adequate safeguards or effective remedies, the conduct of elections alone cannot guarantee democratic legitimacy. These concerns have raised the spectre of a shift from electoral democracy towards electoral autocracy, underscoring the extent of democratic backsliding in the country.

The vulnerability of power

The current political moment exposes the vulnerabilities beneath the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)'s dominance, as growing public resentment begins to test its hold on power. The BJP's failure to secure a parliamentary majority in the 2024 general election had already dented its aura of invincibility. Meanwhile, the government's efforts to reshape the electoral architecture through multiple mechanisms have fuelled concerns that it seeks to institutionalise a permanent majority and forestall a recurrence of its electoral setback.

Unable to offer political solutions, the government has instead deployed its coercive powers to quell dissent, particularly among the youth. Such measures, however, cannot obscure deeper concerns over the erosion of the constitutionally guaranteed right to vote. Nor can the government deflect scrutiny by accusing the Opposition, the CJP or left-wing groups of fomenting anarchy or conspiring to bring down the regime. Such allegations of regime change – which simply means transition of power through elections – are especially unconvincing given the BJP's own record of pursuing regime change of governments whose policies, programmes and practices it opposed.

By resorting to repression, the government has exposed the limits of its political dominance and sharpened the disconnect between the young and the ruling party, as well as eroded trust in the institutions it controls. In short, it is losing the plot. The larger democratic stakes are clear: this is ultimately a fight over the foundation of democracy itself – the right to vote. Although these developments have yet to produce a new political alignment, they have widened the space for dissent and intensified scrutiny of the concentration of executive power. Most strikingly, the ECI has come to be seen as a proxy for the executive, with doubts about its impartiality sharpening broader concerns about executive overreach and the erosion of institutional autonomy.

The challenge now is to convert this heightened public scrutiny into a sustained political check on right-wing dominance. The central question is whether this wave of public dissent over the electoral process can connect with wider popular resentments over the education system, unemployment and rising prices, and translate them into political change. That remains to be seen.

U.S. immigration restrictions may outlast Trump



Abhishek Kadiyala

Research Analyst, Geostrategy Programme, Takshashila Institution

In its second term, the Donald Trump administration has been active in restricting legal immigration to the United States. The administration's attempt to impose a $100,000 payment requirement on certain new H-1B petitions, changes to visa renewal procedures, the introduction of a wage-weighted selection system, and the latest suspensions of the Program Electronic Review Management (PERM) process are cases in point, disproportionately impacting Indian immigrants and firms.

It is tempting to read these developments as a product of the Trump administration alone, but they reflect deeper political interests that are likely to survive post-Trump. Indian nationals account for 70% of H-1B visa approvals, with one-fifth of the visas going to employees of Indian-origin companies. This means that, as the bipartisan focus on immigration reform continues, the issue is likely to sustain as a friction point in India-U.S. relations.

The views of the Democrats and Republicans

Democrats are expected to dominate the upcoming midterm elections in November. They view immigration through a rights-based lens, and their voters remain supportive of both legal immigration and increased legalisation of undocumented immigrants. Some 75% of Democrats see skilled immigration as good for the U.S., compared with 54% of Republicans. Even under the current administration, Democrats have pushed for easing F-1 student visa requirements and have traditionally enjoyed the support of diaspora communities in the U.S., including the Indian diaspora.

However, prominent Democratic Senators such as Dick Durbin and Richard Blumenthal, as well as progressive Independents such as Bernie Sanders, have also pushed for bills seeking H-1B reforms. Democrats view alleged fraud in the H-1B visa system as a serious challenge that needs to be addressed. Similarly, the labour wing of the Democratic Party views the H-1B visa programme as a potential threat to domestic labour protections and workers' rights. The Democrats' immigrant voter base, their open opposition to the H-1B visa fee hikes, and resistance to these restrictions from businesses and unions suggest that a Democratic-controlled Congress may soften the harshest executive measures and tone down the rhetoric. However, concerns about visa fraud and worker protections mean that Democrats are likely to keep up the pressure on the outsourcing model and continue pushing for H-1B reforms.

With both the Republicans and Democrats committed to immigration reform, India faces continued uncertainty

While a plurality of Republicans support restrictions on legal immigration, this number has declined considerably since 2025. Among the Republican leadership, there is a visible split between anti-immigration nationalists and pro-immigration business interests. The Trump administration's hikes in the H-1B visa fee is an example of this conflict. While the administration was openly critical of the programme and aggressively pushed for the fee increase, it subsequently diluted the measure by including exemptions for graduates of U.S. universities and existing visa holders, following pressure from businesses and universities.

The business divide

The debate over wage-weighted entries versus the lottery system for H-1B visas has dominated discussions on immigration within the U.S. business community. There are three broad categories in this debate. The first is the random lottery system that was in place until 2026, which benefited outsourcing firms and start-ups. The second is the wage-weighted lottery system (February 2026), which infers wage levels based on experience, job role and location, dividing visa quotas into four categories. On the surface, this system might benefit big-tech firms, but it could also benefit outsourcing firms that hire highly experienced workers for lower wages. The third is the actual wage weighted lottery model, which is supported by U.S.-based industries. This approach could dilute the advantages enjoyed by outsourcing firms while benefiting American hires and also F1 student hires.

For the artificial intelligence (AI) and big-tech business community, this reform could be beneficial in two ways. First, AI graduate programmes and advanced research roles in the U.S. rely heavily on international talent, with demand for AI skills growing faster than the supply of domestic graduates. The reform could therefore help AI firms secure top international talent for higher wages.

Second, the AI sector is expanding into market segments traditionally occupied by start-ups and outsourcing companies, which often perform low technology maintenance and communication roles. The AI sector could therefore benefit if these start-ups and outsourcing firms were compelled to hire fewer workers. With the AI sector playing a prominent role in campaign contributions for the 2026 midterm elections, these policies to counter outsourcing firms are likely to continue. With over 54% of India's software services exports going to the U.S., which remains the top market for Indian information technology (IT) outsourcing, this represents a major challenge for India. However, these developments could also be viewed as positive news for Indian students at U.S. universities.

Looking ahead

The U.S. Department of Labor's suspension of eight firms, including not only Indian outsourcing companies such as Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services and Wipro but also major technology firms such as Microsoft and Adobe, from green card sponsorship reinforces this trend. It raises the cost of hiring foreign workers for businesses as a whole, creating pressure that remains largely beyond partisan control.

With Mr. Trump's political power potentially diminished after November, anti-immigration rhetoric could decline. However, with both parties committed to immigration reform, India should continue to expect an unfavourable and unpredictable immigration landscape.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Red alert, blue skies

The accuracy of meteorological forecasts for Tamil Nadu, especially regarding rainfall and storms in the Bay of Bengal during the monsoon season, seems to miss the mark. A recent case was the 'red alert' issued for the southern districts of Kanniyakumari and Tirunelveli. In anticipation of potential devastation, the District Collectors declared a holiday for all educational institutions. Fortunately, we experienced bright sunshine instead. However, this required educational institutions to conduct compensatory classes the following Saturday. While the administration must prioritise safety, the frequent discrepancy between official forecasts and actual weather conditions creates unnecessary disruption. Interestingly, independent private weather bloggers often provide more accurate localised forecasts.

Rajakumar Arulanandham,
Palayamkottai, Tamil Nadu

Vaulting to new heights

It was inspiring to read the report about 19-year-old Chuki Birda from Rajasthan, who has set a national pole vault record at the 41st National junior athletics championships in Chennai ('Sport' page, October 25). Such stories deserve wider attention given the discrimination girls still face in parts of India.

M.N. Saraswathi Devi,
Secunderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Lessons on the right to assembly



Thulasi K. Raj

Lawyer at the Supreme Court of India

Lately, the streets of Delhi have been tense with protests against the Central government. The large-scale exclusion of voters in the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) has led to protesters demanding the resignation of Gyanesh Kumar, the Chief Election Commissioner. The government responded with a heavy hand, deploying police and military personnel. This has led to questions regarding suppression of protests and how it offends the constitutional rights to expression and assembly.

The right to dissent and protest is integral to any liberal democracy. Holding rallies and demonstrations have a rich legacy in India, traceable back not only to the independence movement, but also to agitations by trade unions, farmers, social activists, and many more.

Unfortunately, over the past years, one has increasingly observed the emergence of a culture of suspicion. The sentiment –popular among the right-wing – of distrusting any disagreement with the government has a pre-democratic character. The immediate questions regarding 'permission' for protests, or 'funding' of the protesters is predicated on this view. It refuses to see citizens as autonomous agents with a right to protest for what they believe in. It considers the state as the provider of resources and citizens as passive recipients. The heart of the constitutional right to protest lies in not treating protesters with suspicion.

Article 19(1)(a) guarantees all citizens the right to free speech and expression and Article 19(1)(b), the right to assemble peaceably without arms. Fundamental rights operate as limits on state action. In any democracy, there is tension between the exercise of rights and the state's authority. Hence, any restriction on the right to assembly must be subject to Article 19(3). It says that the state can make a law in the interests of sovereignty and integrity or public order, and impose reasonable restrictions. Here, we see a fundamental gap between the liberal state's constitutional spirit and an executive that constraints this right. First, there is a disproportionate invocation of preventive laws. For instance, Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023 was invoked in the capital immediately before the protests. This law is inherently problematic as it gives wide discretion to the executive to direct the removal of persons to prevent the disturbance of public tranquillity, among other grounds. This is coupled with a disproportionate use of force on peaceful protesters, long detentions without disclosing whereabouts, preventing access to lawyers or necessities, and issuance of deportation notices to Overseas Citizens of India who participate in the protest. The government routinely creates a chilling effect on freedoms of speech and assembly.

As stated by the Supreme Court in *Himmat Lal vs Commissioner of Police* (1972), reasonable regulation of assembly is different from arbitrary exclusion. While reasonable 'time, place and manner' restrictions can be imposed, the top court said that if the state ..."can constitutionally close both its streets and its parks entirely to public meetings, the practical result would be that it would be impossible to hold any open-air meetings in any large city." It cautioned that state monopoly on public places cannot defeat the right to assembly. Unfortunately, when the constitutional validity of the predecessor provision of Section 163 of the BNSS was challenged, the court in *Babulal Parate vs State of Maharashtra* (1961) refused to interfere. But it said that the provision is 'attracted only in emergencies.'

Designating protest sites

If any meaningful right to assembly is to exist, public places must be easily accessible and available. This is why the denotification of Jantar Mantar as a protest site assumes serious relevance. Moving protests to distant areas renders the purpose of protests meaningless.

On October 9, when the top court heard petitions challenging the blanket transport ban to Delhi, the court directed that 'suitable alternative sites' for protest must be designated. When the Delhi High Court was met with the denotification challenge, the Additional Solicitor General informed the court that that this was pursuant to the Supreme Court's earlier order.

Crucially, no interim orders were passed by the top court in the cases challenging denotification. Thus, Jantar Mantar remains inaccessible as a protest site. The court must reconsider extending legitimacy to a government that strips the people's right to assembly. It must aspire to close the gap between constitutionalism that prioritises the right to assembly and conservatism which does not.

If any meaningful right to assembly is to exist, public places must be easily accessible and available. Moving protests to distant areas renders the purpose of protests meaningless

The need for a national media council



Rakesh Goswami

Professor of Journalism at Indian Institute of Mass Communication, New Delhi

The recent protests called by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), and helmed by Opposition parties, demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar have exposed a chink in journalists' armour. The crackdown on journalists, especially freelancers and independent journalists, during the October 10 protests, has rekindled the debate on who has the right to be recognised as a journalist and about who decides who is a journalist.

One has seen how during the CJP protests, both in July over the NEET paper leak and in October over the demand for the CEC's removal, freelancers and independent journalists, and content creators descended in hordes at the protest venue already bulging at the seams with reporters from registered media houses. However, during the second round of protests on October 10, phalanxes of riot police removed them from the protest site and sent them to detention centres. Only journalists with the Press Information Bureau (PIB) or Directorate of Information and Publicity (DIP) accreditation were allowed to cover the protests.

A Bench comprising Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi, while hearing a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) which seeks the protection of the right to freedom of expression by freelance journalists and content creators, wondered whether the right to freedom of expression empowered every citizen of this country to be a journalist. "If everyone starts becoming a journalist, it will create problems for every other person," the CJI said. During the hearing, senior advocate Indira Jaisingh said that there must be a national protocol for police not to obstruct the professional work of any journalist who has an identity card from the employer. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta said that in the present era, any person with a mobile phone could claim to be an independent or freelance journalist when he/she would, in fact, be making reels only to garner popularity on social media to earn money by either presenting one-sided stories or sensationalising events.

Recognising journalists

These developments have put the focus back on the question of who recognises journalists. As per the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions Code, 2020, a working journalist is a person whose principal avocation is journalism and who is employed in a newspaper, electronic media or digital media. This definition excludes people employed in a managerial or administrative capacity. Further, Central and State governments provide accreditation to working journalists, freelance journalists, camerapersons and technicians. Accreditation recognises working journalists and others and gives them access to designated official sources of information. For journalists in Delhi-NCR, accreditation is provided by the PIB for covering the Central government while the DIP accreditation gives them the right to cover the Delhi State government. Media accreditation guidelines of the PIB and DIP define the eligibility criteria for all those seeking accreditation. However, one of the major issues with government accreditation is that it has a quota depending upon circulation (for newspapers, periodicals and magazines), subscribers (for news agencies), licence under uplinking and downlinking guidelines (for private satellite TV channels), and unique visitors (for digital news publishers). Therefore, all journalists in recognised media organisations don't get accreditation. This leads us to the question on how all working journalists can be recognised.

Just like there is the Bar Council of India for lawyers and an Institute of Chartered Accountants of India for chartered accountants, the media council can recognise all working journalists, freelance journalists, camerapersons and technicians

One solution could be a national media council or commission. Just like there is the Bar Council of India for lawyers and an Institute of Chartered Accountants of India for chartered accountants, the media council can recognise all working journalists, freelance journalists, camerapersons and technicians. Just like you need a law degree to practise law, a medical degree to become a doctor, the media council may mandate a degree or diploma in journalism and mass communication while applying for a licence.

A few years ago, the Press Club of India drafted a Media Transparency (and Accountability) Bill, which mandated the formation of a national media council, among other things. Recently, some other journalists' bodies have also submitted a memorandum to the government with the same demand. As more and more people with a camera claim to be freelance journalists, it may be high time for the government to give some serious thought to the idea of such a council.

Free bus travel has given women more mobility

The Time Use Survey data from 2019 and 2024 show that women's travel went up in four States that offer free bus rides to women

DATA POINT

Sravani Venkatraju

Between 2021 and 2024, four States made travel in ordinary government buses free for women. Punjab and Tamil Nadu introduced the scheme in 2021, Karnataka followed in June 2023 and Telangana in December 2023. Such schemes are expected to help women reach jobs, colleges and hospitals more easily.

The National Statistics Office (NSO) has conducted two all-India Time Use Surveys, one through 2019 and another through 2024, in which about 4.5 lakh persons in each round reported how they spent every half hour of a day. The two can be compared to see whether women are now moving out of their homes more often.

Analysing movement

In the four States, the share of women aged 15-59 who made at least one trip on the survey day went up from 38.7% in 2019 to 45.3% in 2024, an increase of 6.6 percentage points, while for men the increase was 3.7 points **(Table 1)**. In the 12 other large States that were studied, it was the other way round, as women's travel went up by 4.4 points and men's by 7.6 points.

Telangana and Andhra Pradesh, which were one State till 2014, offer a useful comparison. Telangana's Mahalakshmi scheme started in December 2023, but Andhra Pradesh's Stree Shakti scheme came only in August 2025, after the 2024 survey was over. In 2019, 43.7% of women in Telangana and 40.8% in Andhra Pradesh had made a trip on the survey day. By 2024, this had gone up to 54.6% in Telangana, while in Andhra Pradesh it stayed almost the same at 41.6%.

Since travel went up in almost every State after the pandemic years, it is more useful to check whether women's travel grew faster than men's within the same State. This was the case in all four free-bus States **(Chart 1)**.

In most States without free buses, including Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh, women's travel grew slower than men's, and Bihar was the only clear exception.

Women's travel in the four States grew about six percentage points more than in the other States, which is well beyond the survey's margin of error.

More reason to step out

The survey also records the purpose of each trip. The share of women who travelled for paid work went up by 2.3 points in the free-bus States and by 1.2 points in the others. The biggest change was in trips made for care, such as dropping children at school or taking a family member to the hospital, which nearly tripled in the free-bus States **(Table 2)**. Trips for social, religious and leisure purposes also increased in the free-bus States, but remained the same in the others.

In the free-bus States, the share of women who were travelling went up the most around 9 a.m. and 6 p.m., but there was also an increase in the late morning and afternoon travels, which are not usual office hours and are more likely to be the time for care and household work **(Chart 2)**.

The time of these trips tells a similar story. However, the data do not show a similar rise in paid work so far. The share of women aged 15-59 who did any paid work on the survey day rose from 30.5% to 34.4% in the free-bus States, which is about four points, but in the other States it rose slightly more, from 18.4% to 22.9%. This suggests that free buses have made it easier for women to step out of their homes, but getting a job depends on other things as well, such as whether there is work nearby, whether childcare is available and whether the journey is safe.

Going the distance

The data were sourced from the National Statistics Office's Time Use Survey for the years 2019 and 2024. The author is a II Year student of the MA in Cities and Governance programme at Tata Institute of Social Sciences, Hyderabad

Punjab, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, and Karnataka made travel free for women in select bus services between the two surveys



All aboard: Working women in the State travel free of cost in government-owned buses in Chennai.

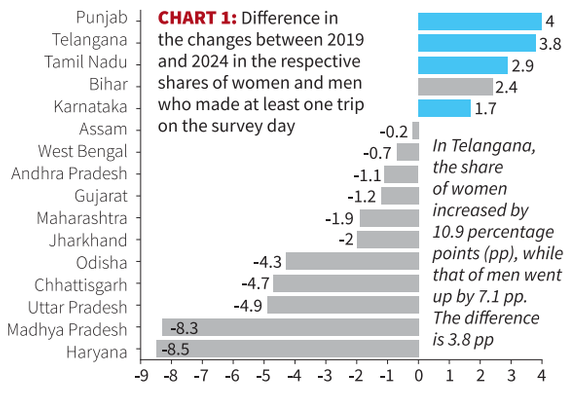


CHART 1: Difference in the changes between 2019 and 2024 in the respective shares of women and men who made at least one trip on the survey day

TABLE 1: Share of women aged **15-59** who made at least one trip on the survey day, and the changes for women and men

State	Free bus since	Women 2019 (%)	Women 2024 (%)	Change, women (pp)	Change, men (pp)
Telangana	Dec 2023	43.7	54.6	10.9	7.1
Tamil Nadu	2021	43.8	50.6	6.7	3.8
Karnataka	Jun 2023	36.6	41.5	5	3.2
Punjab	Apr 2021	22.5	26.6	4.1	0.1
All free-bus States	–	**38.7**	**45.3**	**6.6**	**3.7**
Andhra Pradesh	Aug 2025*	40.8	41.6	0.8	1.9
Other States**	None	23.9	28.3	4.4	7.6

***The 12 States listed in Chart 1 that were taken for comparison including Andhra Pradesh*
**Andhra Pradesh's scheme began after the 2024 survey ended*

CHART 2: The rise in the share of women travelling in free-bus States in each hour of the day

The share of women who were travelling went up the most around 9 a.m. and 6 p.m

There was also an increase in the share of women during noon, which are not usual work hours

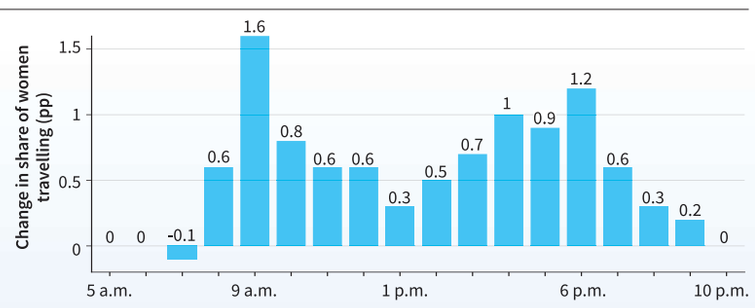


TABLE 2: Share of women aged **15-59** who made a trip for different purposes on the survey day (in %)

Purpose of trip	Free-bus States 2019	Free-bus States 2024	Other States 2019	Other States 2024
Paid work	22.4	24.7	11.7	12.9
Household errands	3.9	5.2	2.9	4.3
Care (school, hospital)	0.9	2.6	0.6	1.2
Study	7.8	8	6.3	6.8
Social, religious, leisure	6.4	7.6	4.5	4.5



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 26, 1976

Chinese herb medicine cures cancer

Tokyo, October 25: A Chinese herb medicine preparation claimed to be remarkably effective against cancer has been developed by scientists at Osaka University and Kink University's Oriental Medicine Research Institute.

The preparation, composed of about 30 kinds of herbal medicines, produces comparatively little of the adverse effects generally noted in cancer-arresting drugs. Patients suffering from breast, abdominal, rectal and uterine cancer showed marked improvement when given the herb medicine, the researchers said. The preparation is based on recipes listed in an ancient book of Chinese medicine and said to be effective for breast and skin cancer. The formula was worked out after performing animal tests for a three-year period. Experiments had been conducted since 1974 on advanced cancer cases treated at the hospitals attached to the two universities. Nine out of 13 cases administered the preparation made good progress and one person was able to resume a normal life even though rectal cancer had recurred and spread.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 26, 1926

The Indian civil service

Simla, October 25: The following Press Communique is issued: In accordance with the recommendation of the Lee Commission, direct recruits to the Indian Civil Service are now being selected in equal numbers from Europeans and Indians. For the purpose of calculation, London examination of one year and Allahabad examination and nominations of the next year are taken together as forming one year. In the year 1925-26, i.e. London examination of 1926 and Allahabad examination and nominations of 1925, numbers actually recruited were 20 Europeans and 22 Indians. These figures are being adjusted in the year 1926-27 by recruiting 29 Europeans and 27 Indians. The London examination of 1926 has yielded 19 Europeans and 11 Indians. This leaves 16 Indians to be recruited in India in 1927 through examination and nomination. Nine of these vacancies are definitely offered for open competition of the Allahabad examination to be held in January next, while the remaining seven are for the present held in reserve to be filled by nomination.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Hike in compensation for wildlife attack deaths and disabilities

25 in per cent. The Keralam government on Sunday announced a 25% hike in compensation for deaths and permanent disabilities caused by wildlife attacks, along with enhanced medical assistance for the injured. Giving details of the revised financial assistance, the government said compensation for deaths had been increased from ₹14 lakh to ₹17.5 lakh. PTI

Adulterated food destroyed by Food Safety Department

922 kg. The Delhi government's Food Safety Department has destroyed 922 kg of adulterated food items during inspections at sweet-making units in Nihal Vihar and a khoya market in Mori Gate ahead of the festive season, officials said on Sunday. CM Rekha Gupta said the department had been directed to continue surprise inspections. PTI

Number of arrests made in France protests by police

1,314 Police arrested 1,314 people in weekend protests across France, the Interior Ministry said on Sunday, adding that 53 officers were hurt in clashes. The arrests occurred as violence broke out on the margins of mass demonstrations in major cities on Saturday over the high cost of living. It was the second consecutive weekend of unrest. AFP

Number of personnel accused of financial irregularities in MP

392 A total of 392 personnel are under the scanner in Madhya Pradesh for alleged financial irregularities, with seven dismissed from service, a senior official said on Sunday. Urban Development and Housing Department Additional Chief Secretary Sanjay Dubey said that action had been taken against 146 officials in connection with these irregularities. PTI

Overnight arrests made by Spanish Police in Barcelona

128 Police made 128 arrests overnight in Barcelona for acts of "vandalism", damage to public property" and "looting", the regional Catalan Police said on Sunday. Seventy-three of those arrested were minors, with the reports due to be sent "to the juvenile prosecutor's office", Catalan Police chief Silvia Cata said. AFP

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Where should judicial restraint begin?

Justice Ujjal Bhuyan's remarks on voter deletions have revived debate over judicial propriety and comments on pending cases; while his emphasis on voting rights and procedural safeguards aligns with existing rulings, his statement against mass disenfranchisement raises questions about limits of judicial speech

LETTER & SPIRIT

V. Venkatesan

In July 2018, Justice Ranjan Gogoi, months before becoming Chief Justice of India, said democracy sometimes needed "noisy judges", alongside independent journalists. Eight years later, that judicial voice has become contentious.

On October 4, Justice Ujjal Bhuyan, delivering the valedictory address at a moot court competition at NALSAR University of Law, said the right to vote was constitutional and integral to the basic structure. A process disenfranchising millions, he said, would be intrinsically arbitrary and violate Articles 14 and 326; Article 326 "cannot be tinkered with", and "no court can condone" mass disenfranchisement. Citing Section 22 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, he stressed the need for notice and a hearing before deletion, except in the case of death.

Former Chief Justice of India B.R. Gavai objected that "judicial propriety" did not permit a sitting judge to comment on a sub judice matter. Former Delhi High Court judges S.N. Dhingra and R.S. Sodhi expressed similar concerns, with Justice Sodhi stressing the statutory framework governing voting rights.

The day after Justice Bhuyan spoke, Justice Vikram Nath, the senior-most puisne judge in the Supreme Court, delivered a lecture in Delhi. "Impartiality and indifference are not the same thing," he said. A judge must be impartial, but need not be insensible to the human consequences of law, he observed. Where is the line between an engaged judge and one who has said too much?



GETTY IMAGES

What does the Indian code require?

The starting point is the Restatement of Values of Judicial Life, adopted by the Full Court of the Supreme Court on May 7, 1997. Clause 8 says a judge shall neither enter public debate nor express views on political matters "or on matters that are pending or are likely to arise for judicial determination". Clause 1 requires conduct sustaining public faith in judicial impartiality. The Restatement carries no sanction of its own, but has been reproduced and relied upon in judicial decisions.

When Justice Bhuyan addressed NALSAR, litigation arising from the West Bengal SIR remained before the Supreme Court. More than 22 lakh deleted voters had appealed for restoration, the Election Commission of India told the court, and related matters were due on October 5. Justice Bhuyan neither named the SIR nor sat on those Benches.

But did Justice Bhuyan state something the court had not already held?

Here the criticism requires qualification. On May 27, 2026, a Bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant upheld the Bihar SIR in *Association for Democratic Reforms v Election Commission of India*. The court described the right to vote as constitutional, though neither absolute nor unregulated, and said Articles 325 and 326 require inclusion of eligible electors and exclusion of ineligible persons. Rule 21A of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, it added, requires notice, inquiry, hearing and a reasoned determination before deletion.

Justice Bhuyan was therefore on established ground in describing voting as constitutional and stressing a hearing before deletion. The more debatable part was his proposition that a process disenfranchising millions would be intrinsically arbitrary and that no court could condone it. Yet the proposition was conditional and did not decide whether a particular SIR produces that result. The issue turns on how closely those words approached an answer to a live controversy.

Must judges remain silent on questions of public importance?

Comparative standards draw a more calibrated boundary. The commentary on the Bangalore Principles of Judicial Conduct recognises judicial freedom of expression on legal education, judicial independence and court administration. Principle 2.4 restrains comment that might reasonably affect a proceeding before, or capable of coming before, the judge, while Principle 4.11 allows judges to write, lecture and teach on law and the administration of justice.

The U.S. Supreme Court's 2023 Code of Conduct permits Justices to speak, write, lecture and teach, but asks them to refrain from commenting on the merits of a pending or impending matter. For scholarly or educational purposes, they may describe the issues involved. The distinction is between explaining an issue and appearing to answer it.

Justice Antonin Scalia demonstrated the risk in 2003 when he criticised a lower-court ruling on the Pledge of Allegiance. The litigant sought his recusal, and Scalia took no part when the case reached the U.S. Supreme Court, although the Court gave no reason. In Britain, Lady Hale outlined competing arguments in the pending Brexit litigation in 2016, then stopped: "the case is destined for our Court, so I must say no more". She later sat in Miller. Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg crossed a different boundary by criticising presidential candidate Donald Trump, then described her comments as "ill-advised".

Indian practice also counsels against treating every public intervention as improper. At NALSAR in March 2024, Justice B.V. Nagarathna criticised Governors who withheld assent to Bills while related disputes were before the Court. Scholars Jasmin Moran and Christopher W. Schmidt recognise apparent-bias concerns without treating judicial silence as the answer.

Is Justice Bhuyan exceptionally outspoken?

Justice Bhuyan is an unusually visible judicial speaker. A conservative open-source audit found at least 25 public-facing engagements since he joined the Supreme Court on July 14, 2023. It covered institutional archives, Bar events and contemporaneous reports, excluding courtroom remarks, internal programmes and events where only scheduled participation could be established. At least nine addresses generated news reports, seven in 2026. The figure is a minimum.

In 2026, his speeches became more pointed. He questioned executive influence in judicial transfers, cited low conviction rates while discussing overuse of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, criticised restrictive bail conditions, sought greater transparency in collegium decisions and criticised frivolous prosecutions arising from food choices, poems, protests and slogans. Most generated headlines without a comparable propriety controversy.

Two episodes stand out. After Justice Bhuyan criticised the Supreme Court's 2024 Delhi Metro arbitration ruling, retired Justice Indu Malhotra called the remarks an "indiscretion". Former Justice Sudhanshu Dhulia, by contrast, defended another July speech on dissent and criminalisation, while cautioning that sitting judges must exercise restraint because similar issues may later come before them. Their disagreement shows why controversy alone is a poor test.

Does his High Court record bear on this?

Justice Bhuyan's Gauhati High Court record cautions against treating speeches as predictors of outcomes. In *Monowara Bewa v Union of India* (2017), his Bench upheld a Foreigners Tribunal finding and rejected a Gaon Panchayat Secretary's certificate as an NRC linkage document. The Supreme Court later set aside that broader conclusion in *Rupajan Begum v Union of India*. In *Sirajul Hoque v State of Assam* (2019), it also reversed a 2017 decision of his Bench where variations in a family name had contributed to rejection of a citizenship claim. Yet in *Md Anuwar Hussain v Union of India* (2014), Justice Bhuyan set aside a Foreigners Tribunal order for lack of sound logic and cogent reasons, remanded the case and ordered the petitioner's release from detention to argue it afresh. His record contains strict and claimant-protective strands. Extrajudicial language about citizenship, liberty or voting cannot safely predict how he would decide a properly argued case.

So, are Justice Bhuyan's critics correct?

India's Restatement uses broader language than the U.S. code. His propositions that voting is constitutional and deletion requires procedural safeguards largely track existing doctrine. The sentence that "no court can condone" mass disenfranchisement comes closer to stating a constitutional conclusion, although it was conditional and did not decide whether the SIR produces that result.

The criticism becomes weaker when enlarged into a claim that sitting judges should avoid public discussion of constitutional law, civil liberties, judicial appointments or court administration. Indian judges have long occupied that space, and international standards recognise its value. If a case presenting the precise issue on which Justice Bhuyan spoke were assigned to him, the Scalia episode shows why recusal could become a question.

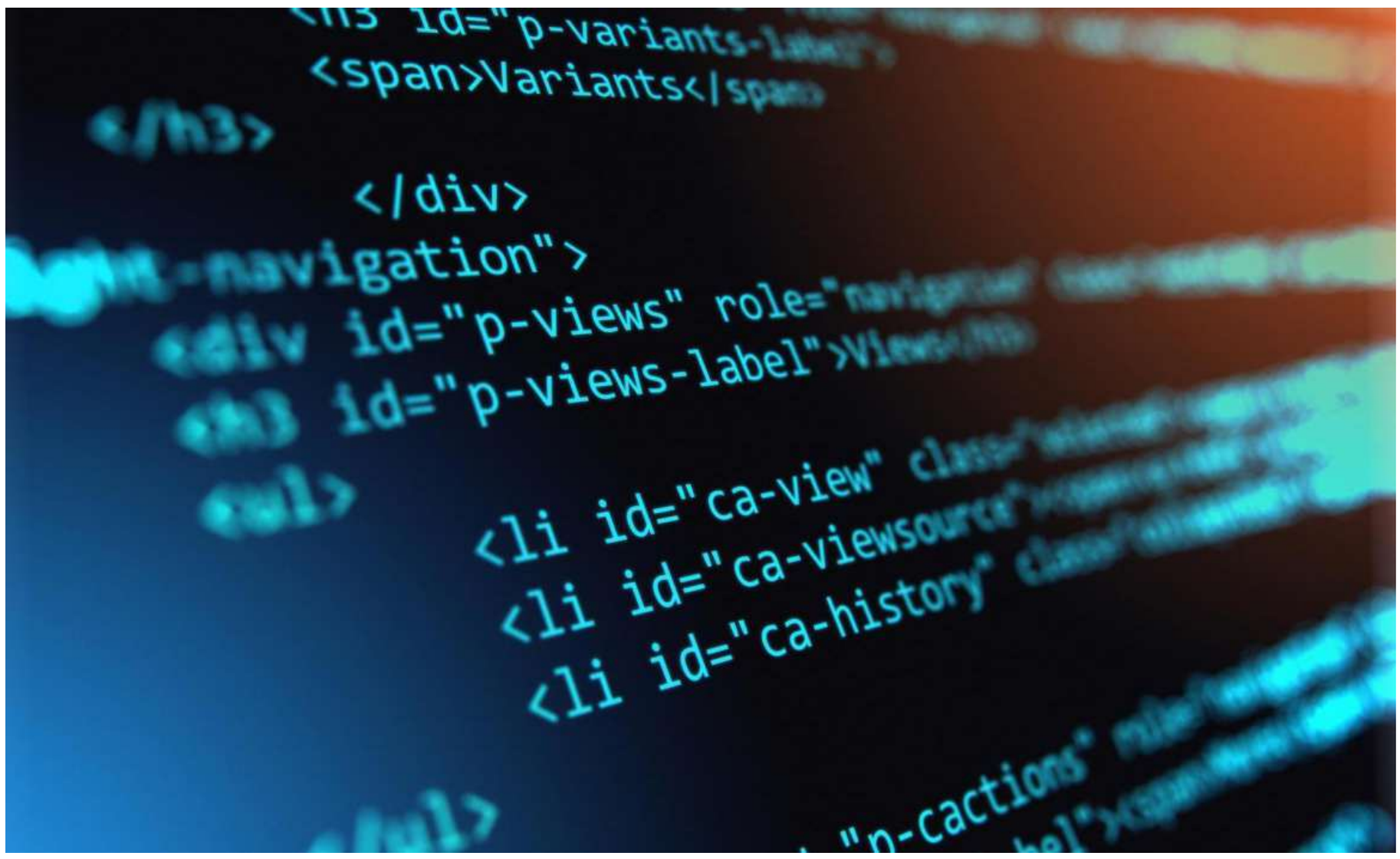
Justice Gogoi's "noisy judge" and Justice Nath's formulation that impartiality need not mean indifference can coexist. The relevant measures are the subject of the speech, the specificity of the conclusion and its proximity to adjudication. Judicial speech can enrich constitutional conversation, but the lecture hall should not sound like a courtroom deciding a case before the parties are heard.

(V. Venkatesan is Contributing Editor at Supreme Court Observer. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

- The Restatement of Values of Judicial Life bars judges from commenting on pending or likely judicial matters
- Comparative standards allow judges to discuss legal issues but caution against remarks that could affect pending proceedings
- Justice Bhuyan's record includes both strict and claimant-protective rulings, showing why public speeches cannot predict judicial outcomes

CACHE



GETTY IMAGES

Why do two newly disclosed PHP security flaws put websites and their users at risk?

Two security flaws in PHP could allow attackers to execute malicious code remotely, potentially exposing private data, passwords, and website servers; the fixes are available, but website owners must update all affected systems and check for signs of breaches

John Xavier

The story so far:

On October 21, the team behind PHP announced two serious security flaws. In simple terms, a hacker could use them to break into a website's server from far away, without needing physical access or a password. Security experts around the world have warned that the flaws could let attackers take control of affected servers.

What is PHP?

PHP is a programming language that runs behind the scenes on websites. You never see it, but you use it all the time.

Say you log into your bank's website or book a movie ticket. Your details travel to a server, which checks who you are, looks up your information and sends back the right page. PHP is often the tool doing that work.

It's especially common in the systems that power online shops, blogs, news sites, membership sites and business tools. If something goes wrong with PHP, a lot of websites can be affected at once. That's true whether it's a small shop on cheap shared hosting or a big company with hundreds of servers.

What went wrong?

Think of a computer's memory as a huge set of shelves. Programs put things on the shelves, take them off and tidy up when they're done. Good software has to keep careful track of what's where, especially when something goes wrong halfway through a task.

If the site is on managed hosting, ask your provider which version of PHP they use and whether the security fix has been installed. If you run your own servers, list every place PHP is installed, and don't assume that updating your main website covers everything

The two flaws are both mistakes in this tidying-up process.

The first is a problem with running out of space. When PHP runs low on memory, it can end up handling half-finished data badly while cleaning up. This can leave the shelves in a mess, which is called "memory corruption."

The second is a stale note. In some error situations, PHP keeps a note pointing to a shelf that has already been cleared. Later, it tries to use what it thinks is there, but finds something else entirely.

This can also corrupt memory.

Why does this matter?

A skilled attacker can sometimes use these messes to sneak in their own instructions and make the server run them. That's called "remote code execution." If PHP has enough permissions on the server, an attacker could read private data, steal passwords or change what your website shows.

There's another catch. These flaws sit deep inside PHP itself, so they can be triggered before a website's own protections, such as login checks, get a chance to step in. A website can have strong security of its own and still be exposed.



How long has this been known?

According to the PHP Foundation, the group that supports PHP, the first flaw was spotted in 2024 during a security review. It took a long time to sort out, and the Foundation has admitted there were delays. Both flaws were made public this month, along with fixes.

That doesn't mean hackers have been using them for two years. Finding a flaw, working out whether it can really be abused, reporting it safely and proving someone actually attacked are all separate steps.

It does show how tricky it is to look after a popular, free software project. Finding a bug is just the beginning. Developers also have to judge how risky it is, build a fix that works, make sure the fix doesn't break anything else and help people install it.

What happens next?

The main step is to update PHP. The fixes are available, and website owners and companies need to check and install them. That's not always quick. A big organisation may have PHP running in many places: live servers, internal tools, testing systems and more. Fixing one doesn't fix the rest.

It's also worth checking whether anyone got in before the update. If there are signs of a break-in, installing the fix may not be enough. Passwords might need changing, harmful changes removed and affected systems rebuilt from scratch.

So what can you do?

If your site is on managed hosting, ask your provider which version of PHP they use and whether the security fix has been installed. If you run your own servers, list every place PHP is installed, and don't assume that updating your main website covers everything.

If you're just a visitor, there's nothing you need to do yourself, because the fix is up to the people who run the websites.

The bigger picture

A website isn't one single thing. It's many pieces working together, and each piece can have its own weak spots.

Encryption keeps your information private while it travels, but it can't promise that the server at the other end is safe. A strong password can't fix a flaw in the software underneath. And a website that was fine yesterday can need an urgent update today.

Most of the web runs quietly in the background, and we only notice it when something breaks. When it does, fixing it takes effort from everyone involved.

THE DAILY QUIZ

A quiz on the occasion of the 81st anniversary of the United Nations

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

V. V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1
After WWII, where did representatives of 50 countries gather at a conference that led to the drafting and signing of the UN Charter that created a new international organisation?

QUESTION 2
Which are the two Asian countries that are presently non-permanent members of the UN Security Council?

QUESTION 3
What is the contribution of Oliver Lincoln Lundquist to the identity of the United Nations?

QUESTION 4
Where was the first session of the General Assembly held in January 1946, with 51 member nations in attendance?

QUESTION 5
What did the first resolution of the United Nations GA focus on?

QUESTION 6
Name the two UN Secretaries-General who have won the Nobel Peace Prize.

QUESTION 7
In which year was October 24 officially designated as 'United Nations Day'?



Visual Question:
Name this former Secretary-General who later became the President of Austria. THE HINDU ARCHIVES

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. The first-ever women's rights convention was held two years earlier, in 1848, in a small town in upstate New York. Name the town. **Ans: Seneca Falls**
2. One of the chief organisers of the Worcester convention later became famous for keeping her own surname after marriage. Who was she? **Ans: Lucy Stone**
3. This suffrage leader, who appeared on a U.S. dollar coin in 1979, said reading Lucy Stone's Worcester speech won her over to the cause. Who? **Ans: Susan B. Anthony**
4. The convention demanded that one word be removed from every State constitution so that women could vote. Which word? **Ans: "Male"**
5. Inspired by reports of the Worcester convention, Harriet Taylor wrote "*The Enfranchisement of Women*" in 1851, the same year she married a philosopher who would later write "*On Liberty*". Who was he? **Ans: John Stuart Mill**
Visual: This famous abolitionist, who had escaped slavery, spoke for women's suffrage at Seneca Falls and was also a speaker at Worcester. **Ans: Frederick Douglass**
Early Birds: K. S. Muthupandian | Logapriya G.K. | Suresh Kumar | Prem Raj P. | Aryansh Raj Saxena



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

He arrived at the wedding looking dapper

She humblebrags about her achievements

S. Upendran

What is the difference between 'dapper' and 'handsome'? (N Unnikrishnan, Kochi)
'Dapper', which rhymes with 'snapper' and 'clapper ', is a word of Dutch origin, and it was originally used to mean 'strong' and 'nimble'. The word underwent a change in meaning, and today its use is mostly limited to men who are fashionably dressed. When you call someone 'dapper', what you are suggesting is that the individual is trim and stylishly dressed. Although the individual may have a body that is appealing, he might not necessarily be good-looking or handsome.

James Bond is the dapper spy that Ian Fleming created.

Unlike 'dapper', 'handsome' can be used to describe both men and women; a woman who is built slightly large, but is very good-looking can be described as being 'handsome'. The focus here is on looks - mostly the face. A handsome individual may be shabbily dressed, and he may not be necessarily trim.

What is the meaning of 'humblebrag'? (V Sadhana, Coimbatore)
Although the word has been in existence since the late 1990s, it came into everyday use only in 2010. 'Humblebrag', as it is obvious, is made up of two words: humble and brag. The word is mostly used to mean to brag about oneself in a humble way. It is something that we have all done some time or another. There were times when we were so proud of our achievement that we were dying to shout about it from the rooftops. We wanted everyone to know. Although we were keen on telling everyone, we were reluctant to do so because we did not want to come across as being boastful; we wanted to be seen as being humble. During our school days, we had friends who, after acing a test, used to say, 'I didn't really prepare. I don't know how I topped the class.' He made it sound as if he were embarrassed by his achievement. We knew that he was anything but embarrassed. Reading between the lines, he was boasting that he would have scored even higher if he had actually prepared. Sometimes, the bragging is in the form of a complaint.

"I wish I hadn't won the award. Now, wherever I go, people want my autograph", she humblebrags.

How is the word 'premises' pronounced? (D Karthik, Ongole)
The word consists of three syllables; the first rhymes with 'hem', 'gem' and 'them'. The 'i' in the second syllable is like the 'i' in 'fit', 'kit' and 'bit'. Many Indians wrongly pronounce it like the 'y' in 'my', 'by' and 'try'. The final 's' in the word is pronounced like the 'z' in 'zip', 'zoo' and 'zap'. The word is pronounced 'PREM-i-siz' with the stress on the first syllable. When you refer to someone's premises, you are not just talking about the house, but also the land on which it has been built. For example, when you refer to the 'school premises', you are talking about everything contained within the school walls – the buildings, rooms, playground, etc.

The protestors were escorted off the school premises.

upendrankye@gmail.com

Word of the day

Exigency:
a pressing or urgent situation

Synonyms: contingency, crisis, emergency, juncture

Usage: *She cancelled her trip due to an unexpected exigency.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/exigency

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ɪksɪdʒənsi/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

'Excess': Insured, but still responsible

COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

In the previous instalment of Cover Note (October 5, 2026, Policy 'excess' does not mean more for you), we saw that an excess or deductible means the first portion of an admissible claim that you must bear yourself.

But why excess? In a motor policy covering a ₹20 lakh car, what difference does a few thousand rupees make? Why do some health policies require a co-payment?

One reason, as we saw, is to discourage small claims and reduce the time and administrative costs of processing them.

Suppose your excess is ₹1,000 and your loss is ₹2,500. You may decide that making a ₹1,500 claim isn't worth the trouble, or you may go ahead. The excess thus influences not only how much the insurer pays, but also whether a claim is made at all.

No-claim bonus

There is another reason to think twice before making small claims, especially under motor and health policies. It has nothing to do with excess. It is the no-claim bonus, or NCB.

The NCB rewards claim-free years, either through a discount on renewal premium or an increase in the sum insured, depending on the type of policy. And this matters to you because making a claim may mean losing some or all of the accumulated bonus.

Consider a car policy with an annual own-damage (OD) premium of ₹10,000 before NCB and an accumulated bonus of 50%. You would normally pay ₹5,000 for the OD renewal, assuming the base premium remains unchanged. But if you make an admissible own-damage claim, even for ₹2,000, you could lose the entire NCB and have to pay ₹10,000 instead.

That is ₹5,000 in lost discount for a claim of ₹2,000!

When to make a claim

So, you should make a claim only if what you stand to receive exceeds the no-claim bonus.

Of course, health insurance NCB provisions work differently, and some motor policies offer NCB protection. So, check your policy to see what happens to your bonus when you claim. Compare the possible loss of NCB with the amount you stand to receive and make an informed decision. But excess serves a purpose beyond discouraging small claims.

Insurance is founded, among other things, on the expectation that the insured will behave as a prudent uninsured – taking reasonable care to prevent losses and minimise their consequences.

Just as the insurer is your partner in misfortune, you should endeavour to be its partner in good fortune by making every reasonable effort to avoid losses. An excess reinforces this responsibility. By ensuring that you bear a portion of the loss, it gives you a financial interest in preventing it. You are encouraged to be as careful with the insurer's money as you would be with your own.

It is somewhat like the margin you contribute when taking a housing loan. The lender finances most of the purchase, but your own money is also at stake.

Specified risks

The larger idea is that insurance is not intended to take every financial consequence of every loss off your hands. It provides protection against specified risks, while leaving you responsible for the portion you have agreed to retain.

An excess, therefore, is not necessarily a shortcoming in insurance protection. It is part of how that protection is designed.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance and corporate history)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



Paying the price: The litmus test comes knocking much later, after the swipes have ended: a shocking bill. ILLUSTRATION: SAINATH B.

Swiping in dark: The hidden cost of plastic money

It's easy to swipe a card to satisfy a desire and gratify an impulse. However, unmindful swipes can accumulate into a mountain of debt, take a toll on monthly budget, and derail financial goals

COST OF CONVENIENCE

Vaishali R Venkat

A smartwatch bought on impulse, a costly phone ordered just for the thrill of owning it, a festive sale too tempting to resist. In isolation, each swipe may seem harmless, yet the danger lies in accumulation. Money spent in moments of desire can quietly turn into a burden that outlasts the fleeting gratification. Small indulgences, if they add up to a sizeable bill, can take a toll on the monthly budget and derail carefully planned financial goals.

The litmus test comes knocking much later, after the swipes have ended: a shocking bill. Now, to overcome the shock, cardholders often look for a shortcut: paying just the minimum due.

> Converting a purchase into equated monthly instalments does not erase the cost; rather, it locks you into a high-margin contract

The minimum due trap

The minimum-due loop is one of the most deceptive traps of a credit card. Paying only this negligible fraction may help avert immediate late-payment penalties and default notices. However, it allows the bulk of your debt to linger and compound.

Crucially, carrying a due attracts interest and simultaneously revokes the interest-free grace period for subsequent purchases. Any new spend begins accruing interest charges immediately at typical annual rates of 36% to 42%, compounded monthly, until the entire bill is cleared in full. If the minimum-due route is a slow leak, ignoring the bill payment entirely is an outright rupture. Failing to pay the minimum due carries far more severe consequences.

The bank would immediately flag the account as overdue, levying hefty late-payment penalties on top of the standard charges. If the default crosses a stipulated time, the bank reports the delinquency to CIBIL and other credit bureaus, leaving a long-lasting scar on your score.

When the bill is bulky, cardholders often lean towards another tempting escape hatch: easy EMIs. Converting a purchase into equated monthly instalments does not erase the cost; rather, it locks you into a high-margin contract.

You forfeit the upfront discounts that are often bundled with full payment, while a relentless 18% GST is slapped onto the interest portion of every single EMI.

By splitting past impulse purchases across future months, you silently mortgage your upcoming cash flows. The bitter truth: the thrill of owning fades fast, but the bill of burden goes on and on.

> The minimum-due loop is one of the most deceptive traps of a credit card. It allows the bulk of your debt to linger and compound

Paying your bill on time is only half the battle. Even if you are punctual in clearing the bills, it's not a total financial hygiene. When the usage on your card is close to its ceiling, you trigger an alarm button inside credit bureaus. Lenders gauge your financial stability through credit utilisation, and crossing the 30% threshold paints a picture of being cash hungry. Even if you do not default payment, a high usage of credit erodes your CIBIL score rating, transforming routine swipes into a hidden roadblock when you eventually apply for a home or vehicle loan.

Gliding your credit card smoothly into an ATM for quick cash would force you to endure a rough patch with huge money leaks.

On most credit cards, cash withdrawals carry zero grace period, meaning standard interest rates of 36 to 42% begin compounding moments after the currency is dispensed. Even on select promotional cards that tout an interest-free window, the fixed fees bite hard.

For instance, banks usually cap single ATM withdrawals at ₹10,000 while levying a flat processing fee of around ₹199 plus GST on every single attempt. Therefore, a requirement of ₹50,000 forces you to glide into the vending tunnel five times, instantly draining roughly over ₹1,000 in raw processing charges alone.

The reward ruse

While disciplined spending yields genuine perks, swiping mindlessly just to earn reward points is a losing strategy. Banks routinely alter redemption ratios, quietly eroding the real value of accumulated points. Furthermore, flat redemption processing fees and GST can easily consume smaller claims.

Swiping your card across international borders or on a few global websites comes with a silent surcharge. Every overseas transaction triggers a forex markup fee, typically between 1.5 and 3.5%, with a relentless 18% GST slapped onto that fee.

Despite the minefield of hidden charges, a credit card isn't an inherent curse. Securing a card with zero annual fees and joining fees, waived forex markups, a generous interest-free window, and substantial reward points can turn routine spending into genuine savings.

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	**Interest Rate (%)**	**EMI (Rs)**	**EMI (Rs)**	**Processing fee**
Axis Bank	8.90 onwards	10,355 onwards	2,071 onwards	Up to 2%
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.50	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 4.13%
Bank of Baroda*	10.40-18.05	10,722-12,710	2,144-2,542	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Bank of India	11.10-16.15	10,896-12,199	2,179-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Bank of Maharashtra	10.00-15.25	10,264-11,961	2,125-2,392	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Canara Bank	9.95-16.00	10,621-12,159	2,122-2,432	0.25% (Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,500)
Central Bank of India	11.50 onwards	10,996 onwards	2,199 onwards	Up to 1%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
HSBC Bank	9.70 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 1%
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	NIL
Indian Overseas Bank	10.50 onwards	10,747 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 0.75%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Poonawalla Fincorp	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 4%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.90-14.05	10,599-11,764	2,120-2,353	0.50%-1%
Punjab National Bank	10.50-17.05	10,747-12,440	2,149-2,488	Up to 1%
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	NIL
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 49
UCO Bank	10.20 - 13.45	10,673-11,492	2,135-2,298	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
Union Bank of India	9.15 - 12.90	10,416-11,351	2,083-2,270	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	**Interest Rate (%)**	**EMI (Rs)**	**Processing fee**
Bank of Baroda	7.85 - 11.55	10,102 - 11.009	Up to Rs. 2,000
Bank of India	7.85-12.55	10,102 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.70-12.00	10,067 - 11,122	Nil
Canara Bank**	7.70-11.70	10,067 - 11,047	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Central Bank of India	7.75-9.55	10,078 - 10,513	NIL (Till 31.12.2026)
HDFC Bank	8.25 onwards	10,198 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
ICICI Bank	8.40 onwards	10,234 onwards	Up to Rs. 8,500
IDFC FIRST Bank	8.99 onwards	10,377 onwards	Up to 5%
Indian Bank	7.75 onwards	10,031 - 11,034	Nil
Indian Overseas Bank	7.80-12.00	10,090 - 11,122	NIL
Karnataka Bank	8.16-11.66	10,177 - 11,037	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank***	7.55-14.30	10,031 - 11,712	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Punjab National Bank	7.85-10.95	10,102 - 10,859	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
State Bank of India	8.45 - 9.50	10,246 - 10,501	Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,000
UCO Bank	7.70-10.25	10,067 - 10,685	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
Union Bank of India	7.75-10.25	10,078 - 10,685	Up to Rs 1,000

*0.25% rate cut for home loan borrowers/customers with 6 months banking relationship
**100% waiver on processing fee till December 31
***Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam
Rates and charges as on October 21

Source: Paisabazaar.com

Implication of residual investments on core portfolios

THINKINVESTOR

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) recently allowed equity funds to invest up to 35% of their residual portfolio in non-equity investments.

In this article, we look at the implication of this regulation on your core portfolios.

When you invest in an equity fund, you expect to get equity exposure. Take large-cap active funds.

According to SEBI's regulation, such funds must invest not less than 80% in large-cap stocks. That gives these funds room to wander into mid-cap and small-cap space. Large-cap active funds typically invest in mid-cap stocks for the residual allocation (not more than 20%). The recent SEBI regulation allows these funds to also invest in gold ETFs, silver ETFs and Infrastructure Investment Trusts (InvITs). The rationale is that gold and silver could perform well when equity market declines sharply.

So, investing in non-equity investments could provide these funds a way to stabilize their portfolios when equity market turns volatile. Equity funds may or may not choose to invest in these non-equity investments. How does this regulation impact your investments? Take core portfolios that you create to achieve your life goals. You may have taken exposure to large-cap active funds and bank deposits to fulfil your equity and bond allocations. In addition, you may have also invested in gold and silver ETFs in the belief that the prices of these metals will increase steadily over the long term. Alternatively, you may be actively trading in gold and silver ETFs as part of your satellite portfolio. But what if the large-cap active fund you invested in takes also exposure to gold and silver ETFs?

You may have unintentionally created more exposure to these metals- your direct exposure to such ETFs and indirect exposure through the active equity funds. Though the investment in non-equity does not affect the tax treatment of your investments in these equity funds, your asset allocation can become somewhat skewed.

Conclusion

Despite the SEBI regulation, equity funds have typically maintained their equity allocation. That may change in the future. If you are concerned about equity funds taking exposure to non-equity investments, you can consider investing in index funds or equity ETFs. As passive products, index funds and equity ETFs are required to mirror their benchmark index.

That means their portfolio will contain the same stocks in the same weights as the benchmark index. So, you will get your intended exposure to an equity index.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Festive party overload at work?



Problem of plenty: In a diverse country like India, the list of celebrations may lead to fatigue. FILE P;HOTO

Kamal Karanth

During Dussehra did you feel you didn't have the right attire for your office's ethnic look day? Don't worry, you can still shop the look as Deepavali is not far away!

Believe me, your HR and admin teams won't let you down. They must be busy already preparing a Deepavali decoration design and working with vendors for a new set of cuisines to get your energies up once again. If we don't dress up, play games, eat together, click and post those pictures, how else can we feel a sense of belonging in our organisations?

"The samosa this time wasn't as good as last year's – did we change the caterer?" was one of the comments on our Slack chats after a recent festival celebration at work.

"Our Diwali sweet boxes should be bigger and premium compared to our competitors," wrote our Key Account Manager.

Our location head emailed, "It's a year since we inaugurated this office; we should celebrate the anniversary with a lunch for all the 100 employees." Celebrations for various occasions have become almost entitlements in the world of work. Cynics believe there are too many. Although everyone agrees that we need to engage more informally to be productive formally.

Harvard Business School records the early 1900s as the time when welfare capitalism showed up. It began after labour unions, social reformers, journalists, and photographers brought to national attention the poor working conditions of industrial workers. Western Electric (after acquisition, the brand was phased out by AT&T) was one of the first few to introduce recreational activities for its workers to participate in running meets, tennis ball games, baseball leagues, lunchtime concerts and beauty pageants.

At that time, even Kodak, Cadbury, and Ford pioneered highly structured social, athletic, and educational events to build company loyalty, improve physical health, boost productivity, and – most importantly – discourage worker strikes and independent labour unionising. If your employer organises an annual sports day or customised versions of IPL, they are not doing anything new but following history. Current organisations may not be afraid of unionism or worker strikes but are concerned about Glassdoor ratings.

Sociologist Emile Durkheim gives the analogy of tribal members whose lives are mostly spent performing menial tasks such as hunting and gathering but, on rare occasions when the entire tribe comes together to celebrate, a sense of "collective effervescence" emerges. In the modern-day workplace, offsites, company dinners, award ceremonies, hackathons, Secret Santa, and so on may lead to collective effervescence.

Among the emails I get, send-off messages are of great interest to me. One of the best memories people share in their goodbye emails is their time out with colleagues, highlighting moments from treks, bootcamps or offsites they enjoyed with their team.

In a country like India, which is vast and diverse, the list of celebrations may lead to fatigue. If you are a founder-led company, there will be a founding day; and if you are a large company, then the 10th, 25th, 50th anniversaries become moments to celebrate survival. From Independence Day and Women's Day to national festivals like Deepavali, Ganesha Chaturthi, Dusshera, Ramzan, Christmas and various regional/State festivals, the list is quite long. One of my HR friends recently joked that his unofficial title is "Head of Rangoli".

Not only do people put great effort into organising these, but they also have to spend substantial energy and time requesting people to turn up. The Slack chat lights up with messages like "The cake (or food) is already here, please come". Makes me wonder if our colleagues are overburdened by these celebrations.

Why are some of us drained by these collective rituals in spite of their celebratory nature? Is it because they are too frequent, or have no variety (just dress, eat and sing), or because of the official setting? Sociologists Peter Fleming and Andrew Sturdy argued that true collective effervescence must be organic and bottom-up.

When management builds games, theme days, or social rituals into the job, the play ceases to be voluntary and becomes a work requirement. As much as it's fun seeing our colleagues dressed in yellow because HR said so, I wonder what the forced dress code did to the reluctant ones, or the ones who didn't oblige and hence weren't in the yellow team picture!

(Kamal Karanth is the co-founder of Xpheno, a specialist staffing company)

Musk's India satcom licence stalled by 'national sovereignty' concerns

For five years, major players have been waiting for the final regulatory go-ahead to launch commercial services.; while Elon Musk lost patience and alleged India was favouring domestic "oligarchs", his rivals and policymakers attribute the deadlock to a complex issue: national sovereignty

NEWS ANALYSIS

Vallari Sanzgiri

Dear Prime Minister Ambani, Please accept my humble apologies for not realising that you are the real boss of India." – SpaceX and Starlink owner Elon Musk

"We welcome competition... Every player must serve the people of India and abide by the laws..." – Reliance Industries Ltd.

"I think I am significantly ahead in the queue from [Musk]. I applied five years back..." – Bharti Airtel Chairman Sunil Mittal

"There are three parties that have got a licence... when they individually fulfil the security conditions, they can start operations." – Communications Minister Jyotirao Scindia

Welcome to India's satcom wars. While bitter and sardonic, Mr. Musk's X post jump-started a heated debate in India's long-delayed satellite communication space. For five years, major satcom players have been waiting for the final regulatory go-ahead to launch commercial services. As the sole foreign player among the three entities closest to clearance, Mr. Musk was the first to lose his patience – lashing out with allegations that the Indian government was favouring domestic "oligarchs".

However, his rivals and policymakers reject that narrative. They attribute the deadlock to a complex and sensitive issue: national sovereignty.

Indeed, back in February 2025, when Mr. Musk discussed Starlink's pending entry during his meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi in Washington and followed up with a phone call in April, a high-level alignment on tech and space was on display. Policy tussles between terrestrial and satcom players repeatedly favoured the global players until last year.



Hostile terrain: The momentum shifted this year, after geopolitical developments clouded Starlink's chances of getting licensing approvals in India. ANI

In 2024, while terrestrial players called for spectrum auctioning, the government favoured the global practice of administrative allocation. In the next battle – over pricing – terrestrial players pushed for high entry barriers, upfront reservation pricing, or similar minimum costs to "level the field" for players who incurred a heavy financial burden after 5G. The pricing structure now awaits Cabinet approval at 4-5% of gross adjusted revenue, easing the financial duress of new players. In a last-ditch effort, telcos asked the government to levy an urban fee of ₹500 per user for satcom players.

This was rejected and it appeared to be smooth sailing for Starlink thus far.

The momentum shifted this year, after geopolitical developments clouded Starlink's chances of getting licensing approvals in India.

> Whether those allocated licence are Reliance Jio or Eutelsat or even Starlink, security definitely becomes important
>
> **A.K. BHATT,** Director General of Indian Space Association

The India-U.S. relation, too, has been rocked by differences over visas, tariffs, and other issues.

As India doubled down on security checks, around June there were rumours of a regulatory freeze for Starlink, and by August the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPACe) rejected Starlink's clearance request due to security concerns. No surprise then that Mr. Musk cried bloody murder.

Security vs connectivity

Addressing Mr. Musk's allegations of a bias, retired Lt Gen. A.K. Bhatt, Director General of Indian Space Association (IspA), says, "Whether those allocated licence are Reliance Jio or Eutelsat or even Starlink, security definitely becomes important. While technology is moving fast and D2D is on the horizon, a deliberation of security consideration does become ethical for any sovereign nation."

Tony Azzarelli, Vice President of Regulatory Affairs and Policy for OneWeb (which is Mittal's partner), also expressed "shock" at Mr. Musk's claim of an oligarchy blocking Starlink's licence. "I would argue that we have been slowed down by the new comers. Why? Everyone knows, just take a look at the geopolitical situation in India-subcontinent and in the middle-east, this has created anguish and fear to the regulatory agencies," he said in a LinkedIn post.

While tactical, Azzarelli's comment about new players and security concerns is not without reason. Shortly after the X outburst, Mr. Musk reportedly ordered the slowdown of a military-grade version of Starlink relied on by Ukraine, wreaking havoc in that country's ongoing war with Russia, according to media reports.

In the days that followed, the company and the U.S. government took turns shifting the blame on each other.

The incident and other similar ones in the past only served to underscore the dangers of handing over communication services to a foreign player.

Kutniti Foundation, a think tank focused on national security, went so far as to call Starlink a wolf in sheep's clothing that adhered to its biggest customer and promoter, the American government intelligence and military, while disregarding the sovereignty and democracy of other nations.

It cited the examples of Gaza and Iran, where Starlink has flip-flopped on its decision to provide connectivity based on its understanding with the parties in power.

An industry source told *businessline* that the Indian government had spoken with the company on certain access and compliance measures. Failing to arrive at a consensus, all players remain in queue.

Need for satcom

Interestingly, some players are not as perturbed as Starlink over India's delay.

During a session at the India Mobile Congress, Tarun Chitkara, Vice President-Regulatory Affairs, Airtel, acknowledged that D2D could be a game-changer, but only for the 1% of that population that cannot access terrestrial services due to geographical or commercial reasons, making it a complementary service for existing domestic players.

This appears especially true when considering that Starlink's annual plan cost ₹2,15,600 for 50-200 Mbps last year, almost 10-14 times that of major Indian broadband providers, which can prove a major drawback in the price-conscious Indian market.

On the flip side, India may want to consider satellite communication as more than just another broadband market, says Akhilesh Tuteja, Partner and National Leader-Clients and Markets, and Technology, Media and Telecommunications, KPMG in India.

Strategic infra

Satcom can serve as strategic digital infrastructure, connecting the hard-to-reach segment, strengthening resilience and creating an opportunity for India to build capabilities for the world, if executed correctly, he argues. "The challenge is not to choose between security and speed, but achieve both," says Mr. Tuteja.

The Cabinet is expected to soon approve the Digital Communications Commission's (DCC) suggestion for a spectrum usage charge (SUC) of 5% of adjusted gross revenue (AGR) for satcom service providers, with a reduction of one percentage point for services in government-notified hard-to-connect and remote border areas.

Until then, the satcom players are left playing the policy version of musical chairs.

(The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

Liquidity ironies come sharply into focus

Madan Sabnavis

The markets turn unfathomable as the 10-year yield tests 7.5% and liquidity in the system dries up. Stock markets are known for volatility and, though there are several theories, it is hard to guess what really drives share prices.

Of late, however, the money and bond (M&B) market has assumed a high tone of volatility never witnessed before.

From a time of worry that call rates were lower than the repo rate, they have now ascended to 5.6-5.7 % as some banks are accessing the marginal standing facility (MSF) market. The 10-year yield is now testing the 7.5% level and liquidity in the system has dried up.

Just what is happening in these markets?

The deposit deluge

It all starts with the liquidity issue. The foreign currency non-resident-bank (FCNR-B) deposit, overseas foreign currency borrowing (OFCB) and external commercial borrowing (ECB) scheme was more than successful, attracting inflows of around $143 billion, of which around $133 billion were from deposits.

This would mean that around ₹13-14 lakh crore of incremental deposits have flowed in over a period of time. As the scheme closed on August 31, the peak liquidity surplus of over ₹10 lakh crore prevailed in early September.



Money matters: Higher durable liquidity and lower banking surpluses are reflective of slower government expenditure activity, which will add to deposits. REUTERS

However, this month is critical due to advance tax payments, which build up towards the middle of the month, topped by GST payments, dragging down the surpluses.

Post September 20, the surpluses fell below ₹5 lakh crore and are marginally positive today. There have been other developments that have affected overall liquidity.

First, the RBI conducted open market operations (OMOs), where government securities were sold – first for ₹1 lakh crore and again for ₹25,000 crore. Second, deposits that were at ₹260 lakh crore before the scheme was announced, peaked at ₹278 lakh crore by August-end and ended at ₹283 lakh crore by September-end. This would have included the FCNR and other domestic deposits.

Bank credit during this period increased by around ₹15 lakh crore. Investments increased by around ₹5 lakh crore. Thus, intuitively, the surpluses between liabilities and assets narrowed considerably.

Alongside this, the durable liquidity situation by the end of September showed that the government cash balances that accrue due to tax collections less spending stood at ₹5-5.5 lakh crore.

Higher durable liquidity and lower banking surpluses are reflective of slower government expenditure activity, which will add to deposits.

Two other factors affected liquidity. First, while forex reserves increased due to the FCNR scheme, there was also considerable drawdown of the reserves to support the rupee.

Hence if the foreign currency reserve levels are examined, it can be seen that from $543 billon on June 5, they peaked at $645 billion on September 11 but fell to $597 billion by October 9.

This $48 billion decline reflects a combination of valuation effects – the dollar strengthened in the market; and the RBI sold dollars in the market.

All sales involve removal of liquidity from the system. The other factor at play has been the overwhelming size of IPOs, which causes temporary distortion in the deposit-credit matrix as funds get held up till the listing date. This affects the liquidity in the system.

Cash holdover

All these factors have combined to reduce the liquidity in the system to the extent that the RBI has started on the variable rate repo series of operations to infuse liquidity. There is also an anomaly in the system with investments of around ₹1.6 lakh crore in the standing deposit facility (SDF), meaning that some banks have surplus liquidity while others don't.

But this is more due to uncertainty over cash flows and the compulsion now to maintain 99% cash reserve ratio (CRR) on a daily basis.

This forces banks to hold on to cash to meet the requirement, and they invest the balance in the SDF window.

The liquidity issue relates not just to the money market but also spills into the bond market.

Thumb rule

The thumb rule for the ideal liquidity position is 1% of the net demand and time liabilities (NDTL) in the system, which works out to around ₹3 lakh crore. As the level fell short, the impact was seen on the T-bill auctions during the week, where the market wanted higher cut-offs and it led to the cancellation of the auction.

Bond yields, too, have spiked to 7.4-7.45% while testing 7.5%.

The sentiment turned more sombre with the release of the monetary policy committee meeting's minutes, which seemed to suggest there would be more aggressive rate hikes in the coming policy.

While the MPC story is old, the market reacts to the minutes quite irrationally. But it is a reality.

Will the situation change and, if so, how soon? The answer at best is a shrug of the shoulder. Bank deposit growth will be fickle with the IPO market taking precedence for deposit holders.

Credit growth at the retail and corporate ends will continue, thus putting pressure on liquidity. The government would need to spend more, which will hopefully happen soon.

Will the RBI continue to sell dollars? One can't tell right now.

As these factors play out, we can expect more VRR auctions to support liquidity and OMO purchases rather than sales, if the situation remains grim going ahead.

(The writer is Chief Economist, Bank of Baroda, and the author of 'Policies that shaped Modern India'. Views are personal)

GAZA CITY

Israeli air strikes kill several across the Gaza Strip, say local authorities



AFP

An Israeli drone strike on a university in Gaza City killed three people on Sunday, Al Shifa hospital operating in the Gaza Strip said. Gaza civil defence spokesman Mahmoud Bassal said four other people were killed on Sunday, two in an air strike in Khan Yunis, one in Deir al Balah and one in the Gaza Strip. AFP

PARIS

French groups plan more rallies to maintain pressure on Macron govt.



REUTERS

French groups called on Sunday for demonstrations on October 31 and November 5 as they sought to maintain pressure on Emmanuel Macron's government after a security operation helped contain unrest during rallies on Saturday. The Interior Ministry said 410,000 people took part in the marches and 1,314 were arrested. REUTERS

CARACAS

After months in exile, Venezuelan leader Machado returns home



AP

Venezuelan Opposition figure and Nobel Peace Prize winner Maria Corina Machado returned to her home country on Sunday after nearly a year in exile. "I am here. With you," Ms. Machado said on X. It was her first appearance since the U.S. military deposed the country's then-President Nicolas Maduro in January. AFP

LONDON

U.K. PM Burnham calls for 'honest discussion' on EU free movement



AP

U.K. Prime Minster Andy Burnham indicated he was open to readopting the EU's free movement rules as part of Britain's future relationship with the bloc, said a report on Sunday. Mr. Burnham told *the Sunday Times* the country should have an "honest discussion" about how immigration has changed since Brexit. AFP

War, or no war, our policies remain unchanged, says Iran

We must accept the new realities, I'm already thinking about the post-war period, Araghchi says; his remarks come as U.S. President Trump indicated on Friday plans for a new military operation

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said on Sunday that a potential resumption of war with Israel and the United States would not change his country's positions.

The remarks come amid mounting U.S. and Israeli threats of renewed attacks on Iran, as President Donald Trump said on Friday that Washington "may do another little Epic Fury," referring to the U.S.-Israeli campaign on Iran that began on February 28.

"Recently, there has been talk of a new war, but I am already thinking about the post-war period. Whether there is war or not, our policies remain the same," said Mr. Araghchiin Tehran.

"They have already done so twice and have seen the results. If they want to try again, they know they will achieve no different outcome from those of the past."

An April 8 ceasefire put an end to the most intense fighting, apart from sporadic exchanges of fire in and around the strategic Strait of Hormuz, a key route for global energy supplies.



Mural messaging: Motorcyclists drive past a billboard depicting a Persian legendary hero hitting U.S. aircraft carriers in Tehran. AP

Iran has claimed control over the strait since the outbreak of the war and has regularly targeted vessels that attempt crossing without its authorisation. In response, the U.S. has been maintaining a naval counter-blockade on Iranian ports.

In June, Iran agreed with the U.S. to a memorandum of understanding laying out a pathway to a permanent settlement of the conflict, only for the deal to later unravel as each side accused the other of violating it. Tehran has since called for a return to the accord to end the conflict.

"The current war has changed everything. We must accept that new realities are taking hold. Shipping routes through the Strait of Hormuz will no longer be the same, and the management of the strait will no longer be the same," Mr. Araghchi said.

"To achieve peace and stability, our region must move towards the complete absence of foreign forces."

Foreign Ministry spokesperson, Esmail Baghaei, said Tehran has not closed the window of diplomacy and messages are being passed to the U.S. via intermediaries.

State media said Mr. Baghaei spoke in an interview with a German broadcaster. He said the U.S. persist in unilateral demands and that Mr. Trump and U.S. officials repeatedly use the phrase "complete surrender," which Mr. Baghaei said no Iranian accepts.

Calls to cut gas usage

Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf on Sunday called for a campaign to cut gas usage by at least 10%, with officials anticipating shortages as winter approaches.

While a major producer, Iran has long suffered shortages of natural gas which have been exacerbated by war.

"To get through the approaching winter, a nationwide effort is essential ... to reduce gas consumption by at least 10%," Mr. Ghalibaf said.

(With inputs from AP)

Lula faces Flavio as Brazil votes in nail-biting run-off

Associated Press
RIO DE JANEIRO

Brazilians began voting in Sunday's presidential runoff between incumbent President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva and Flavio Bolsonaro, a contest that will determine whether the U.S. will significantly expand its growing influence in Latin America.

Polls ahead of the vote showed the two candidates, who need more than 50% of the vote to become Brazil's next leader, in a neck-and-neck race. The election pits veteran politician Mr. Lula against Mr. Bolsonaro, an ally of U.S. President Donald Trump and the son of imprisoned former President Jair Bolsonaro.

It is the final electoral battle for Mr. Lula, who turns 81 on October 27.

Flavio Bolsonaro bested Mr. Lula by more than 2.2 million votes in the first round of the election earlier this month.

Mr. Bolsonaro and Mr. Lula have opposing ideological views on issues ranging from U.S.-Brazil relations and climate change to social welfare.

A win for Mr. Bolsonaro would signify a pivot to the right by Latin America's most populous country and its largest economy, in a year when Mr. Trump allies have notched up victories in Chile, Peru and Colombia. A victory for Mr. Lula would leave Brazil and Mexico with left-of-centre leaders.



Public voice: Voters arrive by boat at a polling station in the Lago do Catalao community in Iranduba, Amazonas state, on Sunday. AFP

Four years ago, Mr. Lula beat Mr. Bolsonaro's father by the narrowest margin since the country's return to democracy in 1985.

Main concerns

Mr. Lula has faced a tough re-election battle because of concerns about the cost of living and security. Mr. Bolsonaro made a tough-on-crime approach the cornerstone of his campaign and pledged to bring down food costs.

"The time of real change has arrived," Mr. Bolsonaro told journalists after he voted in Rio de Janeiro. "Brazil can't go on another four years on its current trajectory."

Meanwhile, Mr. Lula, who is seeking a fourth non-consecutive term, thanked his voters for an outpouring of support as he voted in Sao Bernardo do Campo, where he kicked off his political career as a union leader in the 1960s.

"It is a lot of generosity, a lot of care, a lot of love. I will be forever grateful," Mr. Lula said.

Voting in Brazil is conducted electronically and the result is usually available within hours after polling stations close at 5 p.m. in Brasilia.

Israel presses ahead with West Bank operation

Associated Press
TEL AVIV

The Israeli military pressed ahead with a massive military operation in the occupied West Bank on Sunday that has displaced hundreds of Palestinians in response to a gun attack last week that killed two Israeli soldiers.

The operation in Hebron, the site of Friday's attack, came as Israel enters the final days before a tense election, which is largely seen as a referendum on Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's leadership and security policies.

Land crossings closed

The Army said most Palestinian workers with permits will not be allowed to enter Israeli West Bank settlements on Sunday and Monday, and crossings into Israel will remain closed until after Tuesday polls.

The military said it operated in more than 400 locations over the weekend and arrested 40 Palestinians it claimed were affiliated with militant groups.

The Hebron municipality said the operation displaced more than 2,600 people.

Musk accuses Ukraine of using Starlink for 'killer' drone strikes

Agence France-Presse
KYIV

Tech tycoon Elon Musk accused Ukraine on Saturday of violating Starlink's terms of service by using it for "drone strikes to kill people", after tension between Washington and Kyiv over disruptions to the SpaceX-made network crucial to Ukraine's operations.

"Ukraine military violated Starlink terms of service and used it for offensive drone strikes to kill people," Mr. Musk posted on X, but added that the loophole was closed.

"Starlink's terms have remained consistent as a civilian system, not a means of killing. Violation of those terms will result in end of service," he wrote.

Ukraine disputes claim

Serhii Beskrestnov, a defense technology adviser to President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, said restrictions on the civilian system in Ukraine made such offensive use impossible.

Writing on Telegram, he said that drones operated via the Starlink system had a speed restriction of 70-90 km/h within Ukraine and did not work in Russia.

"Therefore, we cannot use commercial Starlink for deep or medium-range strikes," he said.

Earlier this month, Ukrainian drones connected to Starshield lost connectivity at high speeds, disrupting air defenses during Russian attacks. Officials said the service was restored on Saturday.

(With inputs from AP)

Honouring the dead



Children pose for pictures during preparations for the Day of the Dead in Tlajomulco de Zuniga, Jalisco, Mexico, on Saturday. The Day of the Dead pays tribute to deceased family members and friends. AFP

Serbia goes to polls as students seek to unseat populist Vucic

Agence France-Presse
BELGRADE

Serbia recorded its highest parliamentary election turnout on Sunday in more than three decades, as a student-led movement seeks to oust the party of veteran leader Aleksandar Vucic.

By 6 p.m. local time, two hours before closure of polls, 64.89% voters had cast their ballots, the Statistics Office said.

The snap vote is the culmination of nearly two years of student-led protests sparked by the 2024 collapse of a canopy at Novi Sad railway station that killed 16 people – a tragedy widely blamed on corruption.

The Students' List, a selection of candidates backed by the largely leaderless movement, poses the biggest challenge to Mr. Vucic's right-wing populist Serbian Progressive Party.

Iranian sailors get medical treatment in Sri Lanka

Meera Srinivasan
COLOMBO

Around 40 stranded Iranian sailors aboard U.S.-sanctioned oil tankers anchored just outside Sri Lanka's territorial waters received urgent medical treatment in the island nation on Saturday, Sri Lanka's Foreign Ministry said.

Authorities facilitated the transfer of the Iranian sailors from their vessels to the shore through the port of Galle in the country's Southern Province, Foreign Affairs Ministry spokesman Thushara Rodrigo told *The Hindu*.



A Sri Lankan Navy vessel approaches an Iranian Navy vessel during a rescue operation, off the coast of Colombo, in March. REUTERS

"We coordinated the transfer alone as per our humanitarian obligations. The Iranian Embassy bore all the expenses," he said.

A senior official at the Iranian Embassy in Colombo confirmed the development and said the sailors were taken from Galle to Colombo for medical attention before leaving Sri Lanka on Saturday night.

The development comes a month after *The Wall Street Journal* reported that U.S. "pressure" through sanctions had left the Iranian vessels stranded in Sri Lankan waters.

At the time, the Sri Lankan Foreign Ministry said Colombo would not be extending assistance to the sanctioned vessels, while emphasising that the secondary sanctions were part of a broader directive from Washington, D.C. and not specific to Sri Lanka.

Denying media reports of U.S. pressure on Sri Lanka, Foreign Minister Vijitha Herath said the Sri Lankan government made decisions "strictly protecting the country's sovereignty", even as it was prepared to intervene appropriately on humanitarian grounds.

Earlier this year, Sri Lanka made headlines when a U.S. submarine attacked and sank Iranian frigate *IRIS Dena* in the Indian Ocean, off the island's southern coast. At least 84 people were killed in the torpedo attack, which sent shockwaves across the region. Sri Lanka's ruling Anura Kumara Dissanayake administration, while reiterating its commitment to a "neutral foreign policy", directed its Navy to evacuate the injured sailors.

Houthis target Riyadh airport hours after flights resume

Agence France-Presse
RIYADH

The Houthi militia in Yemen on Sunday launched wide-ranging strikes across swathes of southern Saudi Arabia even as the Iran-backed group said the kingdom struck Yemen dozens of times over the previous 24 hours.

The attacks targeted Riyadh's international airport hours after its partial reopening, as well as an airbase and naval base.

"The Yemeni armed forces conducted three military operations with dozens of ballistic missiles," Houthi military spokesperson Yahya Saree said on X, adding that the strike on the airport "achieved its target".

He added that they targeted King Khalid air base in Khamis Mushait and a naval base in Jazan.

The Saudi Arabia-led coalition fighting the Houthis earlier said at least 10 ballistic missiles were intercepted during.

The Houthi spokesperson warned that Riyadh airport was still "unsafe" and a "military target". He said Saudi Arabia launched 56 airstrikes and missiles targeting civilian infrastructures in Yemen over the previous 24 hours.

The King Khalid International Airport's website showed several domestic and international flights scheduled on Sunday, including arrivals from Dubai, Paris and Cairo, after being closed for two weeks. Tracking website Flightradar24 showed a small number of flights had departed, though the vast majority were cancelled.



People eat chicken taouk sandwiches at the Glow Paradise restaurant in Beirut. REUTERS

$13 'chic' sandwich becomes symbol of Lebanon divide

Reuters
BEIRUT

Seven years after Lebanon's devastating financial meltdown, a debate over a chicken sandwich has exposed an increasingly stark divide between those who can still spend freely and those struggling to get by.

A trendy health restaurant wanted to offer its calorie-conscious customers a healthier take on the beloved Levantine wrap known as the shish taouk. So, The Glow Paradise launched the "Chic Taouk," pricing it at around $13 – nearly double what an un-chic chicken sandwich typically goes for in Beirut.

The pricy pun proved hard to swallow, with outraged critics accusing the restaurant of overcharging in a country where many households struggle to afford basic necessities.

Yet while the debate raged on social media, customers kept buying. The Glow Paradise sold more than 20,000 Chic Taouk sandwiches in just 11 days, according to managing partner Hrag Jeghalian, who described the online exchanges as "natural marketing".

The contrasting reactions touched a nerve in Lebanon, where years of financial turmoil, political dysfunction and conflict have reshaped the country's social landscape, hollowing out much of the middle class while leaving a smaller group of consumers able to sustain an affluent lifestyle.

Sami Nader, an economist at the Saint Joseph University of Beirut, said the throngs at The Glow Paradise belied another reality. "So you see people in the restaurant, but what you don't see is that 22 restaurants closed last month," he said.

War-ravaged Ukrainian city to get aid following Melania-brokered ceasefire

Oleshky has been without power, heat or water and food and medical supplies have been short for months; Moscow captured it on the first day of its invasion in Feb. 2022; the U.S. first lady says the ceasefire will start on Tuesday; it will help in delivery of humanitarian aid and evacuation of civilians

Associated Press

A small city in southern Ukraine, cut off for months by fighting, is set to get a brief pause in the four-and-a-half-year-old war so that aid can get in and residents can get out.

U.S. first lady Melania Trump brokered the localised ceasefire between Russia and Ukraine around Oleshky, a Russian-occupied city she said is "on the brink of disaster".

Ukrainian, Russian and U.S. negotiators reached the deal on Friday. Officials on all sides have confirmed it, but many details have not been released.

On Saturday, the first lady was asked about her work brokering a ceasefire between Russia and Ukraine in the ravaged Oleshky so that humanitarian aid can be delivered and civilians evacuated.

"It is great to have (the) Pope's support," she said, adding that the ceasefire is expected to start on October 27. "I hope everything goes as it's planned."

Asked if she had spoken with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy or Russian President Vladimir Putin, she and President Donald Trump said both.

"I think she's doing better than the professionals right now," the President added.

Asked if she will visit Ukraine, Ms. Trump responded: "We will see."

Oleshky is located in Ukraine's partially occupied Kherson region. It sits on the Dnipro River, which separates Ukrainian forces from the city's Russian occupiers. Moscow's forces captured it on the first day of the full-scale invasion in February 2022. Its buildings were shelled and burned.

Dam collapse

In June 2023, floodwaters swamped the city after the Kakhovka Dam collapsed in an explosion that an Associated Press investigation found was likely caused by the Russian military. Hundreds of residents were killed.

Once home to about 24,000 people, the city has had scarce food and medical supplies for months. There is no electricity, heat or running water. Roads out of town are mined and lined with burned-out cars, and drones buzz overhead. With another harsh winter approaching, those still there face death from hunger or disease.

Ukraine has repeatedly appealed for a local ceasefire to organise evacuations. As the occupying power, Russia is obligated under international law to make sure civilians under its control have what they need to survive.



An undated picture provided by an Ukrainian marine brigade in September shows smoke rising from a residential neighbourhood in the Russian-occupied city of Oleshky in Ukraine's Kherson region. AP

The deal sets out three stages: a ceasefire, then delivery of humanitarian aid, then evacuation of civilians who want to leave Oleshky, according to Dmytro Lubinets, Ukraine's human rights ombudsman and its chief negotiator in the talks. Before any aid moves, mines will be cleared on the routes into the city, Mr. Lubinets said.

Russia's human rights ombudswoman, Yana Lantratova, who took part in the negotiations, said firstly they plan to establish what residents need and then deliver food, medicine, hygiene products and other essentials. She said anyone who wants to leave the combat zone will be guaranteed safe passage.

Mr. Lubinets told the AP that the ceasefire will begin on Tuesday, two days before the humanitarian mission starts, and will last several days.

Russia's chief of the general staff, Gen. Valery Gerasimov, said Russian forces "will cease fire on the Kherson axis" from 4 a.m. on Tuesday Moscow time, which is late Monday in United States. He said Russian forces would also carry out "engineering reconnaissance" and ensure the "humanitarian convoy" can move safely into the city.

Ukraine's General Staff said the ceasefire will begin at 3 a.m. on Tuesday Kyiv time, since Ukraine moves its clocks back an hour on Sunday while Russia does not.

Mr. Lubinets said the pause would apply across the Kherson region and neighbouring areas essential to the operation.

He gave no details on how the ceasefire or the aid mission would be monitored or carried out, citing the sensitivity of the negotiations. He declined to say whether Ms. Trump would travel to Ukraine.

Evacuation of civilians

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said people who want to leave Oleshky will be able to. He would not say whether they would be taken to Russian- or Ukrainian-held territory. Asked how long the evacuation would last, he said only that it would most likely take several days.

"The operation will be carried out gradually and is extremely challenging to implement," Mr. Lubinets said.

The first lady began talks on Oleshky after she heard about the situation at one of her events during the U.N. General Assembly session in September, the White House said. She and a representative then worked directly with Russian and Ukrainian leadership to set the terms. She had already been working with officials from both countries on a separate matter.

"When Melania Trump learned about the situation in Oleshky, the negotiation process began under her coordination," Mr. Lubinets said. He said the sides spent several weeks discussing ideas and developing "new approaches, mechanisms and tools" to help civilians there survive.

Helping children in conflict zones has become one of her signature issues during her husband's second term. She hosted a U.N. Security Council meeting on the issue earlier this year. Last year she wrote to Russian President Vladimir Putin about efforts to reunite families with children she described as "displaced by the war."

British 'heirs of slavery' endorse reparations to Caribbean nations

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Caribbean nations campaigning for slavery reparations have won support from an unexpected source – the descendants of some of Britain's most prominent families to have benefitted from the slave trade.

As prime ministers, courtiers and aristocrats, the Gladstone, Lascelles and Trevelyan families were at the heart of the governing elite down the decades.

They accumulated significant wealth from slavery through the ownership of plantations in the West Indies and South America.

Laura Trevelyan, a former BBC journalist, told AFP she had been unaware of her family's involvement until hearing about an archive listing compensation payments to plantation owners triggered by the British parliament's abolition of slavery in 1833. "I was clueless," she told AFP.



People calling for slavery reparations protest outside the British High Commission in Kingston, Jamaica, in March 2022. AFP

"I looked at the database and saw this small island in the eastern Caribbean called Grenada that various members of the Trevelyan family had claimed compensation for the loss of what was termed their property."

The revelation spurred Ms. Trevelyan, who made a public apology in Grenada in 2023, to co-found the Heirs of Slavery group which supports "reparative justice".

With other members of her family, she has paid voluntary personal reparations of around £100,000 ($133,000) earmarked for educational projects.

Co-founder Charlie Gladstone, a descendant of reforming 19th century prime minister William Gladstone whose father John was one of the largest slave owners in the British West Indies, followed suit by making a public apology in Guyana in 2023.

Another group member is aristocrat David Lascelles, the Earl of Harewood, whose family has links to the royal family.

Riding the wind



A man plays with a baby at Vejers Strand even as gale-force winds hit the west coast of Jutland in Denmark on Sunday. REUTERS

Memory of October 7 tears at leftist heritage of kibbutz on Gaza border

Agence France-Presse
NAHAL OZ

Danny Rahamim pauses for a few moments as he thinks about his neighbours here on an Israeli kibbutz just a few hundred metres from Gaza.

"I'm probably the most left-wing person here," he said.

If that was true before October 7, 2023, when Hamas fighters stormed the border and carried out their unprecedented attack, it is even more true today, as Israel readies to vote in its first election since the country's deadliest ever day.

With a sun-tanned bald head and sporting small glasses, Mr. Rahamim has spent 50 of his 72 years here at Nahal Oz, which like many of Israel's kibbutzim – small communities in the countryside where all work is shared – has historically reflected the socialist ethos of the country's founders.

The kibbutzim were once bastions of the left, voting for peace with the Palestinians, but three years ago they found themselves on the frontlines of the Hamas attacks.

Sixteen of Nahal Oz's 400 residents were killed. Thanks to the proximity of a military base, Mr. Rahamim explained, the death toll was significantly lower than at the neighbouring kibbutzim of Kfar Aza, where 64 people died, or Beeri, where 102 died.

"People changed their minds" after the attack, he said.

"Most of them didn't turn right-wing. But they say they don't believe anymore that things can get better with our neighbours," said Mr. Rahamim, who serves as the kibbutz's spokesman.

"I'm not giving up," he said repeatedly under the flower-covered gazebo of his house.

The peace camp has nearly vanished from Israeli politics.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, the veteran right-winger whose long career is on the line in Tuesday's election, has run his campaign on promises of preventing a Palestinian state. His chief opponent, centre-right former military chief Gadi Eisenkot, has cast himself as being even more firmly opposed to it.

Anger in eyes

On the walls in Nahal Oz, the bullet holes have disappeared under a fresh coat of paint. But the memories remain ever-present. Mr. Rahamim said his own children tell him he is naive.



Dann points at the adjacent Gaza border from the Israeli Kibbutz of Nahal Oz in southern Israel. AFP

His grandson, who is almost four, rides his bicycle to the sound of birds chirping.

Above his yard, strewn with oranges that fell from trees, can be heard the constant buzzing of surveillance drones as Israel keeps an eye on the Gaza border.

"It looks quiet. But there were bodies everywhere," said his stepdaughter, Naama Zadok-Rahamim.

The 37-year-old community employee wears a black T-shirt paying tribute to one of her slain neighbours and a Star of David around her neck. In her eyes, there is anger.

"What I expect from leaders is real security – someone who's going to make sure that something like this doesn't happen again," she said.

During previous cycles of violence, when she heard the bombs falling on the other side of the border, she thought of the suffering of her "neighbours".

"Now it's hard for me to make the separation between Hamas and the other population. I don't know if there's much difference," she said.

Nadav Perez, a 44-year-old hospital worker, has always voted for the left or the far left.

Before the attack, he was involved in a project to build a clinic for patients from Gaza. The regional council official behind the initiative was killed defending his kibbutz in Kfar Aza.

"I wondered if the terrorists who killed him knew that their bullets were killing the idea of a better future," Mr. Perez said.

Since then, "my compassion is more blurred," he admitted, his one-year-old son in his arms.

"I'm sorry to say it," he said, "but I don't really care what's happening on the other side."

Ruins nearby

He said he had not decided how to vote in the election. But he will not vote for Mr. Netanyahu, angry he has not taken responsibility for the failure to prevent the October 7 attack.

Mr. Rahamim, for his part, will vote for the centre-left candidate Yair Golan, noting that he is the only major party leader who has made clear he would govern with lawmakers from Israel's Arab minority.

Looking out on Gaza from an observation post, he pointed to the fences that were so easily breached on October 7.

What once were the first houses on the Gaza side, just 750 metres away, are now nothing but rubble. In the distance, Gaza City also lies in ruins and a burst of gunfire rings out.

More than 10 years ago, his youngest daughter, then a teenager, had a panic attack during a bombing.

"'If we can hear these bombs so strongly here, how can the children of Gaza stand it?'" he recalled her saying.

"I thought to myself that maybe I had done something right," he said.

NEW HIGH

Deepti the first Indian woman to hit a century at No. 6 or lower



X@BCCIWOMEN

Deepti Sharma became the first Indian woman batter to score an ODI hundred at No. 6 or lower, going past Richa Ghosh's 94 against South Africa in the World Cup at Visakhapatnam last year. Deepti's unbeaten 106 is the second highest at No. 6 or lower in the format after Ashleigh Gardner's 115 (Aus vs. NZ, Indore, 2025).

SIGH OF RELIEF

Deepti's three-figure knock in ODIs comes after second-longest gap



X@BCCIWOMEN

Deepti's century, her second in ODIs, came 3450 days after her first (188 vs. Ireland, 2017). It is the second-longest gap between ODI hundreds after South African Marizanne Kapp's 3867 days. This is also the third-longest gap in women's cricket across formats after England's Molly Hide (5117 days between her two Test tons).

TWO TO TANGO

Harmanpreet-Deepti forge a record partnership for India



X@BCCIWOMEN

Harmanpreet Kaur and Deepti Sharma's 153-run stand in the second ODI against Zimbabwe is India's highest partnership for the fifth wicket or lower in women's ODIs. The previous best was the 122-run association between Sneh Rana and Pooja Vastrakar against Pakistan in the 2022 World Cup.

CLARITY

The key is to keep batting and enjoying myself: Harmanpreet



X@BCCIWOMEN

I just want to enjoy myself on the field. The key is to keep batting and enjoying myself... good to see that I am hitting the ball well. At the end of the day, that's what I want from myself. It wasn't a true wicket, it was holding a bit. The idea was to keep batting, and that gave us the result today — Harmanpreet Kaur.

Harmanpreet, Deepti on fire as India seals emphatic series win

Both slam centuries to power the home team past the 300-run mark; the spinners, led by Vaishnavi, run through the visitor's line-up

ZIMBABWE IN INDIA

Lavanya L.
VADODARA





Heavyweights: Harmanpreet and Deepti put the Zimbabwe attack to the sword before Vaishnavi spun a web around the batters. X@BCCIWOMEN

Picture this. Harmanpreet Kaur and Deepti Sharma scored centuries to power India to a big win. Now ask yourself: which of the two blazed her way to triple figures? If your gut said Harmanpreet, it failed you.

On a sweltering Sunday at the BCA Stadium in Kotambi, the second ODI against Zimbabwe turned the script on its head. A restrained Harmanpreet played the artisan while Deepti played destroyer, with their record-breaking 153-run fifth-wicket stand laying the foundation of India's 121-run win and unassailable 2-0 lead.

India was stuttering at 19 for two in the third over – Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma both undone by Nomvelo Sibanda's short-ball ploy – when Harmanpreet joined Pratika Rawal.

Pratika, fresh from a hundred in the first ODI, and Harmanpreet added 124 off 118 balls. The former looked set for another ton when Nyasha Gwanzura deceived her with a change of pace. Tejal Hasabnis followed soon after.

But Harmanpreet remained unfazed, aided by a fearless Deepti who arrived as if stepping in for a net session.

Audacious, classical

As many as 32 of the pair's first 47 runs came through Deepti's audacious shots on the leg-side while Harmanpreet whipped out a catalogue of puritanical drives and cuts on the off-side.

When the century came, celebrations oddly didn't. Neither did tears, like the 91 she scored in the third T20I had drawn out of her. Deepti, too, eventually braved a slowdown to reach her second ODI century in the final over – nine years after her first – helping India set an intimidating 329-run target.

Modester Mupachikwa's sprightly start, despite losing Loryn Phiri early, gave Zimbabwe hope.

With support from Chipo Mugeri-Tiripano, the Lady Chevrons got to 100 in just 19 overs, helped by India's worrying inability to take wickets, especially the seamers. Sayali Satghare finally succeeded in breaching Mugeri-Tiripano's defence.

Left-arm spinner Vaishnavi Sharma's guile and persistence then took centrestage. She removed Mupachikwa for her maiden ODI wicket before dismissing Beloved Biza, Michelle Mavunga and skipper Josephine Nkomo in a cluster.

Deepti ran through the tail before Jintimani Kalita opened her account in the format.

While Zimbabwe ticked one box by crossing 200, its bid to last the full 50 overs was yet to be achieved.

The scores: India 328/6 in 50 overs (Pratika Rawal 61, Harmanpreet Kaur 126, Deepti Sharma 106 n.o.) bt Zimbabwe 207 in 48.5 overs (Modester Mupachikwa 49, Chipo Mugeri-Tiripano 46, Beloved Biza 34, Deepti 3/32, Vaishnavi Sharma 4/39).

Toss: India; **PoM:** Harmanpreet.

Third ODI: October 28, 2 p.m.



Tough nut to crack: Sindhu's wait for a win over Se-young extended to 11 matches. BADMINTON PHOTO

Sindhu fails to solve the Se-young puzzle again

FRENCH OPEN

Press Trust of India
PARIS

P.V. Sindhu put up a spirited fight before going down to world No. 1 An Se-young of South Korea and finishing runner-up at the French Open Super 750 tournament here on Sunday. The Indian lost 21-16, 11-21, 12-21 to Se-young, who clinched her fourth French Open title and 11th crown of the season.

Sindhu used her reach and attacking strokes to take the opening game in 20 minutes.

It was only the second time in her career that she had managed to take a game off the Olympic gold medallist, whom she has never beaten in 11 meetings so far.

Se-young moved to a 3-0 lead while Sindhu reduced the deficit to 5-7 when the Korean sprayed a shot wide. But the 24-year-old clinched a superb 30-shot rally to take a four-point advantage at the break. A slew of errors from Sindhu followed as Se-young earned 12 game points before pocketing it on the fourth attempt.

Exciting rallies

The two played some exciting rallies in the decider. Sindhu had to contend with not only Se-young's quality but also the side drift.

A 36-shot exchange ended with the Indian going wide, but she kept fighting and established a three-point lead at 8-5.

The top-ranked shuttler, however, caught up at 8-8. After securing a two-point cushion at the interval, Se-young continued to stamp her authority and ran away with the contest.

A long shot gave the Korean eight match points, and she sealed the title at the first opportunity.



Cool customer: Shadab is over the moon after piloting Pakistan home in tailender Rauf's company. REUTERS

Ton-up Shadab scripts incredible win for Pakistan

ODI TRI-SERIES

Agencies
LAHORE

England snatched defeat from the jaws of victory again to leave its tri-series final hopes hanging by a thread as Shadab Khan's heroics scripted a stunning one-wicket win for Pakistan here on Sunday.

After Sri Lanka chased down 430 to win in Rawalpindi, England's bowlers were on course to bounce back when they reduced Pakistan to 154 for nine in pursuit of 242.

But Shadab (113 n.o., 96b, 13x4, 5x6) had other ideas. With just No. 11 Haris Rauf for company, all-rounder Shadab showed the urgency lacking from his top-order colleagues to register his maiden international hundred and take Pakistan home with 17 balls to spare.

Earlier, paceman Shaheen Afridi grabbed four wickets to limit England to 241. Ben Duckett (105) produced a fighting century after the visitors slipped to 19 for three.

The scores:
England 241 in 46.4 overs (Duckett 105, Curran 42, Afridi 4/46) lost to Pakistan 243/9 in 47.1 overs (Shadab 113 n.o., Overton 3/43).

Toss: Pakistan; **PoM:** Shadab.

New Zealand rotates pacers to manage workload

CRICKET

Press Trust of India
WELLINGTON

New Zealand has made several changes to its squad for the remaining matches of the T20I series against India, with pacers Lockie Ferguson and Matt Henry among those set to miss games as part of workload management.

Ferguson will rejoin the squad for the fourth and fifth T20Is while Henry will stay in Christchurch and link up with the ODI outfit on November 2.

Kyle Jamieson will remain in Wellington after the third T20I here on Tuesday and turn out for Canterbury in the second round of the Ford Trophy before rejoining for the ODI series. Blair Tickner will join the T20I squad in Wellington for the final three clashes while Josh Clarkson will link up with the team in Auckland for the last two games.

Matt Fisher will travel with the squad to Wellington as cover for the third T20I before returning to the New Zealand-A squad.

Man United sinks, Liverpool takes flight

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
MANCHESTER

Manchester United slumped further into crisis with a 0-3 home defeat to Bournemouth on Sunday, which plunged Michael Carrick's future as manager into doubt.

Carrick's bold decision to drop captain Bruno Fernandes backfired as defeat stretched United's winless run to eight games and left it 16th in the Premier League, just one point above the relegation zone.

Alexander Isak extended his hot streak in Liverpool's 2-0 win against Brighton. Liverpool struck twice in quick succession in the first half, with Pascal Gross' own goal followed by Isak's latest strike.

The results: Premier League: Crystal Palace 0 lost to Newcastle 2 (Osula 47, Barnes 58); Liverpool 2 (Gross 17-og, Isak 21) bt Brighton 0; Manchester United 0 lost to Bournemouth 3 (Rayan 38, Tavernier 43, Evanilson 71).
Serie A: Inter Milan 2 (Thuram 90+1, Zielinski 90+8-pen) bt Fiorentina 1 (Jimenez 65).
Bundesliga: Freiburg 1 (Bischof 82-og) lost to Bayern Munich 3 (Upamecano 16, Gnabry 42, Olise 90+5).
On Saturday: LaLiga: Valencia 1 (Pepelu 38-pen) lost to Villarreal 2 (Freeman 69, Mikautadze 90+6); Atletico Madrid 1 (Alvarez 48) bt Deportivo La Coruna 0.
Serie A: Napoli 3 (Anguissa 28, McTominay 48, 83) drew with Roma 3 (Soule 70, Balerdi 74, 89); Lazio 2 (Taylor 51, Diego Carlos 58-og) bt Parma 1 (Lontani 90+5).
Bundesliga: Borussia Dortmund 1 (Beier 80) bt Eintracht Frankfurt 0.



On target: Rayan starts off Bournemouth's scoring against United in the 38th minute. AFP

Denso Iris reigns supreme



Flying high: Denso proved too good for Sichuan in the summit clash. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

BASKETBALL

K. Keerthivasan
BENGALURU

The best part about Denso Iris (Japan) is that it did not rely solely on its foreign imports, unlike most teams in the FIBA Women's Basketball League Asia at the Sree Kanteerava Indoor Stadium here. Instead, it thrived on collective effort, with every player contributing and the foreigners complementing the team's overall game.

On Sunday, in the final against favourite Sichuan Yuanda Meile (China), it underlined the strength of that approach. Iris' commanding 81-63 victory over the Chinese side was a powerful vindication of its philosophy. It became the first team from Japan to win the title.

Sichuan, heavily dependent on American Chennedy Carter and Australian Sara Blicavs, struggled to find its attacking rhythm. Carter was disqualified early in the second quarter after picking up two technical fouls, while Blicavs was not at her best. With Iris's defence denying it the space to operate freely, Sichuan found it increasingly difficult to raise the tempo.

Iris' disciplined approach and sustained intensity were reflected in the way it built its advantage quarter after quarter, moving from 24-20 after the first quarter to 43-36 at half-time before sealing an 81-63 victory.

The 37-year-old Maki Takada, a three-time Olympian, was a striking example of experience triumphing over age.

Neither exceptionally quick nor overly aggressive, the veteran centre relied on composure, sound positioning to finish as the game's top scorer with 23 points, including seven two-pointers and a three-pointer. G. Parameshwara, Deputy Chief Minister of Karnataka, gave away the prizes.

The results: Final: Denso Iris (Japan) 81 (Maki Takada 23, Haruna Kasagi 15, Mai Kawai 13) bt Sichuan Yuanda Meile (China) 63 (Sara Blicavs 18, Gao Song 12, Chennedy Carter 11).

Third-place match:
Cathay Life Tigers (Chinese Taipei) 73 (Shelbynal Cheyanne Cheslek 24, Penina Davidson 20) bt KB Stars (South Korea) 68 (Yunjeong Na 22, Yeeun Heo 18, Yunha Song 15).

INBRIEF



James Anderson's future unclear after Lancashire exit

England's record Test wicket-taker James Anderson will leave Lancashire after the club announced on Sunday that it would not renew his contract, casting doubts over the 44-year-old's future. "I've supported Lancashire since I was a kid, and to play for them for 25 years was a dream come true," Anderson said on social media. "I have always found it special walking out to play at Old Trafford and have some incredible memories of doing so, including the honour of being captain." Anderson revealed that the decision to part ways with the club had been taken out of his hands. "If it was up to me it wouldn't have ended like this, but I wish the players and fans all the best for the future".



Rybakina beats Fernandez, wins fourth title of the season

World No. 1 Elena Rybakina won her fourth title of an outstanding season with a ruthless straight-sets victory over Leylah Fernandez in the Ningbo Open final on Sunday. The top seed and defending champion cruised to a 6-2, 6-2 win in 73 minutes over the World No. 30 from Canada. Rybakina, the Australian and US Open champion, collected her 15th WTA crown in all and went a long way towards securing the year-end number-one ranking.



Yuki clinches doubles title at Almaty Open

India's Yuki Bhambri won his first ATP Tour title of the 2026 season, partnering Ryan Seggerman of USA to clinch the Almaty Open with a thrilling 7-6(3), 6-7(1), [10-2] victory over top seeds Lucas Miedler and Neil Oberleitner of Austria on Sunday. This victory at the ATP 250 tournament fetched Yuki his fifth career doubles title on the ATP Tour.

Lalit enters bronze-medal bout, three other Indians lose

Lalit kept India's hopes of a rare Greco-Roman World Championships medal alive by advancing to the bronze-medal bout with a convincing 7-0 victory over American Max Emiliano Nowry in Astana. He will take on Kazakhstan's Iskhar Kurbayev in the bronze medal play-off, with an opportunity to add to India's limited success in Greco-Roman wrestling at the global level. Sandeep Tulsi Yadav is the only Indian to win a World Championship medal, in 2013, claiming a bronze. However, it was a disappointing day for three other Indian wrestlers, including Asian Games silver medallist Nitesh Siwach, who fell by the wayside.

India beats Cameroon at FIFA U15 World Cup & Festival

India continued its winning run at the inaugural FIFA U15 World Cup & Festival Azerbaijan 2026, defeating Cameroon 2-1 in its second Group K match in Baku on Sunday.

The result: India 2 (Fareil Ngobo 1-og, R Lalremruatfela 27) bt Cameroon 1 (Muhammad Sohil Khan 20-og).

LIVE TELECAST

Ranji Trophy: day 1, JioHotstar, 9 a.m.
ISL: Sony LIV app, 7.30 p.m.
LaLiga: FanCode, 1.30 a.m. (Tuesday)
New Zealand-A vs India-A: First 'Test' day 4, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 3.30 a.m. (Tuesday)

Confident Tamil Nadu and Railways determined to operate at full steam

Sai Kishore's men approach the game with optimism after having posted an innings victory over Uttarakhand in the previous round

RANJI TROPHY

Sankar Narayanan E.H.
CHENNAI

Two-time Ranji Trophy champion Tamil Nadu won just once last season.

The 2026-27 campaign, comparatively, has started positively for Sai Kishore & Co. (eight points from two games). Seven of those eight points came from their innings victory over Uttarakhand in the previous round.

Their opening fixture – an away match against Rajasthan in Jaipur – ended in a draw, with TN conceding the first-innings lead to settle for a solitary point.

As Tamil Nadu welcomes Railways for this Elite Group-D clash at the MAC Stadium, the host will strive for nothing short of another outright win.

Bhargav Merai's men arrive having faced the same opponents as Tamil Nadu (in reverse order), getting just two points from as many draws. While they conceded 470 against Uttarakhand in Mumbai (Brabourne Stadium), the score swelled to 497 against Rajasthan in the Pink City.

Railways head coach Syed Zakaria Zuffri acknowledged that his team lacked exposure in the bowling department.

"We have a bit of inexperience in the bowling attack... that is our only concern. All the bowlers are young. However, we achieved three consecutive outright wins with a similar attack last season. It is just a matter of time," Zakaria said on Sunday.

The Tamil Nadu bowling unit, on the other hand, is high on confidence, having shot out Uttarakhand for 134 and 113. The team will again bank on lefties Gurjapneet Singh (four wickets in the first innings), Sai Kishore (10 in the match) and Ajith Ram (four in the second essay) to deliver, though the speedster may have to shoulder a bigger workload if the overcast conditions keep the ball swinging.

While both teams got their practice time under the sun on Saturday, Sunday's cloud and rain had them training indoors. They'll be hoping for no Monday blues – and a clear blue sky.



Spin twins: Tamil Nadu will once again bank on the left-arm duo of Sai Kishore and Ajith Ram to deliver the goods. R. RAGU

RANJI TROPHY - THIRD ROUND SCHEDULE

Elite: Group A: Baroda vs. Jammu & Kashmir (Vadodara); Madhya Pradesh vs. Bihar (Indore); Vidarbha vs. Goa (Nagpur); Pondicherry vs. Uttar Pradesh (Puducherry).
Group B: Andhra vs. Chhattisgarh (Vijayawada); Hyderabad vs. Punjab (Hyderabad); Karnataka vs. Tripura (Mysuru); Saurashtra vs. Assam (Rajkot).
Group C: Jharkhand vs. Delhi (Ranchi); Odisha vs. Services (Bhubaneswar); Maharashtra vs. Gujarat (Pune); Kerala vs. Bengal (Thiruvananthapuram).
Group D: Uttarakhand vs. Rajasthan (Dehradun); Tamil Nadu vs. Railways (Chennai); Chandigarh vs. Himachal Pradesh (Chandigarh); Mumbai vs. Haryana (Mumbai).
Plate: Sikkim vs. Nagaland (Rangpo); Manipur vs. Arunachal Pradesh (Ahmedabad); Mizoram vs. Meghalaya (Nadiad).

Padikkal, Sai Sudharsan rescue India-A after openers' poor show

INDIA-A IN NZ

Press Trust of India
LINCOLN

Devdutt Padikkal and Sai Sudharsan batted resolutely to guide India-A to 106 for two in its second innings even as the openers came up with yet another disappointing show on the second day of the first 'Test' against New Zealand-A here on Sunday.

Yashasvi Jaiswal and K.L. Rahul flopped for the second time in the match, leaving India-A reeling at 10 for two, before Padikkal (56 batting off 89 balls, 9x4) and Sai Sudharsan (39 batting off 104 balls, 5x4) stabilised the innings with an unbeaten 96-run third-wicket stand.

Padikkal was the aggressor while Sai Sudharsan played second fiddle.

India-A, which was bowled out for a meagre 113 in the first essay, trails New Zealand-A by 98 runs with two days of play remaining.

Earlier, the home team was all out for 317 after resuming at 135 for three.

Dean Foxcroft (51) struck a half-century while Kristian Clarke (42), in at No. 9, also contributed to help New Zealand-A secure a first-innings advantage in excess of 200.

Too many extras

The India-A bowlers lacked discipline throughout, conceding an alarming 46 runs in extras.

The pace duo of Anshul Kamboj (three for 52) and Auqib Nabi (three for 69) shared six wickets between them while Akash Deep accounted for two batters.

The scores: India-A 113 & 106/2 in 36 overs (Devdutt Padikkal 56 batting) vs. New Zealand-A 317 in 89.3 overs (Rhys Mariu 76, Curtis Heaphy 44, Dean Foxcroft 51, Kristian Clarke 42).

Sharath recalls five-year 'fruitful journey' as a national selector

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

For the last five years, S. Sharath has been a key member of the Indian cricket set-up, serving twice as chairman of the junior committee and three years as a senior selector.

During his stints, the India under-19 team won World Cups in 2022 and 2026, and he also helped select the senior squads that won the 2024 T20 World Cup and the 2025 ICC Champions Trophy.

"It has been a very fruitful journey to be able to contribute to Indian cricket. I missed out on playing for the country, but God has been kind enough to let me contribute in a different role.

"I am grateful for the support of N. Srinivasan sir, K.S. Viswanathan sir, Jay (bhai) Shah and my family," said Sharath.

"It was a team effort, and I was blessed to work with some great former cricketers in both committees. I also have to mention Rahul Dravid and V.V.S. Laxman, and the CoE's support."

The former Tamil Nadu batter gave an insight into what makes a good selector. "First thing is you should disassociate yourself from the fact that you were a former player and come with an open mind. The game has evolved, and you should understand the demands of the team combination," said the 53-year-old.

"Skills are always there, but it is the mental side of the game that is important. A selector must be empathetic. You have more bad days than good days as a player, and how you react on a bad day tells how good a player is."

"If you are a batter, small things like whether he is switched on while at the non-striker's end helping his partner or as a bowler whether he is running in hard through the day, these are things you observe."

On the highlights of his tenure, "In 2021, when I took over as chairman, we were in the midst of a pandemic. Our young boys hadn't played any cricket for two years. So, putting together a team in a short time and winning the World Cup was special. The highlight for me will be the 2023 ODI World Cup. Though we lost in the final, we were the dominant team in that tournament and played an exciting brand of cricket."



Long association: Sharath says he is blessed to have worked with legends like Dravid. THE HINDU ARCHIVES

Kerala Blasters shares the spoils with Mumbai City

ISL

P.K. Ajith Kumar
KOCHI

The Nehru Stadium turned yellow once again. After a long, long time.

The Yellow Army was back in full strength for Kerala Blasters' opening home fixture of the ISL season on Sunday night. The fans began making noise long before the match against Mumbai City FC started. And they got louder, and louder.

All that must have sounded music to the ears of the Blasters men out on the field; they hadn't played before a crowd like that for any match last season. And the match was a fascinating one, too. But, sadly, it didn't produce even a single goal. Both teams had enough opportunities, though.

A combination of solid defending, some splendid saves by the goalkeepers and some inept finishing ensured the match ended in a goalless draw. After the crushing defeat to North-East United in the last match, coach Ashley Westwood must have been hoping for a win at home for the Blasters. He must have been disappointed; his counterpart, Manolo Marquez, would have been the happier of the two to take the one point.

The host had an excellent chance to take the lead as early as the fifth minute. A fine cross from the left flank by Mohammed Sanan, whose pace beat the Mumbai defence, found Adrian Luna. The Uruguayan's diving header, though, went wide.

Such misses would continue to be the recurring theme of the night. The well-orchestrated attacks from either team would never get the desired ending. Credit is also due to the men under the bar – Blasters' Amrinder Singh and Mumbai's T.P. Rehenesh.

The results: At Kochi: Kerala Blasters 0 drew with Mumbai City FC 0. **At Margao:** Churchill Brothers 2 (37, 45+2) lost to Punjab FC 3 (Messi Bouli 13-pen, Alfred 40, Sanathoi 90+5).



Keeping danger at bay: Mumbai's 'keeper Rehenesh effects a great save. THULASI KAKKAT

Dhruv Goswami, Balaprasath share FLGB4 honours

MOTORSPORTS

Sports Bureau
COIMBATORE

Meco Racing's Dhruv Goswami and Dark Don Racing's Balaprasath shared a race win each in the premier Formula LGB4 category of the CTR-JK Tyre FMSCI Indian National Car Racing Championship here on Sunday.

The season's opening round saw rain and safety car interruptions for most part. It was quite a challenge for the drivers but Dhruv and Balaprasath held their nerve to steal the show.

Anish Shetty called the shots in the pro class of the Royal Enfield Continental GT Cup. He moved his way up from the fifth position to cross the line ahead of Navaneeth Kumar.

In the amateur category, Kabir Sahoch completed a weekend hat-trick, fending off early chaos and a collision between Shyamal Das and Akash Boro to win by 1.793 seconds with a fastest lap of 1:19.452.

Pratik Sonawane completed a weekend sweep in the Gentleman class with a flawless pole-to-flag win by 5.053 seconds over Sidharth Balasundaram in the JK Tyre Levitas Cup. Aadam Junaid made it two wins in two starts in the rookie class. Team N1 Intervalve's Biren Pithawalla won a chaotic, rain-hit Indian Super Touring Cars finale by 2.480s.

The results (provisional):
LGB Formula 4: Race 1: Dhruv Goswami (Meco Racing) 21:59.775; 2. Mehul Agarwal (Dark Don Racing) 22:00.131; 3. Arya Singh (Dark Don Racing) 22:00.505. **Race 2:** 1. Balaprasath (Dark Don Racing) 15:42.097; 2. Mehul Agarwal 15:42.489; 3. Raghul Rangasamy (Meco Racing).
RE Continental GT Cup (professionals): Race 1: Anish Shetty 13:13.577; 2. Navaneeth Kumar 13:17.668; 3. Senthil Kumar 13:18.610.
Indian Super Touring Cars: 1. Biren Pithawalla (Team N1 Intervalve) 16:23.827; 2. Arjun Narendran (Arka Motorsports) 16:26.307; 3. Anant Pithawalla (Team N1 Intervalve) 17:01.631.
Indian Touring Cars: 1. Aman Nagdev (Team Performance Racing) 16:25.006; 2. Vidyaprakash Damodaran (Team Performance Racing) 16:43.143; 3. Nikanth Rambalu (Team Perfomance Racing) 16:54.127.
JK Tyre Levitas Cup: Gentleman: 1. Pratik Sonawane 14:44.279; 2. Sidharth Balasundaram 14:49.332; 3. Vinith Kumar 14:52.419. **Rookie:** 1. Aadam Junaid 14:54.128; 2. Shreyans Mittal 15:24.979; 3. Ajay Sankar 15:24.980.
Indian Junior Touring Cars: 1. Deepak Ravikumar (Team Performance Racing) 14:11.882; 2. Srinivas Teja (Team Performance Racing) 14:11.997; 3. Ramcharan Chandran 14:21.844.



Dhruv Goswami, who won a thriller in the Formula LGB4 race.

Tilak — the yo-yo man of India's T20 set-up



ANI

Like Kohli during a chase, he somehow swaps his brain for a computer; he works out angles and areas to target and bowlers to attack, mentally recalibrating with every passing over and somehow insulating himself from the rising levels of panic that manifest themselves in addled decision-making when push comes to shove

R. Kaushik

Versatility is a wonderful virtue to possess in any sphere of life. To be very good at more than one discipline is a grand trait not bestowed upon many. True, one must work unbelievably hard to maximise that gift, but as they say in a sporting parlance, primarily, you make your own luck.

Versatility can also be counter-productive, especially in a setting like a team sport. And in the context of Indian cricket, specifically.

Take Rahul Dravid as a case in point. Because he was so adept at so many different and often unrelated aspects, he was moved out of his comfort zone so many times that towards the end, even he may not have been sure what his comfort zone was. Need someone to fill the breach in Test cricket as an opener? Hey, there's Rahul, you know. Need someone to drop down the order to accommodate a more attacking option at No. 3, as famously happened at the Eden game against Australia in 2001? Don't look beyond Rahul. Looking for a dependable 'finisher' in 50-over internationals, long before that term became fashionable? Surely, Rahul? Require a gun batter to also don the wicketkeeping gloves because it can extend the batting order, provide a specialist option at No. 7 and not affect the balance one bit? Hello, wasn't Rahul a wicketkeeper at school?

The same path

It's amazing how his namesake from the same city has walked pretty much the same path. K.L. Rahul is the modern-day equivalent of Rahul Dravid, having donned each of the roles his illustrious predecessor did during a wonderful career that ran between 1995 and 2012. In those 17 years, just about the only thing Dravid didn't do was keep wickets to his own bowling - he even took two wickets in an over in an ODI against South Africa in Kochi in March 2000, getting rid of left-handers Gary Kirsten and Lance Klusener with his off-spin. Perhaps the only reason 'KL' doesn't have an international wicket is that successive captains from Mahendra Singh Dhoni to Shubman Gill, himself included, haven't yet summoned him to the bowling crease.

Tilak has remained unbeaten in 26 chases in all T20s, 12 of them in country vs country battles, and finished on the winning side every single time

Tilak Varma hasn't done all of the above things - he hasn't even made his Test debut or opened the batting in white-ball internationals, though he does boast five T20I wickets - but he is fast emerging as the ultimate yo-yo man of the current T20I set-up. India's vice-captain in the 20-over format provides the classic case of being asked to play the situation.

He doesn't have a fixed batting position even though he has made no secret of the fact that his preferred slot is No. 3, from where he has uncorked both his international centuries. Forget about fixed, there is no guarantee that he will occupy the same berth for two games in a row - indeed, he has batted at a different slot in each of his last three innings - and yet, that hasn't come in the way of an average of 44.13 and a strike-rate of 147.47 after 68 T20I innings.

Virat Kohli is acknowledged as the ultimate chaser in white-ball history and it is hard to argue with that tag, given how many times he has made the impossible look commonplace. But how is this for a stat? Tilak has remained unbeaten in 26 chases in all T20s, 12 of them in country vs country battles, and finished on the winning side every single time. What do you make of that, Virat?

The wirily elegant left-hander's latest masterpiece came at the Hagley Oval in Christchurch on Saturday, in a match few believed was headed India's way. New Zealand's 180 for five was already a lot more than it read numerically, and assumed even more gargantuan proportions after India played themselves into a hole at 70 for five, skipper Mitchell Santner accounting for three of those wickets with his parsimonious, penetrative left-arm spin.

Tilak had walked in at 69 for four and taken a single off his first delivery from Santner, only for Axar Patel to be dismissed next ball, caught at long-on. India needed 111 off 55 deliveries with Tilak one ball young, and Naman Dhir and Nitish Kumar to follow. The odds of them pulling off a second consecutive stiff run-chase were pretty long.

But over the last year or so particularly, the 23-year-old Tilak has showcased a skillset that is clearly out of the ordinary. Like Kohli during a chase, he somehow swaps his brain for a computer, working out angles and areas to target and bowlers to attack, mentally recalibrating with every passing over and somehow insulating himself from the rising levels of panic that manifest themselves in addled decision-making when push comes to shove.

Instant hero

The Hyderabadi had become an instant hero to millions in September last year when he wrenched the T20 Asia Cup final rudely out of Pakistan's hands. In the third successive Sunday showdown between the sides in the desert sands of Dubai, Pakistan seemed on course to avenge defeats over the two previous weekends and win the match that mattered the most by having India on the mat at 20 for three in response to their 146 all out, courtesy a dramatic meltdown that saw them lose their last nine wickets for 33 runs after looking good for 180, at the very least, at various stages.

Batting at No. 4, Tilak strung together a 57-run stand for the fourth wicket with a struggling, out-of-sorts Sanju Samson (24 off 21) before finding excellent support from the vastly underrated Shivam Dube. The tall left-hander contributed 33 in an alliance of 60 but when he departed off the last ball of the penultimate over, a nervy India still needed 10 with the speedy but profligate Haris Rauf thrown the ball by Salman Agha.

Tilak settled all the nerves with a thumping six off the second ball, smearing the short offering over the deep backward square-leg fence for a resounding six. Rinku Singh applied the finishing touches but there was no disputing who the real hero was. Tilak finished undefeated on 69 off 53 with only three fours and four sixes, but the timing of those boundaries complemented his hard running superbly as India pulled the fat out of the fire with something to spare.

He doesn't have a fixed batting position even though he has made no secret of the fact that his preferred slot is No. 3, from where he has uncorked both his international centuries

The stakes were just as high in Nisshin earlier this month when India faced their arch-rivals, again, in the final of the Asian Games. This time, India batted first and seemed to have sold themselves a few short, despite opener Abhishek Sharma's blazing 28-ball 61, when Tilak exploded in a frenzy of fours and sixes. Batting at No. 6, he reached his 50 off a mere 21 deliveries, helping India amass a frenetic 78 runs off the last 35 deliveries of the innings, a decisive contribution given that their final margin of victory was 19 runs.

In Christchurch on Saturday, there was just a straightforward victory - how extraordinarily naively simplistic to put it thus - on the line. No Asia Cup trophy (which India are still to receive, lest it should be forgotten), no Asian Games gold medal. Just a regular, regulation win and the chance to go 2-0 up with three to play, But this was neither a straightforward, nor a regular and regulation task, not with the top five back in the hut and Tilak having to make do with only Nos. 7 and 8 for meaningful company.

He wasn't coming off a great immediate sequence of scores himself - 7 off 6 balls (at No. 5) in the rain-ruined game against West Indies in Bengaluru last Saturday, then 6 off 11 (at No. 3) in Thursday's first T20I in Christchurch. His return to the middle-order was promoted by the adductor muscle injury to Ishan Kishan that brought Vaibhav Sooryavanshi into the XI at No. 3, but Tilak didn't allow being tugged around repeatedly to faze him.

"I have said before that I want to finish games for the country," Tilak had said in Bengaluru after the abandoned game. "I love doing that job. For me as an individual, it will be easier batting at No. 3 and finishing games. But Ishan is batting brilliantly at No. 3 and for me now, there is no option but to bat at 5 and 6 and do the job for the team.

Mentally prepared

"I am mentally prepared for that role. I have won a few games from there. As a finisher, most of the times in T20s, you will get a maximum of 5-6 overs to bat, so you have to play your strokes from ball one. I have batted up the order from my childhood, therefore I am confident that whether I bat at 3 and 5, I have got both the techniques where I can adapt (to the demands of each role)."

Perfect chasing template

As if to show that that was no empty boast, Tilak produced the perfect chasing template at the Hagley Oval. He also played it smart. Knowing that spin was doing the trick for New Zealand and that therefore to attempt anything outrageous against Santner and offie Michael Bracewell was nothing if not foolhardy, he bided his time, waiting for pace to be brought back into the attack. He didn't, however, let the spinners apply the choke. First with the increasingly impressive Dhir and then with Nitish, Tilak ran wonderfully well between the wickets, using the dimensions of the ground to such great advantage that you could have been forgiven for mistakenly believing that he had played all his cricket at the Hagley.



AFP

Even when the task became more and more difficult - 46 needed off the last three overs - Tilak kept his wits about him. By now, Dhir had perished after a terrific cameo, 31 off 17, but Nitish was chugging along nicely. Tilak switched gears without seeming to, two fours in the 18th over (from Jacob Duffy) the precursor to three fours and a six from the next, sent down by Nathan Smith. That brought the equation down to a manageable 11 off the last over and Tilak calmly battered Duffy's second ball wide of mid-off for four to practically finish off the chase.

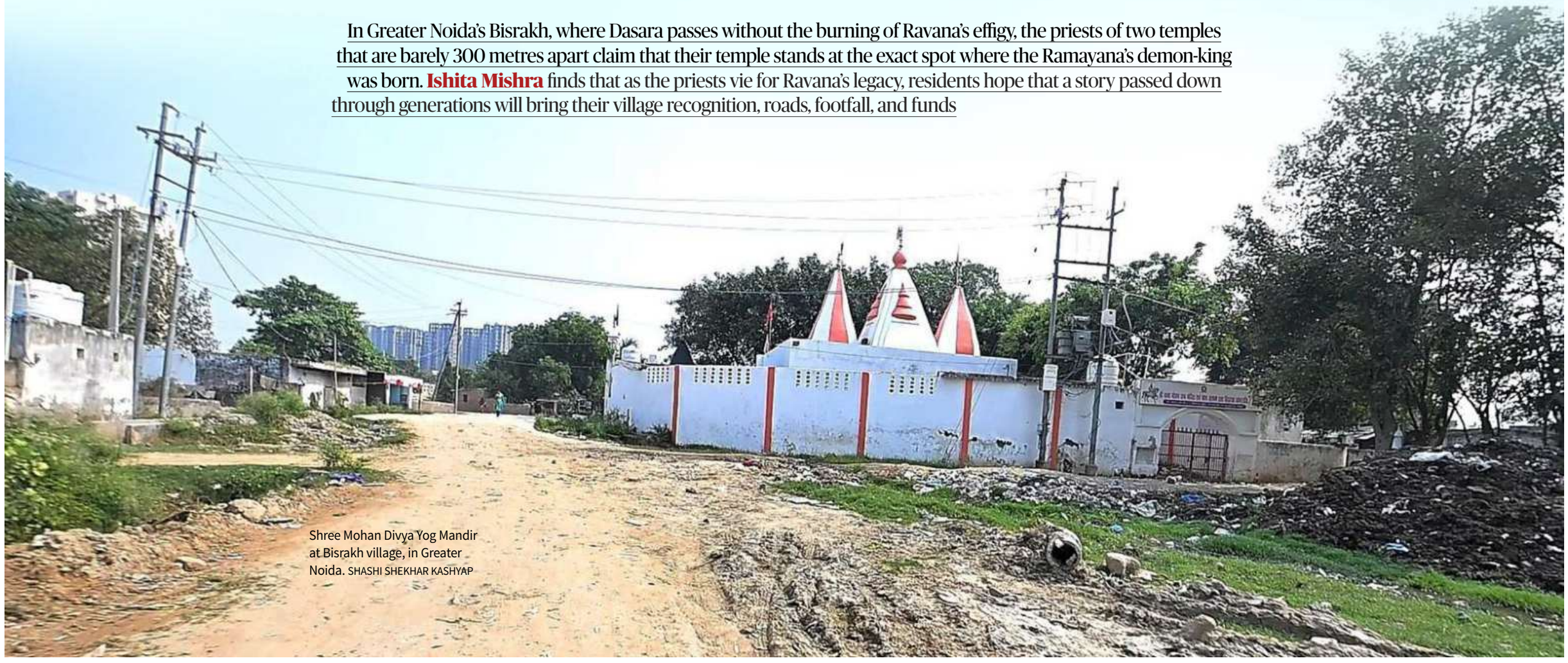
By the time Nitish formally heralded victory, Tilak had conjured a 25-ball half-century and reiterated his chasing credentials. No. 3 might be his favourite position, but how can he expect to get a sustained run there when he is so good at No. 5 and 6 and 7 when he refuses to take a backward step. Tilak is working zealously on the approach - batting-wise and mentally - needed in the middle order, and is well on his way to mastering it. To say that he won't be occupying the No. 3 slot on even a semi-permanent basis in a hurry is no exaggeration, but no one, not even he, is complaining.

THE GIST

- Tilak produced the perfect chasing template at the Hagley Oval. He also played it smart. Knowing that spin was doing the trick for New Zealand and that therefore to attempt anything outrageous against Santner and offie Michael Bracewell was nothing if not foolhardy, he bided his time
- The wirily elegant left-hander's latest masterpiece came at the Hagley Oval in Christchurch on Saturday, in a match few believed was headed India's way
- Tilak is working zealously on the approach – batting-wise and mentally – needed in the middle order, and is well on his way to mastering it

A development dream linked to Ravana's birthplace

In Greater Noida's Bisrakh, where Dasara passes without the burning of Ravana's effigy, the priests of two temples that are barely 300 metres apart claim that their temple stands at the exact spot where the Ramayana's demon-king was born. **Ishita Mishra** finds that as the priests vie for Ravana's legacy, residents hope that a story passed down through generations will bring their village recognition, roads, footfall, and funds



Shree Mohan Divya Yog Mandir at Bisrakh village, in Greater Noida. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

A day before Vijayadashami, Lekh Raj, 45, a debutant vlogger, eager to go viral, stood outside a plastered but unpainted temple in Bisrakh, a village in Greater Noida, some 30 kilometres from Delhi.

He adjusted the phone on his selfie stick and rehearsed the script his teenage son had drafted. Around him there were no festive crowds and no towering effigies waiting to be set alight, none of the signs of celebration unfolding across much of the country.

In the Hindu mythological saga the *Ramayana*, Vijayadashami (victory on the 10th day) is the day Lord Rama vanquished Ravana, the 10-headed demon-king of what is now Sri Lanka. The festival celebrates the triumph of good over evil.

"What you are seeing behind me is not just any village temple," says Raj, speaking into his phone camera, turning it from his face to the entrance of the modest shrine called Prachin Shiv Mandir.

Behind him, an elderly priest, his matted locks tied around his head, is garlanding a figure of Ravana carved into the wall.

Raj continues speaking into his phone: "This temple has a legend more unusual than most. It is the birthplace of Ravana, the only place where the demon king is a son of the soil and Dasara is not a festival." He adds that the village derives its name from Ravana's father, sage Vishrava.

For decades, Bisrakh had one temple, a *swayambhu* (self-born) Shiva shrine, which was known as Ravana's birthplace. Then, in 2000, the Shree Mohan Divya Yog Mandir came up, barely 300 metres away and contested the claim.

For Raj and several other content creators on social media, this is gold. People have told him that beginning a video at the temple could bring him luck. The algorithm – hungry for online newness that could spiral upward into a trend – may grant him his wish to be famous.

Divine dreams and a temple's renewal

Mahant Ramdas, caretaker of the original temple most villagers regard as Ravana's birthplace, has expanded the shrine into a sprawling complex. Hailing from Kanpur Dehat in Uttar Pradesh, Ramdas claims to have seen the temple in a "divine dream" over four decades ago. He sought it out and found the place lying neglected in the forest, he says.

It now has three worship areas, residential quarters for 10 priests, a bathing space, a garden, and a large open ground for festival gatherings.

He also managed to get huge land donations from villagers to construct another temple, in front of the existing one, dedicated to various goddesses.

He also governs another temple in Rajasthan, he claims, as his students travel across north India to perform *Bhagwat Katha* (reciting the holy book *Bhagwat*) and *Rudrabhishek* (a bathing ritual associated with Lord Shiva).

Pointing towards the dimly lit sanctum, Ramdas says that the *Shivalinga* inside is "taller than a mountain" and no one could dig its roots out. "When we tried to (during the reconstruction process), snakes started coming out from the earth. This work was stopped and since then we have locked the basement of the sanctum," he shares, further emphasising the ancientness of the temple.

The priest points towards a newly constructed section of the temple, where the bust of Ravana is placed side by side with Lord Rama.

"Nowhere in the world will you find Ravana being worshipped with Ram," he says.

For Raj, this is precisely the kind of image that might attract travellers and pilgrims. As he pans his camera across the complex, he also captures boards bearing the names of donors.

He repeats several of the claims he hears from the priest and local residents before pausing to ask Ramdas a question.

"How come Ravana, who was born to a sage in Greater Noida, became the king of Lanka, situated miles away?" he asks Ramdas. The priest offers Raj's audience a legend.

"Parvati, Shiva's wife, was adamant about having a palace of her own. Shiva commissioned the job to Vishwakarma, the divine architect, who crafted the breathtaking city of Lanka out of solid gold. To perform the house-warming, Vishrava, Ravana's father, was called. Deeply pleased with Vishrava's rituals, Shiva offered him anything he wanted," Ramdas says. Driven by ambition, the sage asked for the golden city itself, he adds.

Shiva granted it, and that is how Lanka became the inherited realm of Vishrava's lineage. It was first passed to Kubera, the god of wealth, before Ravana seized it from his half-brother and established his reign.

The *Uttar Ramayana,* which talks about the lives of Lord Rama and Sita, after their return to Ayodhya, describes Ravana as the son of sage Vishrava and Kaikesi, the descendant of Pulastya who is a mind-borne son of Brahma. This claim finds a mention in mythological author Devdutt Pattanaik's articles titled: *What is Ravana's Surname?* The article also mentions the presence of Sal forests in his maternal region has led scholars to question the traditional belief that the early *Ramayana*'s geography extended far south of the Vindhya and Narmada rivers. Keen to boast of Ravana's lineage, Ramdas adds, "Ravana was such a wise Brahmin that even Ram had performed penance and prayers after killing him."

A new site and claims of an old home

In the newly built temple, Acharya Ashokanand repeats the story of Ravana's journey to Lanka, adding that it is this temple's premises that he was born in.

Ashokanand identifies himself as *Mahamandaleshwar*, a title given to Hindu monks within the *Dashanami* tradition of *Shaivite* ascetics. Ashokanand, who generally wears trousers and T-shirts changes into a saffron robe whenever a devotee arrives in the temple. He also says Bisrakh was mentioned in the *Shiva Purana*, one of the 18 in the *purana* series of religious texts. He immediately opens a page in *Kalyan*, a book published by Gita Press, which mentions a river called Harnad, which he claims is today's Hindon and described Bisrakh as the birthplace of Ravana and his half-brother Kubera.



"I do not contest the ancientness of the Shivlinga in the other temple. It was the place where Ravana's father used to worship. But my temple was his house. People don't give birth in temples. They give birth in homes. So the place I own is Ravana's real *janmabhoomi* (birthplace)," he says, while drawing a parallel to the Ram *janmabhoomi* in Ayodhya.

> In 2016, I was the first to propose the installation of a statue of Ravana in the temple. But the statue was vandalised by fringe groups that opposed it.
>
> **ACHARYA ASHOKANAND**
> MAHAMANDALESHWAR OF SHREE MOHAN DIVYA YOG MANDIR



> Ravana was such a wise Brahmin that even Ram had performed penance and prayers after killing him.
>
> **MAHANT RAMDAS**
> Caretaker of Shiva shrine, Ravana's birthplace in Bisrakh

Here, a temple was built at the exact site where the idol of Ram Lalla was placed in 1949. Over the years, it led courts to fist lock up the Babri Mosque structure, then allow Hindu worship inside, eventually turning that spot into the legal anchor of the dispute.

In his temple spread across about 1,600 metres, statues of various Hindu gods, including Rama and Hanuman, stand. Ravana's is absent. "In 2016, I was the first to propose the installation of a statue of Ravana in the temple. But the statue was vandalised by fringe groups that opposed it. At that time, Ramdas also objected. He said that Ravana could not be worshipped as he was a demonic figure. But later, he himself installed Ravana's statue," he alleges. He adds that he has now ordered a taller statue of Ravana, which will be ready in time for Vijayadashami next year.

Claiming the *Ramayana*, written by Valmiki, has unnecessarily vilified Ravana, Ashokanand says that the demon-king never abducted Sita with an aim to make her his queen. "He abducted Sita to ensure his own sister Surpanakha was safe. He never touched Sita. She was kept with an all-woman army. He never met Sita in Lanka," he claims. When asked about Ravana proposing to Sita in Valmiki's *Ramayana*, he says it has many flaws.

Over 300 versions of the *Ramayana* exist globally, ranging from Valmiki's Sanskrit foundational text to international adaptations like Thailand's *Ramakien*. Sri Lanka uniquely preserves this legacy through its own cultural lens, honouring king Ravana as a heroic ruler.

Meanwhile, in the village

Confused between the legacy claims of two temples situated within walking distance, Raj decides to speak to the residents of Bisrakh, which has a population of around 5,000 people, including Muslims.

In the village, signboards proudly advertise Raavan DJ, Raavan Kirana Store, Raavan Hair Salon. Sonu, a student from the village exaggerates for the reel, as he says, "Some villagers had even named their children after him".

Dishondhi Saifi, 90, one of the village's oldest residents, says he has not seen a Ramlila in Bisrakh ever in his lifetime. "Some people tried to organise the Ramlila performance, followed by the effigy burning of Ravana here, but young men died in the village mysteriously. After that no one dared to celebrate Dasara," he says.

Saifi's claim is supported by Ajay Bhati, the last village head of Bisrakh before it became part of an urban civic body.

"Our village holds great religious importance. Despite Ravana abducting Sita, you cannot dispute his dedication for Shiva and his wisdom. I really feel that this place needs immediate attention from the government," Bhati says, urging both the Central and Uttar Pradesh governments to include Bisrakh in the Ramayana circuit.

The Ramayana circuit is a religious tourism initiative developed by the Government of India to connect and upgrade the infrastructure of key cities associated with Lord Rama's life.

"I have met the MP of our area (Mahesh Sharma), who was then an MoS (Minister of State) with Ministry of Culture and Tourism, but he never paid heed to our requests," he says, adding that the soil from Bisrakh was sent during the construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

Bisrakh is not alone in honouring Ravana. He is also worshipped in Kanpur, Jodhpur, and Kakinada, where people celebrate his intellect and devotion to Shiva.

In Mandsaur, Madhya Pradesh, locals even revere Ravana as their son-in-law, believing it to be the hometown of his wife Mandodari.

Beyond the mythology and folklore lies a complex web of caste politics. Dominating the demographic landscape of Bisrakh are the Gujjars, a prominent agricultural community in western Uttar Pradesh. Many villagers believe that Brahmin-dominated socio-religious institutions have intentionally suppressed the village's historic heritage. "We cannot deny that Brahmins claim all religious landmarks. Maybe this is the reason why a Gujjar-majority village never got its due," Bhati says. He supports Ramdas's temple as the original birthplace of Ravana.

A pitch for development

Not everyone in Bisrakh is interested in choosing a side. Suman Devi, 64, visits the Shiva temple to offer prayers. She lights a *diya* before the Shivling as the smoke from incense curls through the courtyard. She does not visit the other temple, but believes, "Both temples are ours."

Beyond the mythology and the rivalry, Bisrakh's immediate concerns are more practical. Neighbouring areas in Greater Noida have transformed with glass-fronted office buildings and sprawling high-rise apartments, while Bisrakh still looks like a village with broken roads and homes where people cannot afford paint.

"People may disagree over which temple marks Ravana's birthplace, but all of us want to put Bisrakh on the national pilgrimage map. The prospect of visitors brings the promise of better infrastructure and livelihoods, even if the scale of those benefits remains uncertain," says Devi.

As Raj looks for one more detail to make his video stand out, he returns to the question that has animated his visit.

"We all know he died on Vijaydashmi. But when was he born?" he asks the priests.

Ramdas draws a blank, waving away the question. Ashokanand offers a vague reference to an ancient divine timeline which, he says, has not been recorded.

The question remains unanswered.

As twilight settles, Raj finishes editing his short video, adds a trending soundtrack, and puts it in drafts for a final review. He pulls on the shoes he had left outside the older temple.

On one wall, a hand-painted sign displays a phone number, inviting people of any religion to call and discuss whatever is troubling them.

Raj saves the number on his phone, seeing another possible angle for future content. Then he leaves Bisrakh's dusty lanes behind.

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Eerie feeling: Vast areas of the Taramani MRTS station remain unused, making the station unsafe for women travellers.
B. VELANKANNI RAJ

When safety slips through a gaping hole

A recent fatal accident at the Thirumayilai MRTS railway station has once again highlighted the huge gaps in the maintenance and safety of MRTS stations in Chennai. With the Railway Board giving the go-ahead for handing over the service to CMRL, **R. Srikanth** does a deep dive and throws light on what needs to be done

When the Mass Rapid Transit System (MRTS) was proposed in the 1970s for Chennai, it was envisioned as the first mass public transport corridor to run on an elevated section in the country, years before the Metro Rail was even an idea in India. In anticipation of good patronage, humongous railway stations were built in one go, along with various passenger amenities such as escalators, lifts, and toilets.

Built in phases, the full MRTS service from Beach to Velachery was launched in November 2007. It was extended to St. Thomas Mount this year. The MRTS project, including the extension, had suffered delays of several decades.

Futuristic model

Envisioned as a futuristic model of mass public transport for easy and fast movement, the MRTS now stands as an example of poor maintenance, with passengers left with inadequate operational, civic, and security amenities. Particularly, on the security front, the MRTS has earned a bad reputation among women commuters after incidents of sexual assault and theft at a few stations, including Perungudi, Taramani, Thiruvanmiyur, and Indra Nagar.

The latest incident is the death of a 55-year-old woman at the Thirumayilai station. The woman, Vijaya, a resident of Pallikaranai, had travelled on an MRTS train along with her daughter and got down at Thirumayilai on October 8. Wanting to answer nature's call and finding the toilet shut, the woman tried to relieve herself by entering one of the many abandoned rooms on the platform. The room being pitch dark, she fell to her death through a huge gap on the floor. Her body was found only after four days; that too, because of the foul smell that drew the attention of officers of the Railway Protection Force (RPF) station housed on the ground floor.

Sprawling facilities

Having built sprawling railway stations in the MRTS section, Southern Railway realised that it required a large workforce and huge funds to maintain the amenities. So it drew up a security plan in 2013. It decided to close one of the two entrances at 14 elevated stations, including Perungudi, Taramani, Thiruvanmiyur, Indra Nagar, Kasturba Nagar, Kotturpuram, and Chintadripet. It also closed the access ways leading to these entry and exit points on the elevated platforms with grill gates and shut several rooms on the platforms built for commercial units and vendors that remained empty.

At the Thiruvanmiyur, Indra Nagar, and Kasturba Nagar stations, mezzanine floors, originally apportioned for commercial use, were closed with grill gates. Large, empty stations were soon being used by the homeless, especially at Perungudi, Taramani, Light House, and Thiruvallikeni.

R.K. Prabhu, a resident of Baby Nagar in Velachery, who has been using MRTS services since the full services were launched, complains that anti-social elements take over portions of the Perungudi station at night for consuming alcohol and playing cards. Though officials had shut down a portion of the station with concrete slabs, the wall has been broken open, and that space is still being used for drinking and dumping garbage.

> The vast, deserted ground-floor areas, multiple entry and exit points, and lack of a dedicated security detail have made these stations vulnerable to anti-social activities
>
> **C. SYLENDRA BABU**
> Former Director-General of Police

Regular commuters say that except at a few stations, toilets are not usable at all.

The Thiruvanmiyur station is another station that has a haunted feel after sunset. "Several rooms around the station have remained unoccupied for years. Liquor bottles, garbage, and other discarded items can be found here. Many youngsters also use the premises for drinking and smoking," said workers cleaning the station. Located right next to Chennai's Information Technology Corridor, the station is being used by a significant number of women commuters.

"Those working in Tidel Park, Ramanujam IT Park, and the IIT Madras Research Park get down here. After 7 p.m., this place looks unsafe. Some of us take the overbridge to the station. A security person should be stationed at this bridge," suggested S. Ragini, who works at a prominent IT company in Tidel Park. Other commuters from the IT park say there are stray dogs on the bridge at times and even on the station premises. While Southern Railway has posted RPF personnel to man the platforms of each railway station, the security officials face difficulties in patrolling the stations effectively.

Commercial exploration

Right to Information activist Dayanand Krishnan says it is a surprise that the vast spaces could not be commercially exploited by setting up offices, food plazas, and other business establishments. He said Southern Railway should have organised a stakeholder meeting with big commercial establishments before commencing the construction of such buildings. They would be ideal for housing supermarkets.

Mr. Krishnan says the quality of space plays an important role in attracting not only business establishments but also consumers. The MRTS stations are not "inviting places", he added. Additionally, the poor quality of construction is a deterrent for vendors – roofs leak even after light rain and rainwater stagnates on the platforms and the ground floors.

Former Director-General of Police C. Sylendra Babu says, "Chennai's massive elevated MRTS stations have become poorly policed spaces, allegedly sheltering petty criminals and drug-users, with incidents of alcohol and drug consumption and sexual harassment reported over the years. The vast, deserted ground-floor areas, multiple entry and exit points, and lack of a dedicated security detail have made these stations vulnerable to anti-social activities."

'GRP is understaffed'

He says the Government Railway Police (GRP), which is legally responsible for passenger safety, is understaffed, while the RPF primarily focuses on safeguarding railway property. He called for establishing GRP police stations at major MRTS stations, with the Railways and the State government sharing the cost equally.

Mr. Babu added that the Railways had failed to utilise the enormous spaces commercially for decades, leaving them neglected and vulnerable to misuse. As the MRTS readies itself for merging with the Chennai Metro Rail limited (CMRL) network, administratively, it is important that the issue of space utilisation is sorted out first.

Former Superintendent of Police (GRP) V. Pon Ram also says Chennai's MRTS network continues to face security challenges owing to inadequate police deployment, poorly lit stations, and vast, underutilised spaces.

Merger with CMRL

With commuters already losing direct train services from Velachery to Avadi, Tiruvallur, Arakkonam, and Gummidipoondi, after the fourth line between Egmore and Beach came into use, calls to hand over the MRTS to the CMRL, without delay, have been renewed. The Railway Board has given the go-ahead for handing over the service to CMRL.

Commuters say safety and security, besides amenities, in the CMRL network are far superior to those available at the MRTS stations. Prasanna Kumar, a frequent commuter on the MRTS system, says, "I hesitate to take an MRTS train late in the evening because I don't feel safe. It is equally challenging for women passengers. The access pathway to the station itself is not well lit. This is why I'm eagerly anticipating the CMRL's take-over of the MRTS. The CMRL stations have CCTVs and people don't have to be anxious about their safety."

While talk of the take-over has been in the pipeline for nearly 15 years now, the approval from the Railway Board came only this year and the signing of the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between the Tamil Nadu government and Southern Railway is expected to happen within two months. The transition period of the take-over will begin slowly, with the CMRL introducing security and housekeeping services initially. "Improving passenger-related issues and services will be the priority. Meanwhile, upgradation of station structures and systems will follow," an official said.

Purchasing new trains for this system may take a minimum of two years. In those two years, officials have said, the MRTS will see some significant changes in the maintenance of stations and their surroundings.

(With inputs from R. Sivaraman, Sunitha Sekar, and Sangeetha Kandavel.)

Southern Railway holds safety audit

In the week since the accidental death, the Chennai Division of Southern Railway undertook a comprehensive review of building safety plans at all the MRTS stations and took steps to prevent such accidents.

A senior official of the Chennai Division said all shaft openings identified at stations, including Thirumayilai and Perungudi, were closed. Vacant, unused rooms were locked and stickers were pasted, restricting access. Permanent closure of the restricted areas is in progress. Signage for commuters will come up soon. As for station security and passenger assistance, the official said a Station Master and support staff had been deployed at important stations, including Thirumayilai, Chepauk, and Velachery. Commercial staff members are being deployed for ticketing services and for assisting passengers at the stations, the official added.

Additional security personnel have been deployed at the stations and for patrolling trains, the official further said.

Run-down system

The MRTS, envisioned as a futuristic model of mass public transport, has become an example of poor maintenance and lack of passenger amenities

- A 55-year-old woman of Pallikaranai was killed after she fell through a huge gap in an abandoned room of the Thirumayilai station
- The MRTS has been notorious for poor commuter security
- Commuters have demanded that the MRTS be handed over to the Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL) at the earliest
- Southern Railway has started closing abandoned rooms. It is also taking steps to install grill gates at the unused entry and exit points to prevent unauthorised entry
- Additional RPF personnel have been deployed on MRTS trains to improve the security of women commuters

